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Molineux emerges the most expensive player

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INSIDE



Saudi strikes kill 14, say Houthis as they target Aden

ADEN
Yemen's Houthis said Saudi strikes killed more than a dozen people on Wednesday, while the Iran-aligned group targeted the airport in government stronghold Aden. The Houthis last month launched a lightning offensive in Yemen. » PAGE 14



'Privacy law does not infringe on press freedom'

NEW DELHI
Union Information Technology Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw on Wednesday said that the Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act did not infringe on press freedom, asserting that the Constitution guaranteed journalistic independence. » PAGE 4

Nirmala, Rahul spar over Tata leadership issue

NEW DELHI
Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman and Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi sparred on Wednesday over the leadership dispute at Tata Sons, with Mr. Gandhi questioning why Home Minister Amit Shah had hosted representatives of Tata Trusts and Tata Sons at his residence and accusing the government of "criminally destroying" the Tata Group. » PAGE 5

Second 'police encounter' in 12 hours in Bengal

KOLKATA
Hours after an accused in a rape and murder case was killed in a 'police encounter' in West Bengal's North 24 Parganas on Tuesday, another 40-year-old man accused in the murder of a BJP worker in Murshidabad was shot dead by the police, officials said on Wednesday. » PAGE 2

Railways to turn off charging points at night

HYDERABAD
Train passengers will no longer be allowed to keep their mobile phones charging overnight, with the Railway Board issuing strict instructions to all zonal railways to switch off charging points between 11 p.m. and 5 a.m. » PAGE 6

Can ECI punish voters for being lax, asks SC

- ECI in 'error' to force pre-existing voters whose names were deleted to apply as new electors: SC
- How can voters, included in 2003 rolls be purged over 'logical discrepancy' in 2026: Justice Bagchi
- ECI was compelling the voters to misrepresent themselves as new applicants, say petitioners

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Wednesday questioned the authority of Election Commission of India (ECI) to deprive citizens forever of their right to vote simply because they were lax in returning enumeration forms during the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, which has disenfranchised nearly 13 crore voters across the country.

"Let us say a voter was lax, inert, or did not respond, will that be a ground for you, the Election Commission of India, to forfeit his or her right to vote for ever? We will answer that," Justice Joymalya Bagchi, part of the Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, addressed the poll body.

The court said the ECI was in "error" to force pre-existing voters, whose names were deleted from the electoral roll, to apply as new voters under Form 6 of the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960.

Senior advocate Dama Seshadri Naidu, for the ECI, said the court's Bihar SIR judgment on May 27 had mentioned that the poll body had "residuary powers".

Justice Bagchi clarified that the Bihar judgment was not a "binding precedent" and asked why the ECI had not then used these residuary powers to reach out to voters who had not responded to enumeration forms.

"First and foremost, in Bihar SIR, the ECI had not undertaken 'logical discrepancy' as a category. We had permitted you in West Bengal as an interim arrangement... We have not finally adjudicated on the legality of 'logical discrepancy'," Justice Bagchi spoke for the Bench.



> Of the 1,45,10,299 electors in Delhi at the start of the SIR, 47,56,722 were marked as having not returned their enumeration forms
>
> **PRASHANT BHUSHAN**
> Counsel for petitioners



> Let us say a voter was lax or did not respond; will that be a ground for you [ECI]... to forfeit his or her right to vote for ever?
>
> **JUSTICE JOYMALYA BAGCHI**
> Supreme Court judge

Justice Bagchi asked how voters, included in the 2003 electoral roll after an intensive revision, could be purged in the name of 'logical discrepancy' in 2026.

'Grave offence'

Petitioners, activists Anjali Bhardwaj and Amrita Johri, represented by advocates Prashant Bhushan and Neha Rathi, submitted that the ECI was compelling voters to misrepresent themselves as new applicants, an offence which attracts imprisonment.

"You cannot touch these Forms. Form 6, Form 7 [for objection to proposed inclusion/deletion of names in the existing electoral roll], and Form 8 [application for shifting of residence] are cast in stone... You cannot make changes to them," Justice Bagchi said.

Mr. Bhushan said the ECI's approach to voters in the Delhi SIR was short-sighted.

"It ran like 'you were absent at your address when we came with the enumeration form, you are deleted from the electoral roll'. Of the 1,45,10,299 electors in Delhi at the start of the SIR, 47,56,722 were marked as having not returned their enumeration forms on account of being absent, shifted, dead or duplicate entries," he submitted.

The court asked the ECI whether a person who had temporarily moved out of Delhi for a month-long assignment, and missed filling out his enumeration form, would be considered as 'permanently shifted'.

"If a voter has moved residence from Vasant Kunj to Sarita Vihar, is it not enough for him to simply disclose his voter details to continue in the electoral roll," Chief Justice Kant asked the ECI.

'Structural incongruity'

Justice Bagchi said the requirement for voters to apply through Form 6 and Form 7 would arise only after the final voter list was published, and not during the draft stage.

"Why don't you allow the deleted voters to continue to submit their enumeration forms? There is a structural incongruity between your manner of conduct of SIR and the Form 6 and 7 regime. Why should voters be asked to apply with Form 6, they can just put in their enumeration forms belatedly... Keep it open-ended. Don't stick to any timelines for voters," Justice Bagchi addressed the ECI.

Chief Justice Kant asked why the ECI had to rush the SIR in Delhi, with no elections around. The last date for filing claims and objections for inclusion/deletions in the Delhi electoral roll is October 30.

Mr. Naidu said voters were never 'deleted' as they could return to the electoral roll at any time before the filing of nominations for an election.

SIR: SERIOUS QUESTIONS
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64.5 lakh electors 'missing' in final Karnataka rolls

Around 64.5 lakh electors are potentially missing from the final electoral rolls of Karnataka released after the special intensive revision on Tuesday, as per calculations based on Elector-to-Population ratio of 66.11, released by the office of the Chief Electoral Officer. » PAGE 9

Tragic error



Deadly track: The derailed coaches of two high-speed trains that collided near Toledo in Spain on Wednesday. At least 68 people were killed and 58 others injured in the country's second deadly rail collision this year. REUTERS (REPORT: PAGE 14)

IIP growth in Sept. slows to 6.7%, lowest in four months

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

Growth in industrial production slowed to a four-month low of 6.7% in September, with nearly every sector slowing as compared with the previous month, the latest official data show.

Data on the Index of Industrial Production (IIP), released on Wednesday, show that growth in 10 out of the 11 sectors covered was slower in September than it was in August. The IIP had grown 7.8% in August 2026 as per the revised data.

FULL REPORT ON
» PAGE 12



Caught in the storm: An uprooted tree lies on top of a car in Visakhapatnam as Cyclone Arnab hit A.P. on Wednesday. K.R. DEEPAK

Heavy rain claims five lives as Cyclone Arnab makes landfall in A.P.

Nellore Sravani
VIJAYAWADA

Five people were killed in rain-related incidents as Cyclone Arnab battered north Andhra Pradesh with extremely heavy rain and winds gusting up to 150 km per hour as it made landfall on Wednesday morning. More than 1,000 trees were uprooted and crops across 80,500 hectares were affected, official reports said.

More than 42 weather stations across the northern districts of Visakhapatnam, Vizianagaram, and Anakapalli recorded over 200 mm of rainfall in a 24-hour period ending on Wednesday morning. Garividi of Vizianagaram recorded the highest of 260 mm. Another 271 stations reported at least 100 mm during the period.

The landfall process of the 'very severe cyclonic storm' continued till 8 a.m., after which the system weakened into a 'severe cyclonic storm'.

'Odisha prepared'

Neighbouring Odisha, where the cyclonic system is expected to bring heavy rainfall until Thursday morning, said it is prepared to deal with any eventuality. Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi said 17 districts of Odisha had been affected by heavy rainfall triggered by Cyclone Arnab.

In its national bulletin issued at 8.30 p.m., the India Meteorological Department said the severe cyclonic storm had weakened into a cyclonic storm. It is likely to become a deep depression by midnight and move north-northwestwards in the next 24 hours before gradually weakening, it said.

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu, who briefed Union Home Minister Amit Shah on the damages caused by the cyclone, said crops, mainly paddy, across more than 70,000 hectares have been inundated, and horticultural crops spread over 10,500 hectares have also been affected.

He announced relief measures for those affected, including fishermen, farmers, handloom households, people in relief camps, etc.

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CENTRAL AID SOUGHT
» PAGE 3

Netanyahu leads in polls but falls short of majority

Agence France-Presse
JERUSALEM

Results from Israel's hard-fought election pointed on Wednesday to no clear winner as a leader of the Arab minority appealed to a hesitant Opposition to join forces to end the divisive reign of Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu.

With more than three quarters of the vote counted, Mr. Netanyahu's right-wing bloc was slightly ahead but short of a majority in Tuesday's election, the first since the Hamas attack on October 7, 2023, which has led Israel to wage war on Gaza and across the region.

Both Mr. Netanyahu, Israel's longest-serving Prime Minister who is allied with far-right and ultra-Orthodox Jewish parties, and Gadi Eisenkot, a former military chief leading a broad Opposition bloc, vowed that they would seek to form the next government.



Mixed verdict: Supporters of Israeli PM Benjamin Netanyahu celebrate in Jerusalem on Wednesday. AP

But neither looks set to reach the 61-seat threshold for a majority. With 85% of ballots counted, Mr. Netanyahu's bloc had 53 of the 120 seats in Parliament and Mr. Eisenkot's opposition had 48. The final results could still change but one place of clear gains was among Israeli Arab lists which were set to jump to 19 seats.

The Arab take

Voters from the Arab community, descendants of Palestinians who stayed after Israel's creation and who make up around 20% of the population, have been enraged by the Netanyahu government's ultra-nationalist Jewish vision for the country and the Palestinian territories.

Yousef Jabareen, head of the leftist Arab-majority Joint List, said the Israeli public had voted for new leadership, and "anyone who wants to offer a substantive and genuine alternative to Netanyahu's blood-soaked government will have to talk to us".

"It's either the continuation of racism, the continuation of exclusion and the continuation of supremacy, or a genuine Jewish-Arab partnership," he said.

Mr. Eisenkot has resisted allying with Arab parties. Mr. Netanyahu during the campaign relentlessly attacked the Opposition by saying it would put Arabs in power, running on the slogan: "Either the Right or Palestine."

Yair Golan, the head of Israel's main left-wing party and a member of Mr. Eisenkot's camp, became the first member of the Opposition camp to call for an alliance with Arab parties.

But Mr. Eisenkot's camp also includes right-wingers who share many of Mr. Netanyahu's hawkish views and have rejected working with Arab lawmakers.

A lack of a clear majority for either camp could mean weeks spent trying to cobble together coalitions, with possible new elections on the horizon if negotiations fail.

HIGH ARAB TURNOUT
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INBRIEF



Out on parole, Asaram fails to return to Jodhpur jail on time

A fresh legal trouble awaited Asaram in Jodhpur after he reported to the central jail nearly 17 hours after the deadline set for his return from medical parole. The Ratanada police registered a case against the convicted godman under the Prisons Act on Tuesday night for failing to surrender within the stipulated time, even as the jail authorities refused to admit him due to the late hour. Asaram, who is serving a sentence in a rape cas, finally surrendered at Jodhpur Central Jail around 10 a.m. on Wednesday after spending the night at Arogyam Hospital in Bhagat Ki Kothi. The 20-day parole granted to him by the Rajasthan High Court on October 6 ended on October 27. PTI

Centre opposes Rajoana's plea against death sentence in SC

The Centre on Wednesday opposed in the Supreme Court a plea filed by Balwant Singh Rajoana seeking commutation of his death sentence to life term in the 1995 assassination of then Punjab Chief Minister Beant Singh. Rajoana, who has been incarcerated for more than 29 years, including on death row for over 15 years, has sought commutation of his death sentence due to the delay in deciding his mercy plea. "We will argue this matter. I don't think such a prayer can be granted," Additional Solicitor General K.M. Nataraj, told a Bench of Justices Vikram Nath, Sandeep Mehta and Aparesh Kumar Singh. PTI

Second 'police encounter' in 12 hours: accused in Bengal BJP worker's murder killed

BJP Minister pens poem on 'encounter'; hours after a rape and murder accused was gunned down, police shot down key accused in the August 28 murder in Murshidabad under similar circumstances

Senjuti Sengupta
KOLKATA

Hours after an accused in a rape and murder case was killed in a 'police encounter' in West Bengal's North 24 Parganas district on Tuesday, another 40-year-old man accused in the murder of a Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) worker in Murshidabad in August was shot dead by the police, officials said on Wednesday.

Samaul Sheikh, who was a key accused in the murder of BJP worker Sujit Mondal on August 28, was shot dead in an alleged gunfight with police in Murshidabad at 3 p.m. on Tuesday. Around 12 hours before, Prahlad Das, an accused in the alleged rape and murder of a minor girl in Gaighata, North 24 Parganas, was killed under similar circumstances around 3.30 a.m.

According to the police, the accused, Samaul Sheikh, was taken to Dhulian under Murshidabad's Samserganj police station to reconstruct the crime scene. "Prima facie, officials from the Crime Investigation Department (CID) brought him to the spot for investigation. However, he allegedly snatched the service weapon of an officer and tried to flee the spot. He died in retaliatory firing during the incident," said the Jangipur Superintendent of Police Surinder Singh. The officer added that police immediately reached the spot upon receiving information. The accused was rushed to a hospital in Anupnagar, where he was declared dead. Later, the body was sent to the subdivisional hospital for an autopsy. CID officials did not comment on the "encounter".



Minister Agnimitra Paul wrote a poem, 'Encounter', to underline her message on crime and safety amid Opposition outrage over the two killings in separate 'police encounters' in West Bengal. FILE PHOTO

On August 28, a bidi worker-cum-local BJP worker, Sujit Mondal, 36, went missing, and a ransom call was made to his house. Parts of his dismembered body were later found. Three persons, including Samaul Sheikh, Tazkira Bibi, and Johni Skheikh, were arrested in connection with the incident, which the police suspect involves a dispute over financial dealings.

Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari had handed over the case to the CID and alleged non-cooperation by the local police when the family members of the victim approached the police and sought security.

Meanwhile, the mother of the rape-murder accused on Wednesday demanded "justice" for her son even as State Minister Agnimitra Paul turned to poetry to underline her message on crime and safety amid public outrage over the two killings in separate "police encounters". Titled 'Encounter', the Bengali poem calls for "firmness against crime".

The poem, however, does not directly refer to either case or name the accused. BJP State president Samik Bhattacharya earlier said, "In many situations, police may have to open fire, especially when they are attacked."

Opposition parties, including the Mamata All India Trinamool Congress and the Communist Party of India (Marxist), have condemned the incidents. "Instead of relying on the rule of law, people are taking the law into their own hands," said CPI(M) State secretary Mohammad Salim.

(With inputs from PTI)

Mann, all Punjab MLAs are invited to visit Pakistan

Pakistan Punjab Minister extended the invitation after Punjab CM expressed desire to attend an international Punjabi conference in Lahore

The Hindu Bureau
CHANDIGARH

Days after Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann expressed his desire to attend an international Punjabi conference in Lahore, Pakistan Punjab Minister for Minority Affairs and Chairman of the Pakistan Sikh Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee, Ramesh Singh Arora, has extended an invitation to Mr. Mann and all legislators of the Punjab Assembly to visit Pakistan.

"Bhagwant Singh Mann Sahib, as the Minister for Minority Affairs, as the president of the Pakistan Sikh Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee and as a Pakistani citizen, we invite you. The Chief Minister of Punjab, Maryam Nawaz, invites you," Mr. Arora said.

Tour of shrines

Speaking in the Punjab Assembly in Lahore, he said, "We invite the Punjab Assembly of India to come, and Pakistan will not only arrange your pilgrimage to Kartarpur Sahib, but we will also take you to the sacred places of other faiths present here."

The invitation follows Mr. Mann's statement during the recently concluded session of the Punjab Assembly that he wished to accept the invitation from the organisers of the Lahore International Punjabi Conference scheduled to be held in Lahore from November 27 to 29 and that he would also want to visit Sikh shrines in Pakistan.

Long-pending demand

Sikh devotees, Sikh organisations, and political parties have been demanding the reopening of the Kartarpur Corridor, which connects Dera Baba Nanak in India to Darbar Sahib gurdwara in Pakistan.

It was in Kartarpur Sahib, now in Pakistan, where Sikhism's founder Guru Nanak Dev had spent the last 18 years of his life.

The corridor has remained shut since May 7, 2025, after tensions escalated between India and Pakistan following the Pahalgam terror attack.

All 17 escapees from district jail in Tamil Nadu apprehended in less than 40 hours, say police

The Hindu Bureau
THENI

With the arrest of all 17 remand prisoners who escaped from the Theni district jail in Tamil Nadu, the combing operation concluded successfully on Wednesday.

On Monday night, the remand prisoners claimed that one of the inmates suffered epileptic seizures and required assistance. When a jail warder opened the cell, they overpowered him and escaped.

Subsequently, the 17 of them moved out in small groups and reached the main gate, where again, they assaulted the personnel. After taking the keys forcibly, they made their escape.

Inspector-General of Police (South Zone) Vijayendra Bidari formed 17 special teams with SPs – Pradeep Gowtham (Theni) and N Jayakumar (Dindigul) – as coordinators. The police also fanned out to neighbouring Keralam as well in search of the escapees.



Seventeen teams had been formed and the SPs of Theni and Dindigul were in charge of the search operation. G. KARTHIKEYAN

The first break came within a few hours on Tuesday, when the teams spotted one of the prisoners early morning. In the next few hours, they secured another four persons. Later, in the evening, the teams used three high definition drones and caught eight more accused. On Wednesday, two other prisoners were nabbed, which took the total to 15.

From 2 p.m. onwards, the teams zeroed in on the last two persons and nabbed them somewhere between Cumbum and Gudalur.

In less than 40 hours, the entire combing operation was successfully carried out and police said that the search had ended.

ED attaches assets of Azam Khan's Jauhar varsity in PMLA case

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Wednesday provisionally attached land and buildings of Mohammad Ali Jauhar University in Uttar Pradesh's Rampur in connection with a a money-laundering case against the Maulana Mohammad Ali Jauhar Trust, its founder and Samajwadi Party leader Azam Khan and others.

'Land forcibly taken'

The ED initiated an investigation under under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002, on the basis of 26 FIRs registered at the Azim Nagar police station in Rampur under various sections of IPC, alleging that agricultural land of farmers was forcibly taken over for the university.

"As per the inquiry report of the district administration, Rampur, 45 plots of enemy property measuring about 34 acres at village Singhankhera were also illegally occupied by Azam Khan for the university even after the lease for this land to the trust had been cancelled by the custodian. The possession of this land has been taken back by the office of the Custodian of Enemy Property for India under the Ministry of Home Affairs through the district administration, Rampur," an ED official said.

The probe agency added that during investigation, it found that funds meant for public works were diverted to the university and government works were executed on the private campus, and funds from contractors who had been allotted government contracts, were routed back to the trust as donations.

Furniture thrown, proceedings disrupted as lawyers' protest against HC judge turns chaotic

Ishita Mishra
NEW DELHI

Chaos erupted in one of the courtrooms at the Allahabad High Court on Wednesday as protests against a judge escalated, with advocates allegedly throwing furniture towards the dais. The conduct of the lawyers prompted the court to consider disciplinary and contempt proceedings against those involved.

A Bench of Justice Arun Kumar Singh Deshwal was hearing a bail application when slogans and commotion from the adjoining corridor interrupted the proceedings.

After being informed that the lawyers were protesting over the alleged mistreatment of their colleague, the judge expressed concern over the disruption caused to litigants and the functioning of the court. The protest reportedly stemmed from allegations that a lawyer had been mistreated by Justice Ajay Bhanot.



The lawyers were protesting over the alleged mistreatment of their colleague by Justice Ajay Bhanot of the Allahabad HC. VIDEO GRAB

Terming the conduct of the lawyers as "wholly unjustified" and "contemptuous", the Bench observed that litigants approach the court seeking judicial relief and should not suffer because of disagreements between lawyers and a particular judge.

"Registrar (Protocol) is directed to get the CCTV footage of camera installed outside of Court No.66, identify the advocates involved in the incident and submit a report to this court by next date of listing. After identifying the advocates, the matter may be referred to the Bar Council of U.P. for initiation of disciplinary proceedings as well as initiation of contempt proceedings against them," Justice Deshwal ordered.

Unmarried rural youth in Maharashtra seek govt. help in getting brides

Radheshyam Jadhav
PUNE

It is not the inflation, unemployment, deletion of names from the voters' list or corruption that is simmering in rural Maharashtra youth who are gearing up for an agitation. Unlike other Gen Z across India, these youth have an unusual demand – get us brides to marry.

"We are planning not only a Statewide but a nationwide network of boys who are not getting brides to marry and plan a massive agitation," Kisan Nanaware, a 28-year-old youth from Solapur, told *The Hindu*.

Mr. Nanaware came into the limelight after he held a dharna demanding bride at the District Collector's office in September. He fears he may suffer the same fate as thousands of men in rural Solapur in western Maharashtra, pointing out that the issue stretches far beyond men in their early 30s, with some in their 40s and 50s having given up hope of finding a partner.

Youth such as Mr. Nanaware argue that the State must issue an official resolution detailing steps to assist those who are unmarried. Their core demands include setting up an all-religion marriage registration bureau under the Social Welfare Department, providing direct financial assistance, creating steady rural employment, and guaranteeing remunerative prices for farm produce. He warns that if authorities fail to act, the movement could take an aggressive turn.

The politicians who have been facing various kinds of agitations are now facing heat of the unmarried youth.



Kisan Nanaware (28), who held a dharna seeking a bride last month, now plans to build a network of unmarried rural youth to protest against State apathy to their plight. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

What was supposed to be a standard campaign stop for the Maharashtra Legislative Council elections in Ashti, Beed district (Marathwada region), took a dramatic turn when an agitated young man seized the microphone from local organisers and voiced an issue cutting across rural Maharashtra for which he wanted an immediate answer from the leaders. "Keep aside all other problems and look at our condition," he demanded, speaking to a crowd of ruling alliance leaders gathered for the Graduates' and Teachers' constituency elections held on October 23. "Many of us, including me, have crossed 30 or 32 and still we are not getting brides. Solve this problem first!"

Leaders of the BJP-led ruling coalition were not entirely surprised by the outburst. Behind the scenes, politicians have been monitoring simmering anger among rural men who find themselves systematically rejected by prospective brides and their families due to falling farm incomes, lack of steady employment, and a skewed gender ratio.

Maharashtra recorded a sex ratio of 899 girls per 1,000 boys during the 2022-24 period, marginally improving from 896 girls in 2012-14 but well below the national average of 918 girls, according to the latest Sample Registration System Statistical Report.

Bleak prospects

From Ministers to leaders across party lines, veteran leader Sharad Pawar to local gram panchayat sarpanches, young boys are now raising one simple question, "What about our marriage?" No one has answer to this.

"If not leaders, who is going to answer? At least they must solve one problem and this is the pressing one," said 32-year-old Avinash Shende from Yavatmal in Vidarbha region. Along with farming, he is working on a contract with a private cleaning agency and has not completed his graduation. He added that like him other youth in the region are now galvanising support to take up this issue at the State level. He says the movement would start from gram sabhas in villages.

The ruling BJP-led alliance in the State is worried as the frustration on the ground is quickly turning into organised agitation. The agitated youth have demanded that if the State government is unable to help them secure brides or improve their financial standing through stable jobs and fair agricultural prices, it must introduce a monthly pension scheme for unmarried men.

'Difficult challenge'

"For a government already dealing with widespread agitations over inflation, unemployment, and the ongoing Election Commission of India's SIR drive, this demographic crisis presents a difficult challenge. Unlike economic policy or infrastructure projects, resolving a social shortage of brides is not something easily fixed by government decree. But then, the youth are not in a mood to listen," said a local BJP leader in Sangli district who requested anonymity.

BMC to launch pre-Deepavali drive to curb pollution

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

The Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) will undertake a nine-day special cleanliness and dust mitigation drive across Mumbai from October 29 to November 6, focusing on major arterial roads and dust-prone stretches to curb air pollution and improve the city's air quality ahead of Deepavali.

The drive, initiated on the directions of Municipal Commissioner Ashwini Bhide, will cover major roads, including the Jogeshwari-Vikhroli Link Road, Santacruz-Chembur Link Road and Bandra-Kurla Complex Connector.

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Naidu seeks Central aid for cyclone damage

Chief Minister appeals for continued NDRF support and an early despatch of Central team to assess damage to crops, houses, roads and power infrastructure; paddy and other crops spread across over 80,000 hectares have been damaged; Godavari delta coast bears the brunt of cyclone

The Hindu Bureau
VIJAYAWADA

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu has sought the Centre's assistance in dealing with the impact of the very severe cyclonic storm, Arnab, which crossed the Andhra Pradesh and Yanam coasts on Wednesday morning, causing extensive damage to crops, houses, roads and power infrastructure in several coastal districts.

Mr. Naidu spoke to Union Home Minister Amit Shah over the phone.

In a letter dated October 28, the Chief Minister requested continued support from the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) and other Central agencies. He also sought the early deputation of a Central team to assess the damage, once the State government submits its detailed assessment.

More than 28,000 people had been evacuated from vulnerable locations and shifted to relief shelters.



Picking up the pieces: Fishermen try to salvage nets and boats at Odalarevu village in Konaseema district of Andhra Pradesh on Wednesday. V. RAJU

180 houses damaged

The preliminary assessment put the number of damaged houses at around 180, with most of the reported damage concentrated in Konaseema district.

Strong winds uprooted more than 220 trees along the State roads alone. Close to 1,000 trees got uprooted in Visakhapatnam. Damage to road surfaces was also reported at a few coastal locations, while power supply was disrupted in parts of the affected districts.

Restoration teams were working to clear roads, repair damaged infrastructure and restore electricity.

The extent of the damage was still being assessed, and the figures were expected to be revised as field reports became available.

Heavy rainfall and inundation caused damage to agriculture and horticulture crops. Paddy and other crops spread across about 70,900 hectares were reported to have been inundated or damaged. Horticulture crops covering another 10,450 hectares were also affected, taking the preliminary estimate of the total affected agricultural and horticultural area to about 81,350 hectares.

The damage was concentrated along the Godavari delta coast, particularly in Konaseema, Kakinada, East Godavari and West Godavari districts. Krishna and Anakapalli districts were also affected. Visakhapatnam resembled a war-torn zone after the rain and gusty winds brought down trees, poles, and transformers.

Showers in Telangana

Under the impact of Arnab, various parts of Telangana received showers on Wednesday. Several areas in Khammam, Mulugu, Suryapet and Bhadradri Kothagudem received between 10 mm and 21.3 mm of rainfall till early afternoon.

Nalgonda, Mahabubabad, Warangal and Jayashankar Bhuplapally received up to 10 mm rain.

Chennai Police issue Look Out Circular against granite baron's daughter

We believe she is aware of certain suspicious money transactions done to help her father Veeramani evade legal action: police

S. Vijay Kumar
CHENNAI

The Greater Chennai Police (GCP) have issued a Look Out Circular (LOC) against Archana Veeramani, daughter of Gem Granites owner R. Veeramani, restraining her from travelling abroad, police sources said on Tuesday.

Archana, who was taken into custody by the Special Investigation Team (SIT) at the Chennai International Airport after she boarded a flight to Singapore on October 23, was questioned and allowed to leave after she complained of illness.

"We believe she is aware of certain suspicious money transactions done to help her father evade legal action," a police officer said, explaining the reason for the issuance of the LOC.

Eight cases

Veeramani, his associate Shanthi, and others face eight cases under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act.

A couple of days ago, the police issued LOCs against five persons, including Archana, to prevent them from escaping to a foreign country. The SIT said the individuals could be in possession of evidence relating to the POCSO Act cases.

Efforts were still being made to trace Prakash Kanniah, who has absconded and is believed to be staying in the United Kingdom, the sources said.

Meanwhile, the police have frozen the bank accounts of Veeramani's business establishments. They had already frozen the bank accounts of Prakash Kanniah and a couple of others.

"We have already come across a few suspicious transactions. Freezing the bank accounts is to prevent the use of money to influence or intimidate the witnesses or tamper with the evidence," said an officer.

The SIT was in the process of filing a charge sheet in the designated court for POCSO Act cases.

"We will seek maximum punishment for the accused persons," the officer said.

In almost all the cases booked under the POCSO Act involving victims who were then minors, the accused offered gifts, chocolates, and mobile phones to sexually exploit them.

The SIT will soon question Veeramani, his associate Shanti, and her husband Mahendra Simhan by confronting them with fresh evidence seized in the case.

Will identify lapses, says Karnataka Cong. after MLC poll loss

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

The Karnataka Congress will conduct a comprehensive review of its organisational shortcomings, said State Pradesh Congress Committee president B.K. Hariprasad, after losing all four Legislative Council constituencies for graduates and teachers that went to the polls on October 23.

In a post on X, Mr. Hariprasad said the Congress had been confident of winning all four seats, but the results went against its expectations. The party had accepted the verdict and would use it as an opportunity for introspection, he said.

The BJP-Janata Dal (Secular) alliance won the Bengaluru and North East Teachers' constituencies as well as the Karnataka South East and Karnataka West Graduates' seats.

The Congress earlier held one of the four seats.



B.K. Hariprasad

The results strip the Congress of its majority in the Upper House. With the fresh mandate, the Congress has 37 members in the 75-member Upper House – one seat down.

The JD(S) has increased its tally from six to seven while the BJP, after retaining all the three seats, has steadied its strength at 24.

The Congress, however, has an opportunity to increase its tally since five seats nominated by the government are yet to be filled.

'Enlightened electorate'

Describing graduates and teachers as an "enlightened segment of the electorate", Mr. Hariprasad said the party would examine why it had failed to win their confidence and identify shortcomings in understanding their expectations, communicating its positions and maintaining sustained engagement with them.

The review would also examine the State government's response to concerns raised by teachers and graduates, including job insecurity, challenges in the education system and issues affecting their professional interests, the PCC president said.

Mr. Hariprasad said the party would assess whether its government's welfare programmes and the Congress's political positions had been effectively communicated to voters. "The result heightens our responsibility to shape our organisational functioning, public outreach and political strategies more effectively," he said.

INBRIEF



Bengaluru Metro gears up to open new elevated corridor

Bangalore Metro Rail Corporation Limited (BMRCL) has obtained the much-awaited safety clearance for the elevated portion of the Metro Pink Line between Kalena Agrahara and Tavarekere, Bengaluru Development Minister Krishna Byre Gowda said on Wednesday. He said BMRCL will launch the service as soon as the Centre gives a date for inauguration. The Pink Line is a 21.25 km north-south corridor from Kalena Agrahara to Nagawara. The 7.5-km elevated corridor has six stations. PTI

Nod for Vigilance probe into KIIFB's Kannur land deal

The Keralam Cabinet on Wednesday decided to recommend a Vigilance probe into alleged lapses in the acquisition of land in Kannur district by the Kerala Infrastructure Investment Fund Board (KIIFB). The decision follows a finding by an expert committee that the land acquisition by the KIIFB was skewed. The committee, as part of its scrutiny of KIIFB operations based on a government decision, had questioned the Board's decision to acquire land in Kannur and Palakkad districts.

Man sentenced to 20-year RI for sexually assaulting minor

A 25-year-old man was sentenced to 20 years of rigorous imprisonment by the L.B. Nagar fast-track court in Telangana on Wednesday for sexually abusing a minor girl. According to the prosecution case, the minor girl's mother, who is the complainant, was in a live-in relationship with Jarpula Ganesh. The minor girl, who was also living with them, was repeatedly sexually abused by Ganesh. On October 29, 2024, Ganesh allegedly took the complainant and her daughter to an isolated location and attempted to sexually assault the minor. He fled after the mother raised an alarm, the police said.

3 fishermen in Gokarna dead after inhaling toxic gas

Press Trust of India
KARWAR

Three fishermen were killed and two were hospitalised after inhaling toxic gas while clearing decomposed fish waste from a boat at the Tadadi harbour near Gokarna in Karnataka's Uttara Kannada district on Tuesday.

A 64-year-old fisherman is in a critical condition. According to the police, they were cleaning the storage compartment of the boat when they collapsed. Fisheries Minister K.S. Basavanthappa visited the bereaved families and handed over cheques for ₹10 lakh each to the kin of the deceased.

Come rain or shine



Members of the National Rural Livelihoods Mission's Sanjeevini Okkoota stage a protest at the Freedom Park in Bengaluru on Wednesday. They have demanded that their honorarium be credited directly to their bank accounts. SUDHAKARA JAIN

Maritime Bill passed in Keralam; Opposition walks out

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Keralam Assembly on Wednesday passed the Keralam Maritime Board (Amendment) Bill, 2026, despite a walkout by the Opposition Left Democratic Front.

The Bill provides for restructuring the State Maritime Board, setting up a Maritime Land Bank and an enforcement wing, and revising contracts for 17 port projects. It will become law after receiving the Governor's assent.

Opposing the Bill, Leader of the Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan said it dealt a blow to the right to life and to livelihood of coastal people guaranteed by the Constitution. The provision to set up a land bank – comprising land under the control of the State – for townships and other projects would lead to their eviction from the land where they parked boats, dried nets, and repaired vessels.

'Corporate takeover'

Mr. Vijayan alleged that constructions along the coast and private tourism projects that went against coastal protection laws would destroy the marine ecosystem. The Bill would hand over the State's coast to corporate mafia, he said, before walking out.

In his reply, Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan refuted the Opposition allegations that all land under the control of the State government would be transferred to the board. The Bill specified that the land within port limits would come under the land bank, he said.

(With PTI inputs)

Kochi police chief shifted amid probe into car crash involving judge's minor son

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

Amid widespread outrage over the Cheranalloor car crash case, the Keralam government removed S. Kaliraj Mahesh Kumar as the District Police Chief (Kochi City) on Wednesday.

A 55-year-old man was killed at Cheranalloor in Kochi after he was mowed down by a luxury car allegedly driven by the 17-year-old son of an additional judge on October 25. After the incident, the police were accused of mishandling the case.

Mr. Kumar is likely to be replaced by R. Nishanthini, who is at present serving as IGP (South Zone). The move comes a day after the government suspended four police officers attached to the Cheranalloor police station based on a report submitted by ADGP P. Vijayan.

Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala is reportedly, unhappy with the manner in which the City Police handled the case, particularly the invocation of relatively minor charges against the accused teenager. He had also conceded in the Assembly the lapses on the part of the police in handling the case.

Meanwhile, the police carried out an overnight search operation at the judge's apartment in Aluva, which continued till Wednesday morning.

Judge questioned

The police on Wednesday questioned the judge who was also booked in the case with his 17-year-old son. The questioning went on till late in the evening.

Though the teenager was booked under Section 105 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita for culpable homicide not amounting to murder and taken into custody, he was subsequently granted bail by the Juvenile Justice Board.

Former KPSC official held; chief questioned

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Crime Branch investigating the alleged irregularities in an examination conducted by the Kerala Public Service Commission (PSC) arrested a former deputy secretary, P. Satheesh, in connection with the case on Wednesday.

Mr. Satheesh, who was recently named an accused in the case pertaining to a Kerala State Planning Board examination, was apprehended from his home in Kozhikode. This is the first arrest in the case.

The accused, who had retired from service last year, was reportedly in charge of the PSC's examination wing and responsible for the evaluation process of the controversial examination.

SIT probe

The Special Investigation Team (SIT) under the Crime Branch had recently booked the retired official, along with another senior PSC functionary, R. Hari, additional secretary, in the case.

Kerala PSC chairperson M.R. Baiju was questioned by the SIT led by S. Ajeetha Begum. Mr. Baiju reported at the Crime Branch headquarters, adjacent to the State Police headquarters, with police escort around 2 p.m. The official, whose questioning lasted over five hours, left the premises around 8 p.m.

BJP MP seeks reopening of Kartarpur corridor

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

Rajya Sabha member Vikramjit Singh Sahney on Wednesday said that he has urged the Union government to reopen the Kartarpur corridor ahead of Guru Nanak Jayanti next month.

The corridor, inaugurated in 2019, links two important Sikh shrines—Dera Baba Nanak in Punjab's Gurdaspur district and Gurudwara Darbar Sahib in Kartarpur, Pakistan.

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Wednesday inaugurated a painting exhibition, titled after the Prime Minister's radio programme *Mann Ki Baat*, to mark 25 years of Narendra Modi's public life. The exhibition has been organised by the World Punjabi Organisation, of which Mr. Sahney is international president.

Mr. Sahney is among six Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) MPs who recently switched to the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP).

"The corridor was closed after the Pahalgam terror attack. We have requested the Minister to reopen it ahead of Guru Nanak Jayanti next month, but it is the government's call," Mr. Sahney said.

Link between Japan and Northeast to be strengthened: govt.

Kallol Bhattacherjee
NEW DELHI


Randhir Jaiswal

India has a "very strong partnership" with Japan, and bilateral projects involving the northeastern States will be "further strengthened", Randhir Jaiswal, official spokesperson of the External Affairs Ministry, said on Wednesday.

The comments came hours after Bangladesh Prime Minister Tarique Rahman and his Japanese counterpart, Sanae Takaichi, agreed to "enhance connectivity in the region", and signed agreements that will pave the way for additional Japanese assistance to Bangladesh's Matarbari deep sea port, which will connect with northeast India.

"We have very strong partnership with Japan. We also have several initiatives involving northeast [India] and Japan, and we would like to further strengthen these linkages," Mr. Jaiswal said. The Japanese language was being taught to the working population in the northeastern States as part of these initiatives, he added.

"It will also give a boost to the Japan-India economic partnership here in India as well," Mr. Jaiswal said. Northeastern States were also receiving assistance from Japan as part of that larger bilateral framework, he said.

Japan and Bangladesh have signed multiple agreements during Mr. Rahman's ongoing visit to Tokyo, which includes further development of the industrial hub centred around the Matarbari deep sea port. Mr. Rahman met Ms. Takaichi and representatives of leading business houses during the visit.

Sources from Japan maintain they envisage the linking of the Matarbari port with India's northeast to ensure optimal usage of the industrial hub and the first deep sea port in Bangladesh, which currently depends on ports in Malaysia and Singapore for handling big vessels.

India raises concern over U.S. support for Pakistan's F-16 jets

Rajnath Singh discusses cross-border terrorism with Hegseth; Secretary of War reaffirms support to combat issue; they review defence relations

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI


Defence Minister Rajnath Singh during a meeting with United States Secretary of War Pete Hegseth on Wednesday. PTI

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Wednesday raised India's concerns over Washington's support package for Pakistan's F-16 fighter aircraft with U.S. Secretary of War Pete Hegseth during a bilateral meeting on the sidelines of the ASEAN Defence Ministers' Meeting-Plus (ADMM-Plus) in Cebu, Philippines.

The two leaders also discussed the threat of cross-border terrorism, with Mr. Hegseth reaffirming Washington's support to India in combating the menace.

According to the Ministry of Defence, the meeting provided an opportunity to review progress under the India-U.S. Major Defence Partnership, including the implementation of foundational security agreements and avenues to enhance operational readiness, technology sharing and defence industrial integration.

Mr. Singh emphasised the need for a zero-tolerance approach towards countries that support, train or finance terrorist organisations. He expressed appreciation for the consistent support extended by the U.S. in India's fight against cross-border terrorism.

Mr. Singh also conveyed to Mr. Hegseth that any transfer of advanced military technology to Pakistan could ultimately result in the technology reaching a third country, raising concerns over its wider proliferation and implications for regional security.

The two Ministers also reviewed the ten-year India-U.S. Defence Framework and discussed strengthening maritime security cooperation, military-to-military exchanges and resilient defence supply chains.

Separately, Mr. Singh held talks with Japanese Defence Minister Shinjiro Koizumi, reviewing progress in bilateral defence cooperation since their meeting in August. The discussions explored joint development in naval shipbuilding and design.

DPDP Act does not infringe on press freedom: Vaishnaw

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI


Ashwini Vaishnaw

Union Information Technology Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw on Wednesday said the Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act did not infringe on press freedom, asserting that the Constitution guaranteed journalistic independence.

"The journalistic freedom is guaranteed by the Constitution. That freedom is absolutely available. There is not even an intention to affect the journalistic freedom," Mr. Vaishnaw said. He invited editors and media professionals to engage in an open dialogue with the government on concerns surrounding the law.

The remarks came amid concerns from news publishers that the law could make investigative reporting more difficult. They have argued that the absence of a specific exemption for journalism could affect reporting on matters of public interest, especially investigations involving personal information collected without consent. They have also raised concerns about retaining information required as part of investigative reporting, and protecting confidential sources. The Minister said the privacy law "fully maintains the journalistic freedom the Constitution guarantees", adding that it was aimed at protecting personal data without undermining media freedom.

It is learnt that the government is also open to amending the law to explicitly safeguard journalistic activities, if necessary. "If hardcoding is required, we can hardcode it; it only requires an amendment... There is no problem in that because our intent is clear," a top source said. The source added that the government was willing to discuss the concerns and that any confusion could be addressed through an amendment in Parliament.

Mr. Vaishnaw said the DPDP Act was introduced following a Supreme Court judgment recognising the right to privacy.

(With agency inputs)

Former Minister Anbil Mahesh Poyyamozhi seeks bail in alleged ₹100-crore bribery case

R. Sivaraman
CHENNAI


Anbil Mahesh Poyyamozhi being taken to a hospital after being remanded to judicial custody in Chennai on Monday. PTI

DMK leader and former School Education Minister Anbil Mahesh Poyyamozhi, who was arrested on Monday in connection with an alleged ₹100-crore scam involving private schools, has filed a petition seeking bail.

He also challenged his arrest, alleging non-compliance with mandatory arrest procedures. He said the FIR itself was registered without the approval required under Section 17A of the Prevention of Corruption Act, 1988.

He was arrested by the Chennai Central Crime Branch police for allegedly cheating private school administrators of more than 100 crore on the promise of securing government approvals.

In his bail petition, Mr. Poyyamozhi alleged that the grounds of arrest were not communicated to him and that no arrest memorandum was issued.

He further contended that the police had failed to comply with the procedure prescribed under Section 36 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), 2023.

'Custody unnecessary'

The former Minister argued that custodial interrogation was unnecessary in the absence of specific material warranting his detention.

He said that the investigation could proceed without custody, and expressed his willingness to cooperate with the investigating agency and comply with any conditions imposed by the court.

Mr. Poyyamozhi also denied being a flight risk, stating that there was no material to suggest that he would abscond, tamper with evidence, or influence witnesses.

He sought bail citing his lack of criminal antecedents and his medical condition – pancreatitis. The bail petition will come up for hearing before the special court for cases under the Prevention of Corruption Act on Thursday.

Vellore councillor held

Puzhal police on Wednesday arrested Vellore DMK councillor 'Teeta' Saravanan after a video of him making a controversial remark about the Karur stampede went viral on social media.

Saravanan allegedly made the remark during a protest by DMK cadre on Monday night, when Mr. Poyyamozhi was being taken to the Puzhal Central Prison following his arrest.

In the video , Saravanan was heard saying, "If we had finished him off at Karur on that day, we wouldn't be in this situation today." The remark was allegedly directed at C. Joseph Vijay.

Puzhal police registered a case against Saravanan under Sections 192 (wanton provocation with intent to cause a riot), 296(b) (obscene acts and songs), 353(1) (statements likely to cause public mischief) and 351(3) (criminal intimidation) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita.

The police launched a search for the councillor after he absconded. He was eventually traced to a DMK functionary's house in Villupuram.

Meanwhile, Vepery police booked former DMK Minister P.K. Sekarbabu, MP Kalanidhi Veerasamy and 10 others for staging a protest outside the Police Commissioner's office on Monday in connection with Mr. Poyyamozhi's arrest and interrogation.

Court gives ex-WFI chief final chance to respond to appeal

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A Delhi court on Wednesday gave BJP leader and former Wrestling Federation of India (WFI) president Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh a final opportunity to respond to an appeal by four women wrestlers challenging his acquittal in a sexual harassment case.

Special judge Dig Vinay Singh of the Rouse Avenue Courts issued the notice to him.

The appeal challenges the August 3 order of the Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate (ACJM), which acquitted Mr. Singh and his aide Vinod Tomar. The trial court cited "significant" inconsistencies in the complainants' accounts of the dates, years and locations of the alleged incidents.

The wrestlers contend that the decision was legally flawed, relied on a selective assessment of evidence and failed to apply established legal principles.

In their appeal, the wrestlers argue that the judgment relied on "archaic and stereotypical assumptions" about victims' expected behaviour and gave undue weight to minor discrepancies while overlooking the broader evidence.

The case gained national attention in 2023 when wrestlers, including Sakshi Malik, Vinesh Phogat, Bajrang Punia and Sangeeta Phogat, staged prolonged protests in New Delhi, demanding action against Mr. Singh over allegations involving several women wrestlers. The alleged incidents occurred between 2016 and 2019 at the WFI office, Mr. Singh's official residence, and during international tours.

Cabinet clears 3% hike in dearness allowance

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The Cabinet on Wednesday approved a 3% hike in dearness allowance and dearness relief, benefiting over 1.17 crore Central government employees and pensioners.

Announcing the decision, Information and Broadcasting Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said the Union Cabinet headed by Prime Minister Narendra Modi has taken the decision ahead of Diwali. The increase will be effective from July 1, 2026. It will benefit 48.54 lakh employees and 68.71 lakh pensioners.

The Cabinet also approved the Container Manufacturing Promotion Scheme with a budgetary outlay of ₹10,000 crore up to FY40 to promote a globally competitive container manufacturing ecosystem in India.

India rejects patent plea for the treatment of drug-resistant TB

Bindu Shajan Perappadan
NEW DELHI

The application was challenged on the grounds that the combination lacked an inventive step

The Indian Patent Office has rejected a patent application filed by the U.S.-based Global Alliance for TB Drug Development (TB Alliance) for the combination of bedaquiline, pretomanid, and linezolid (BPaL), a six-month, all-oral treatment regimen for drug-resistant tuberculosis.

Recommended by the WHO for eligible people, BPaL offers a shorter course of treatment than older, longer regimens, reducing the burden of treatment on patients and their families.

"Only those who have been treated for TB know what it feels like to go through more than a year of antibiotics with painful injections. Access to a shorter, oral and effective treatment can mean returning to work, caring for their families and rebuilding their lives", explained Loon Gangte of DNP+.

The decision follows two pre-grant oppositions filed in 2020 – one by Eldred Tellis (Sankalp Rehabilitation Trust) and Ganesh Acharya, with support from the Lawyers' Collective and Médécins Sans Frontières Access Campaign, and the other by the Delhi Network of Positive People (DNP+), with support from TWN.

The patent application was challenged on the grounds that the combination as well as its use in a shorter treatment regimen, had already been disclosed in scientific research dating back to 2015. They argued that combining these known medicines did not constitute an inventive step warranting a new patent monopoly.

India has the world's largest tuberculosis burden. According to WHO estimates, approximately 2.71 million people developed TB in the country in 2024, accounting for a quarter of global cases, with an incidence rate of 187 per 1,00,000 people. Civil society groups are also demanding that the TB Alliance stop the pursuit of proprietary rights over BPaL in other countries.

Data shared in masked form, says ULIP amid complaints over sale of vehicle information

Jagriti Chandra
NEW DELHI


The Road Transport Ministry sought an audit after finding that some entities were extracting data in large volumes from ULIP. FILE PHOTO

After the Ministry of Road Transport sought an audit of users accessing the Centre's logistics portal following complaints that multiple apps and websites were selling vehicle information, the Unified Logistics Interface Platform (ULIP) rejected the allegations of its misuse. It said that all data were masked and called for broader scrutiny of the platforms involved.

"ULIP relays information in the format received from the source API. For example, vehicle owner names, chassis and engine numbers retain their masking, and mobile number field remains null in both the source response and the response provided to users. ULIP does not independently generate, unmask or enrich the underlying data," ULIP wrote in response to a story in *The Hindu*.

The Ministry sought an audit after finding that some entities were extracting data in large volumes from ULIP with some pulling out as many as 50 lakh records a month. The Road Ministry shares vehicle information with multiple government agencies and private firms from its portals such as VAHAN, SARATHI, e-Challan and PUCC portals.

ULIP said it uses sufficient safeguards that include screening of entities that have access to its portal, their proposed use cases, binding terms and conditions, IP whitelisting, phased onboarding and continuous monitoring of API usage. This framework complies with the Road Ministry's Policy for Data Sharing from the National Transport Repository which prescribes authentication, secret keys, masking of personally identifiable information (PII) and defined approval mechanisms, ULIP added.

Referring to multiple apps selling vehicle information data in unmasked form, ULIP said there needed to be a "scrutiny of wider ecosystem of platforms and channels through which such information is being made available".

The Road Ministry has written to the Indian Computer Emergency Response Team (CERT-In), the government's nodal agency for investigating cybersecurity incidents, seeking a forensic audit of VAHAN, SARATHI, e-Challan and PUCC portals, which hold a range of vehicle-owner information.

It has also sought the intervention of the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MEITY) for a review of its data sharing policy and suggest ways to strengthen it. The Road Ministry also plans to audit various enforcement agencies that access its portals for data.

Nirmala and Rahul spar over Tata Group leadership dispute

Congress leader questions industry's' 'silence' over leadership battle, says the conglomerate is being 'criminally destroyed'; Union Finance Minister hits back, accuses him of politicising commercial, legal matters and casting 'baseless aspersions'

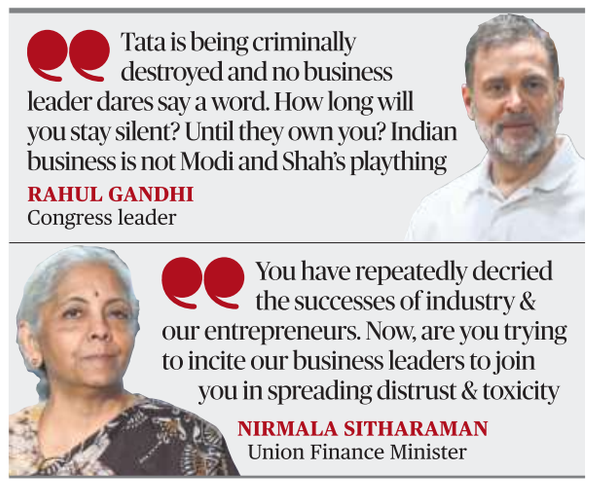
Sandeep Phukan
NEW DELHI

Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman and Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi sparred on Wednesday over the leadership dispute at Tata Sons, with Mr. Gandhi questioning why Union Home Minister Amit Shah had hosted representatives of Tata Trusts and Tata Sons at his residence and accusing the government of "criminally destroying" the Tata Group.

Hitting back at Mr. Gandhi's charge of criminal destruction, the Finance Minister accused him of politicising commercial and legal matters and casting "baseless aspersions".

The Opposition leader responded by asking which "commercial and legal matter" required a meeting of Tata Trusts and Tata Sons hosted at Mr. Shah's residence.

> Tata is being criminally destroyed and no business leader dares say a word. How long will you stay silent? Until they own you? Indian business is not Modi and Shah's plaything
>
> **RAHUL GANDHI**
> Congress leader



> You have repeatedly decried the successes of industry & our entrepreneurs. Now, are you trying to incite our business leaders to join you in spreading distrust & toxicity
>
> **NIRMALA SITHARAMAN**
> Union Finance Minister

"Which 'legal and commercial matter' required Tata Trusts and Tata Sons to be hosted at Amit Shah's residence? When is crony number 1 going to appear in the game and which pieces of Tata is he going to get?" Mr. Gandhi said in a post on social media platform X addressing the Minister. "Finally, all India's businesses except 3-4 of your cronies, already hate all of you and don't need any incitement," he added.

Mr. Gandhi's post followed an earlier rebuttal from the Finance Minister.

"Being the LoP @RahulGandhi, I suggest you refrain from politicising every issue. Also, casually labelling commercial and legal matters as criminal is unacceptable," Ms. Sitharaman said in a post on X.

"You have repeatedly decried the successes of Indian industry & our entrepreneurs. Now, are you trying to incite our business leaders to join you in spreading distrust & toxicity?" the Minister said.

Mr. Gandhi had earlier questioned the "silence" of India's business leaders over the bitter leadership dispute at Tata Sons, the holding company of the country's largest conglomerate.

'Lack courage'

"Tata is being criminally destroyed and no business leader dares say a word. How long will you stay silent? Until they own you? Indian business is not Modi and Shah's plaything," Mr. Gandhi said, adding, "You lack courage. We don't. We will ensure justice for these crimes."

Mr. Gandhi is the first high-profile politician to publicly comment on the dispute, which has split the trustees of Tata Trusts and spilled into the Tata Sons boardroom.

Unlike other conglomerates, Tata Trusts, a group of philanthropic entities, holds approximately 66% of the shares in Tata Sons, which oversees the group companies, including Tata Consultancy Services Limited, Tata Motors Limited, Tata Steel Limited and Titan Company Limited.

Earlier this week, Tata Trusts chairman Noel Tata challenged the resolution to reappoint N. Chandrasekaran as chairman of Tata Sons, which was passed at the September 17 board meeting.

At the heart of the friction between Tata Trusts and Tata Sons is the question of listing Tata Sons on the stock exchanges. While Mr. Chandrasekaran is in favour of a listing, amid pressure from the Reserve Bank of India, Mr. Noel Tata is opposed to the move.

In her post, Ms. Sitharaman contrasted the Congress's record in government with that of the Narendra Modi-led government, accusing the former of having suppressed entrepreneurship through the "Licence-Quota Raj".

"So Rahul*ji*, refrain from seeing ghosts everywhere," Ms. Sitharaman said.

There was no immediate reaction from the Tata Group to Mr. Gandhi's allegations.

Modi questions Congress over party's losses in MLC elections across four States

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Wednesday took a dig at the Congress, pointing to the principal Opposition party's losses in the Member of Legislative Council (MLC) elections held using ballot papers across four major States.

"MLC elections in 28 seats across four big States – Uttar Pradesh, Maharashtra, Bihar and Karnataka. Elections held using ballot papers. Guess how many seats Congress won?" said Mr. Modi on X.

Results for all 11 seats had been declared in Uttar Pradesh. While the Bharatiya Janata Party won six seats, the Samajwadi Party bagged five. In Bihar, the BJP-led NDA alliance won four seats. The Jan Suraaj Party opened its account with one seat, while the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) secured one seat and Independents bagged two. In Karnataka, the BJP-JD(S) alliance swept all four seats.

Mahayuti allies BJP and Shiv Sena, and Opposition NCP (SP) won one seat each out of the five Maharashtra constituencies, while counting of votes for two other seats was underway.



Narendra Modi

The Congress claimed its candidate has won the Nagpur Graduates constituency, with State unit chief Harshwardhan Sapkal saying that the BJP nominee has been trounced in the RSS headquarters.

'Whirlwind of lies'

Earlier, at a press briefing, BJP MP Sudhanshu Trivedi said the MLC election results showed a lack of public support for the Congress and that its methods were not working. He said the ambitions of Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, and the Congress to "spread anarchy by creating a whirlwind of lies" appeared to have been dented by the results.

"The most important aspect of these elections is that they were conducted through ballot papers and ballot boxes... This makes it clear that the Congress party lacks the ability to secure the support of the public or the concerned electorate in any kind of election, whether conducted using EVMs (Electronic Voting Machines) or through ballot papers and ballot boxes," he said.

Responding to Mr. Modi, Congress leader Pawan Khera said Mr. Modi should demonstrate his confidence in the BJP's electoral prowess by committing to hold all future Lok Sabha and Assembly polls through ballot paper, suspend the special intensive revision of electoral rolls, restore the 13.3 crore deleted voters, remove Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and repeal the law granting him lifelong immunity.

(With inputs from PTI)

INDIA bloc to hold 'impeachment' of CEC at Kharge's residence tomorrow

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) will hold its proposed "public impeachment" of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar at Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge's official residence here at 3.30 p.m. on Friday, Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh announced on Wednesday.

The Congress president's official residence was decided as the venue after the Opposition bloc's attempts to organise the event at the Ashok Hotel and Ramlila Maidan allegedly ran into hurdles over permissions.



Mallikarjun Kharge

The programme has been planned as a curtain-raiser for the Opposition's November 1 rally at Ramlila Maidan against alleged electoral irregularities and the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

"The CEC has openly violated the spirit and provisions of the Constitution. He has hollowed out the very foundation of our meticulously planned electoral democratic system. In plain words, he has lied to the Supreme Court. Acting on the signals of that venomous duo, he has turned himself into their tool. Their turn will come next," Mr. Ramesh said.

On Tuesday, the Congress had alleged that the authorities were obstructing the event to silence criticism of the Election Commission of India (ECI).

Congress general secretary (organisation) K.C. Venugopal claimed that Ashok Hotel, which had initially granted permission, withdrew it following police intervention. The party subsequently decided to shift the programme to Ramlila Maidan.

However, Mr. Venugopal alleged that police personnel stopped workers from setting up infrastructure at the venue.

Responding to the charge, Deputy Commissioner of Police (Central) Rohit Rajbir Singh had told *The Hindu* that the Congress had sought permission only for a rally at Ramlila Maidan on November 1. No separate request for a mock impeachment had been received, he said.

Cockroach Janta Party backs INDIA bloc's November 1 rally against irregularities in SIR

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), on Wednesday extended its support to the Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) bloc's November 1 rally against the irregularities in the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, reiterating its demand for Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar's resignation.

In a statement shared on social media, the CJP said the SIR had raised serious concerns over the possible exclusion of eligible voters, arguing that the Election Commission of India's responsibility was to safeguard every citizen's right to vote.

"The fundamental principle of democracy is that people get to choose their government, not that the government gets to choose its voters," the party said, alleging that the SIR exercise had undermined public confidence in the electoral process.

In a post on X, CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke said, "Gyanu must go! The Cockroach Janta Party extends its support to the INDIA Bloc's November 1 rally. Nation above all!"

The CJP said it would support all organisations fighting for free and fair elections. The statement ended with the slogans "Jai Bhim" and "Jai Hind".

The endorsement comes ahead of the INDIA bloc's planned rally at Delhi's Ramlila Maidan on November 1, part of the Opposition's campaign against alleged electoral irregularities and its demand for greater transparency in voter-list revisions.

(With inputs from PTI)

Amit Shah to inaugurate martyrs' memorial

The Hindu Bureau
CHANDIGARH

Union Home Minister Amit Shah will visit Haryana's Ambala on November 5 to inaugurate a memorial, dedicated to martyrs of the country's freedom struggle, Haryana's Energy Minister Anil Vij said on Wednesday.

"Documents show that in 1857, the 60th and 5th Native Infantry regiments sounded the bugle of the freedom struggle at Ambala Cantonment. Yet history never remembered those heroes who were tied to trees and shot," he said.

Police arrest former West Bengal Minister Indranil in Durga Puja ticket scam

Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

Former West Bengal Minister Indranil Sen was arrested by the Kolkata Police on Wednesday in connection with a Durga Puja ticket scam case.

Mr. Sen, a Minister during the Mamata Banerjee administration, had been summoned for questioning at the Enforcement Directorate (ED) office. He was arrested by the State Police immediately after leaving the ED's office.

Mr. Sen, who faces allegations of financial irregularities, had been avoiding summonses by the ED and the police. He was questioned by the ED at their office in the CGO Complex in Salt Lake for over four hours on Wednesday.

The former Tourism and Culture Minister was denied anticipatory bail by the Calcutta High Court.

Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari said that Mr. Sen had been under investigation for a while. "... We arrested him on the basis of evidence," Mr. Adhikari said, adding that all "such thieves" will end up behind bars.



Former West Bengal Minister Indranil Sen (left) arrives at the Enforcement Directorate (ED) office. PTI

Mamata-Trinamool Congress general secretary Abhishek Banerjee said, "Under the BJP those who refuse to sell their conscience are the ones being sent to jail. Meanwhile, thieves and fraudsters are forgiven for even the gravest crimes as soon as they take up the BJP flag."

The controversy is focused on MassArt, which was established after Durga Puja received the UNESCO intangible cultural heritage tag in 2021. Two years later, allegations of irregularities linked to Mr. Sen's dealings with organisation surfaced. The outfit is headed by his wife Madhuchanda Sen.

The complainant, Jaydeep Mukherjee, alleged that Mr. Sen had misused UNESCO's name and his position in the government to wrongfully secure money from people under the MassArt banner.

"It is alleged that the accused falsely represented their organisation as UNESCO sponsored, and collected huge sums of money from the general public through MassArt between 2022 and 2025," the ED said in an official statement. The ED investigation alleged that Mr. Sen used the platform for personal financial gains.

BJP names Hardeep Puri as candidate for RS bypoll in M.P.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Bharatiya Janata Party on Wednesday named Union Minister Hardeep Singh Puri as the party's candidate for the coming Rajya Sabha byelection in Madhya Pradesh, necessitated by the resignation of former Minister of State for Information and Broadcasting L. Murugan earlier this month.

Mr. Puri, 74, is the Union Minister for Petroleum and Natural Gas. His term as MP from Uttar Pradesh is set to end on November 25. The byelection to the vacated seat in Madhya Pradesh is scheduled for November 12. Mr. Murugan had four years left of a six-year term when he vacated his Rajya Sabha membership. The BJP is well poised to get Mr. Puri elected without trouble due to its comfortable numbers in the State Assembly.

Mr. Puri's return to the Rajya Sabha quells months of speculation about his potential exit from the helm of affairs at the Union Oil Ministry – a position he has held since July 2021. It has been a tenure with geopolitical challenges due to the war between Ukraine and Russia as well as the Iran-U.S. conflict, along with controversy over Mr. Puri's name appearing in the Epstein files released by the U.S. Department of Justice. Mr. Puri's likely continuation in the Council of Ministers is also being seen as a vote of confidence in him by Prime Minister Narendra Modi.



Hardeep Singh Puri

Taking to X, Mr. Puri expressed his gratitude to the Prime Minister and the top leadership of the BJP for his return to the Rajya Sabha, stating that it was "not merely a responsibility but an opportunity to further strengthen my dedication to the organisation and my resolve to serve the public."

Suvendu raises allegations over aide's murder; asks Mamata to rest at home

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

Making allegations against the higher-ups in the Trinamool Congress over the murder of his aide Chandranath Rath, West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari on Wednesday advised Trinamool Congress chairperson Mamata Banerjee to stay away from electoral politics and take rest at home.

Speaking in the West Bengal Assembly after two newly elected MLAs of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), Hasirani Rath, the mother of Chandranath Rath, and Sakharav Sarkar, took oath, the Chief Minister defended his decision to vacate Nandigram and remain MLA from Bhabanipur.

In the 2026 West Bengal Assembly polls, Mr. Adhikari was elected from both Nandigram and Bhabanipur. "Had I vacated Bhabanipur, the person I had defeated twice would have got another opportunity to contest an election. I did not want to give her that opportunity. I had trounced her in Bhabanipur, and I would urge her not to contest elections any more. You have already crossed 75 years of age. There is no need to enter the electoral fray any further. You should take rest at home," the Chief Minister said.



West Bengal CM Suvendu Adhikari advised Mamata Banerjee to stay away from electoral politics. FILE PHOTO

Contract killing

Mr. Adhikari also spoke about the murder of Chandranath Rath, who was shot dead in Madhyamgram on May 6, barely days after the BJP's win in the Assembly polls.

The Chief Minister alleged that his former aide was killed because of his association with him. "Chandranath was murdered simply because he was my aide. The CBI has arrested seven people, including the shooters and contract killers. What remains to be established is where the Rs 2 crore 'supari' for the contract killing came from. Was it Camac Street, Kalighat or Diamond Harbour? Once that is known, the investigation will be complete," he said.

The reference to Camac Street and Diamond Harbour is usually associated with Lok Sabha member Abhishek Banerjee, while Kalighat is a reference to Mamata Banerjee.

INBRIEF



UAE honours flydubai crew, Smit Machchhar for bravery

UAE President His Highness Sheikh Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan has conferred the First Class Order of Zayed II on Indian Captain Smit Machchhar and fellow flydubai crew members in recognition of their courageous efforts to ensure passenger safety during an attempted mid-air attack aboard a Dubai-Tel Aviv flight. The medals were presented by His Highness Sheikh Hamdan bin Mohammed bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Crown Prince of Dubai, Deputy Prime Minister and Minister of Defence, who commended the crew's actions and sense of responsibility, Dubai Media Office said in a statement on Tuesday. PTI

SC asks Sanjay Raut to appear in person over contempt case

The Supreme Court on Tuesday directed the physical appearance of Shiv Sena (UBT) Rajya Sabha MP Sanjay Raut in court on November 17 in a contempt case initiated by the Supreme Court Bar Association (SCBA) over allegedly derogatory remarks made about the Chief Justice of India. A Bench headed by Justice Aravind Kumar allowed senior journalist Nikhil Wagle to appear virtually on the same day (November 17) in the same contempt case. Mr. Wagle, accused of making public comments of a disparaging manner against the CJI, was represented by senior advocate Indira Jaisingand has also filed an affidavit in response to the contempt notice.

HC notice to Centre, Meta for blocking Instagram account

The Delhi High Court has asked the Centre and Meta to respond to a plea against withholding the Instagram handle 'Bring Back Ballot', which published content advocating the use of paper ballots for elections. Justice Amit Mahajan, on October 27, issued notice on the petition by the account operator, organisation Mission Save Constitution, and its founder lawyer Mehmood Pracha, and listed the case for hearing on November 6. The petition said that on the day the organisation proposed to hold a peaceful protest, called "Bring Back Ballot - EVM Hatao Desh Bachao", at Jantar Mantar, it discovered that its handle was not available in India.

Early intervention vital for child development: CDC chief

Inclusive early childhood development (iECD) seeks to ensure that every child, including those with developmental delays, disabilities, autism and other forms of neurodivergence, has equitable access to healthcare, nutrition, protection, and early intervention, Deepa Bhaskaran, director, Child Development Centre (CDC), Thiruvananthapuram, said at a media workshop organised by UNICEF and PIB. It aimed to strengthen understanding of inclusive early childhood development, child rights and disability inclusion, promote ethical, child-sensitive and non-stigmatising reporting, and raise awareness of AI-related risks.

Regulator cuts prices of 543 anti-cancer medicines

Bindu Shajan Perappadan
NEW DELHI

The National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA) on Wednesday revised downward the maximum retail price of 543 anti-cancer medicines of different brands, effective November 9.

On October 17, the NPPA had announced Trade Margin Rationalisation (TMR) of 137 non-scheduled anti-cancer drugs in public interest to address excessive trade margins, make cancer treatment more affordable, and improve access to anti-cancer medicines.

Meanwhile, Jan Swasthya Abhiyan India (JSA India), an organisation working for accessibility of medicines, said that controlling trade margins alone is insufficient. Life-saving cancer treatment must be affordable based on medical need, not a patient's ability to pay.

"For example, the reported MRP of one brand of palbociclib fell from approximately ₹40,421 to ₹2,720 per pack, while thiotepa fell from approximately ₹80,072 to ₹7,150 per vial. Such drastic reductions raise serious questions about the pricing practices of pharmaceutical companies," the group said.

Centre forms panel to probe death of young cheetah in M.P.'s Kuno

Wildlife officials say the animal may have been shot in self-defence after being mistaken for a leopard, but they have not yet ruled out poaching

Mehul Malpani
BHOPAL

The Union government has formed a high-level committee for an on-ground investigation into the death of a 19-month-old cheetah cub due to gunshot injuries outside the boundaries of the Kuno National Park in Madhya Pradesh.

The Union Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change, in a statement, said the Centre had taken "serious note" of the cub's death.

The three-member probe team will closely coordinate with the Madhya Pradesh Forest Department and the special task force constituted by the State to ensure strict and swift action in the matter, it added. The team will also review the security protocols and monitoring measures in place for the big cats.

"Viewing the matter with utmost gravity, the Centre has deputed a high-level team for an on-ground investigation into the incident, given the critical importance of Project Cheetah and the need to ensure the highest standards of protection for the reintroduced population of the Big Cat," it said.



Fragile existence: The Union government launched its ambitious reintroduction programme for cheetahs in September 2022. PTI

The team comprises the Inspector-General of Forests, National Tiger Conservation Authority (NTCA); Additional Director, Wildlife Crime Control Bureau (WCCB); and Regional Deputy Director, WCCB. "The Central team deputed by the MoEFCC would work in coordination with the State machinery. It would also examine the implementation of security protocols, as well as monitoring and protection measures being undertaken to avoid any such incident in future. The Central team would submit its findings and recommendations to the Ministry for further directions to the State Government and field authorities," the Ministry said.

Madhya Pradesh's top wildlife officials say that it could be a case of shooting in self-defence after mistaking the animal for a leopard, but have not ruled out the possibility of poaching.

Union Cabinet gives nod to ₹7,396-crore panchayat scheme

Sobhana K. Nair
NEW DELHI

The five-year scheme will have a Central share of ₹4,869.48 crore and State share of ₹2,526.07 crore

The Union Cabinet on Wednesday approved the Pradhan Mantri Viksit Gram Swaraj Yojana (PM-VGSY), a ₹7,395.55-crore scheme aimed at strengthening the planning and governance capacities of gram panchayats over the next five years.

The scheme will be implemented from 2026-27 to 2030-31 with a Central share of ₹4,869.48 crore and a State share of ₹2,526.07 crore. The government said around 32 lakh elected representatives, panchayat functionaries and other stakeholders across 2.55 lakh gram panchayats and traditional local bodies would be trained under the programme.

The new scheme is an upgraded version of the Rashtriya Gram Swaraj Abhiyan, with a greater emphasis on "holistic" development, as opposed to the existing practice of providing separate training modules for individual schemes. The idea is to offer "digital handholding" for the panchayat representatives to help them with evidence-based planning. Though the government refers to the 32 lakh representatives as "beneficiaries," it does not offer any stipend.

The scheme seeks to position gram panchayats as the focal point of local governance and development planning. It envisages preparing 2.55 lakh Gram Panchayat Development Plans (GDPDs) through the eGramSwaraj portal, enabling village-level priorities to align with Central and State government schemes and resources.

Awareness drives will be conducted across the country as part of the programme, with each campaign expected to reach at least one lakh citizens. A key element of PM-VGSY is the creation of a common digital platform that will integrate information on government schemes, beneficiaries, community assets and available resources. This will help panchayats identify development gaps, improve departmental coordination, and monitor implementation more effectively.

Railways to turn off charging points in trains during night

V. Geetanath
HYDERABAD

Train passengers will no longer be allowed to keep their mobile phones charging overnight, with the Railway Board issuing strict instructions to all zonal railways to switch off charging points between 11 p.m. and 5 a.m.

In an official communication, the Board has directed railway authorities to conduct surprise inspections in coaches during overnight journeys. Both officers and supervisory staff have been asked to ensure strict compliance with the directive, with no exceptions permitted under any circumstances.

Senior railway officials said a circular mandating the shutdown of mobile charging circuits during night travel had been issued more than a decade ago. However, the rule was apparently not being enforced consistently on some trains.

The Railway Board's renewed insistence on implementing the measure follows a recent incident in the South Eastern Railway zone. Railway staff reportedly failed to switch off charging points during the prescribed hours, leading to a power bank explosion while being charged.

However, some officials believe the focus should be on preventing the charging of power banks during the six-hour overnight period rather than restricting charging altogether.

They also argued that the number of charging points should not be increased indiscriminately.

SC agrees to hear AITUC challenge to definition of 'industry' in new law

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court agreed on Wednesday to hear a petition filed by the All India Trade Union Congress (AITUC) Tamil Nadu challenging the definition of 'industry' under the Industrial Relations Code (IRC) 2020 as "deliciously vague", especially when the new law exempts a wide array of institutions from charitable to sovereign functions of the government.

The IRC affords legal protections to workers who are employed in institutions which come under the ambit of 'industry'. Section 2(p) of the IRC defines industry as any institution engaged in a "systematic activity carried on by co-operation between an employer and worker for the production, supply or distribution of goods or services with a view to satisfy human wants or wishes".



Appearing before a Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, senior advocate Gopal Sankaranarayanan and advocate Aarthi Rajan, for the trade union, referred to the exceptions to 'industry' listed in the Code.

Mr. Sankaranarayanan submitted that the exceptions to 'industry' included institutions wholly or substantially engaged in charitable, social or philanthropic service to "any activity of the appropriate government relatable to sovereign functions" to "any other activity as may be notified by the Central government".

"Is there a problem with the definition of 'industry'?" Chief Justice Kant asked.

The senior counsel said the definition in the Code did not meet the requirements of the 'triple test'. A 1978 seven-judge Constitution Bench judgment, authored by Justice V.R. Krishna Iyer, in the *Bangalore Water Supply and Sewerage Board v. A. Rajappa* case, had laid down conditions that any activity which was systematic or organised, operated on the basis of employer-employee cooperation and dealt in the production of goods and services to satisfy human wants came within the ambit of 'industry'. The judgment had brought even hospitals, educational institutions and municipalities within the fold of 'industry'.

In August 2026, a nine-judge Bench headed by Chief Justice Kant had reviewed the interpretation given by Justice Iyer in 1978 to the definition of 'industry' under Section 2(j) of the Industrial Disputes Act, 1947. However, the nine-judge Bench had been preceded by the coming into force of the 2020 Code, which largely made the reference to it infructuous.

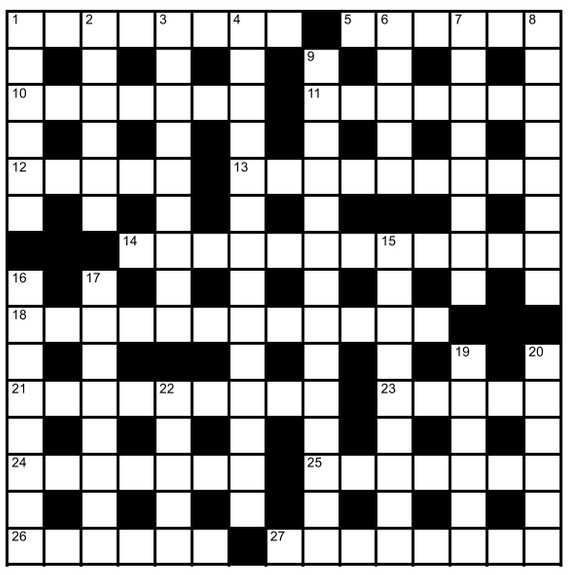
"The future of 'industry' in Section 2(p) of IRC is not burdened by the interpretation of 2(j) in the Industrial Disputes Act," Chief Justice Kant had observed.

TH CROSSWORD + 14935

(set by Afterdark)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at *https://thehindu.com/crosswords*

SCAN TO PLAY



Across

1 Roadwork Company clerk at the outskirts to get a valve, say (8)
5 At the same time as wife, husband is crossing line on time (6)
10 Rowdy's cover at slums exposed (7)
11 A plane curve can be seen at eclipse, after initial cover disappears left (7)
12 A play in rugby looks odd after second choke-tackle in the front (5)
13 Old boy's toxic and disgusting (9)
14 Doctor reins her fear with an aerosol spray, perhaps (3,9)
18 Happiness at party after Sita's mingling (12)
21 Box kept near gate has arrack, essentially for the band (9)
23 Neighbour at North East has friend (5)
24 To that article, two leading reporters toiled one-third (7)
25 In release, Tom said - process of the temporal bone (7)
26 Break off with blonde, sister relayed (6)
27 Deadly deli, i.e barmen at both ends menacing (8)

Down

1 Rift in school is mushrooming primarily (6)
2 Aromas are forbidding in old society (6)
3 Disconcerted masculine insults (9)
4 Quotient of two integers derived from standard operation using Faraday's rule (6,8)
6 Curse over 50 individuals makes them a genus of snail (5)
7 A connector in friend's back's jagged at the tip, points to erosion at both ends (3,5)
8 Exchequer at Surrey vandalised (8)
9 Our primitive ancestor learnt, had men adopt one development (11,3)
15 Caught son turning inside on the description of a facial feature (4-5)
16 Different fool retweeted without no end (8)
17 Holders assemble rocket in ship (8)
19 One pill at the beginning and end by doctor's order advances calmness (6)
20 Vehicle found in a small ridge (6)
22 Time lost in matches for betting odds (5)

SUDOKU

			3			9		
				2				
	2	1		7			3	4
5		7			1			9
	6						4	
2			9			1		7
9	8			1		6	7	
				3				
		4			2			

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

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Solution to previous puzzle

I	M	P	O	S	T		A	S
N		A		A			H	
A	D	O	R	I	N	G		D
R		V		D		S		L
D	I	S	E	M	B	O	W	E
		N		L		I		
S	C	U	B	A		S	I	D
U				S		S		E
S	P	R	I	N	T	E	R	
E		C				O		A
T	R	E	E		S	O	L	I
B		B		T		L		E
B	O	N	E	D	R	Y		I
W		R		U				C
L	I	G	H	T	S		K	E

S	O	R	T					
		N		E				
		E	M	E	S	N	E	
		R		A				
		O	U	C	H			
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		A	O	S				
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R	I	T	Y					
		A		R				
I	N	H	I	B	I	T		
		C		G		A		
R	N	E	L					

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

4	7	6	2	3	9	8	1	5
5	3	2	8	1	6	9	4	7
8	1	9	7	5	4	6	2	3
3	6	8	1	2	7	5	9	4
1	2	4	9	8	5	3	7	6
7	9	5	6	4	3	2	8	1
2	5	3	4	9	1	7	6	8
9	4	7	5	6	8	1	3	2
6	8	1	3	7	2	4	5	9

FAITH

Karva Chauth significance

Celebrated on Chaturthi tithi of Krishna Paksha in the Karthik month, the festival of Karva Chauth is a significant occasion for married women in north India. They pray for their husbands' long life, prosperity and health. Culturally, the festival connects with the initiation of the Rabi crop in the agricultural calendar and culture of martial communities where the men went far away to battle and the women who were left behind worried and prayed for their well-being, said Prof. Kumool Abbi.

Elaborate rituals are part of this festival. Married women observe complete *nirjala* fast from sunrise to moonrise. A pre-dawn meal called *sargi* is offered by the in-laws for the married women to partake, before the fast. The important myths associated with the festival of Karva Chauth are those of Satyavan and Savitri, Karwa and Princess Veeranwali. The legend of Satyavan and Savitri, which is narrated by sage Markandeya in the Mahabharata, is widely shared on this occasion. Savitri, a princess chooses Satyavan as her husband, but is warned by sage Narada that he was destined to die in one year's time. When Yama arrives to take away Satyavan, Savitri follows him, discoursing on dharma with him. Impressed by her wisdom, Yama grants her a boon. She perseveres and he grants further boons, the last of which is the granting of Satyavan's life. This underscores the importance of dharma in one's life. The festival culminates with the sighting of moon and offering prayers and water (*argya)* to the moon using an earthen pot *karva*. The water is offered through a sieve as the moon rises and the fast is broken with water offered by the husband who is seen through the same sieve.

New genetic tools are breathing fresh life into India's staple crops

As new tools like apomixis become more widely available and private companies shift focus to Indian seeds, it is as important to think about how our system will adapt to these changes as it is to focus on investing in fundamental research in plant genetics, physiology, and host-pathogen interactions

K. VijayRaghavan



India's food security largely depends on rice and wheat, which take up more than half our farmland and provide most of the calories we eat. THOMPSON LE/UNSPLASH

Technology is rapidly changing the way we cultivate rice and wheat, and India has the opportunity to lead the pack if we restore the attraction of fundamental research in plant sciences to our students. The shrillness of anti-GMO voices has driven aspiring biology researchers to other areas of life sciences, which use much the same methods. We need to bring them back to plant research, too.

India's food security largely depends on rice and wheat, which take up more than half our farmland and provide most of the calories Indians eat. Scientists and breeders designed today's wheat and rice varieties at a time when the consequences of excess fertilizer use on soil were not sufficiently anticipated, when pesticides were used to hit insects and other pests with a metaphorical hammer, and when water and electricity were abundant or heavily subsidised.

Today, however, climate change, extreme weather events, droughts, and floods are more immediate concerns. This together with demands for sustainable and moderated use of pesticides and fertilizers, but without compromising yield, has created a high-bar of demand in a competitive world. In addition, science and technology are but one component of solutions that also involve politics, economics, and global supply chains.

Public institutions

The supply of seeds to farmers, for crops such as rice and wheat, has had a strong public-sector presence. The National Seeds Corporation (NSC) was established in 1963. The NSC partners with State seed corporations and State agricultural universities to ensure reliability in the early stages of seed supply. The Indian Council of Agricultural Research (ICAR) laboratories and State agricultural universities ensure supply of 'breeder seeds', certified to be of the highest quality. These are then amplified by partners, which include private companies to generate 'foundation seeds', which are distributed.

For wheat, public institutions dominate the supply of certified seeds, with private players being present in only about 5% of the market. However, their share is growing rapidly, at about 8% each year. In the case of rice, private companies dominate the market for hybrid seeds, with public institutions mainly supplying farmers with small-holdings.

In India, public institutions play a large role in wheat and rice, unlike with maize and cotton, where private companies dominate. The new varieties they develop are available to any registered seed company, public or private. The government has a system in place to make and distribute these new varieties widely, cheaply, and fairly – a system which works reasonably.

India took a big step forward in 2025 in using new gene-editing technology to improve rice, and became the first country to allow farmers to grow rice that had been edited using this technology. The scientists also grew these rice strains in fields, and the approved seeds are now being given to farmers.

Two types of rice, DRR Dhan-100 and Pusa DST Rice-1, were developed by Indian researchers using the CRISPR gene-editing technology. Researchers tested these new rice types widely in 2023-2024. The advances were significant. One variety DRR Dhan-100 took 130 days to mature, compared to 150 days of the baseline strain. It produced close to 20% more rice, at about 5.4 tonnes per hectare, and reduced water use and labour costs. Pusa DST Rice-1 was developed to grow reasonably in salty or alkaline soils. Its yield in these conditions was about 10-30% more than the baseline strains. Government announcements point to lowered water and fertilizer use and, consequently, lowered greenhouse gas emissions as well.

Tale of two varieties

The story behind these two strains is worth understanding for how fundamental research on rice flowering leads to application. The targeted gene in DRR DNAn-1 encodes a product that degrades cytokinin, the hormone driving spikelet formation on a rice panicle. This process caps how many grains a plant can produce.

ICAR's CRISPR edit partially reduces, but does not eliminate, this enzyme's activity, letting cytokinin accumulate just enough to boost spikelet and grain number without the stunted growth seen in complete knockouts. In 2005, Motoyuki Ashikari's team in Japan had already traced a grain-number trait to a natural small deletion in the corresponding gene in a high-yielding wild rice relative, and ICAR recreated that two-decade-old discovery by design, in weeks rather than through years of conventional breeding.

The PUSA DST-1 story is equally interesting. In 2020, a team at ICAR-Indian Agricultural Research Institute, led by Viswanathan Chinnusamy, used the CRISPR-Cas9 gene-editing tool to delete a stretch of a rice gene called *OsDST*, in a particular strain, producing plants with broader leaves, fewer stomata, and sharply better survival under salt stress (over 65% versus just 20% in unedited plants).

This engineered mutant reproduced the effects of a naturally occurring chemical mutation found years earlier in a completely different rice subspecies, confirming that disabling *DST* itself rather than some editing side-effect of the edit had conferred the stress tolerance. Pusa DST Rice 1, released five years later, is the commercial maturation of this already published laboratory mutant, illustrating a journey from a characterised gene to seed ready for farmers to use.

In both cases, the residues of the gene-editing tools were not detected in the final strains. Thus, while genetic engineering tools were used, the results are equivalent to those that would come from conventional mutagenesis and breeding, only much faster and more accurate.

Work on apomixis

Scientists at public institutions conducted the work on the rice, and the resulting seeds will not be tied up in restrictive patents or licensing agreements. The developers have also made sure that the technology used to create it will not be a bottleneck for public breeding programs.

Other innovative approaches are now on the horizon and will likely be deployable in the near future, led by a method called apomixis. It was first successfully demonstrated in rice by Venkatesan Sundaresan and his colleague Imtiyaz Khanday at the University of California, Davis, in 2018. In apomixis, plants are engineered to bypass the normal process of sexual reproduction and fertilisation. This allows desirable traits of the parent plant, known as hybrid vigour, to be preserved indefinitely, rather than being lost in the next generation. The efficiency of this method has improved significantly, with success rates reaching around 90% in rice. Various research groups are now exploring apomixis in other crops, such as maize and sorghum.

Sundaresan's work on plant development earned him a share of the prestigious Wolf Prize in agriculture in 2024, alongside Elliot Meyerowitz and Joanne Chory. In December 2025, Sundaresan and Khanday received the VinFuture Special Prize for their work on self-cloning crop technology, which has the potential to revolutionise agriculture.

There is still a big gap between the lab and the field. Tests in different environments are required to get regulatory approval and to set up systems to produce seeds in large quantities. Because adding foreign genes is not required to make apomixis work, many of these techniques could potentially follow a simpler regulatory process. The technology makes sense for small farmers. If they can save seeds from high-yielding crops and replant them without losing any quality, they will not have to keep buying new seeds every year. This is currently a big expense for many smallholder rice and wheat farmers.

Driving progress

India has not seen a gene-edited wheat released yet, but there are some conventional developments in the pipeline. For instance, the government recently introduced 184 new crop varieties across 25 different crops, including some climate-resilient wheat lines that are expected to reach farmers within the next three years. Hybrid wheat has been a challenge for breeders due to the complexities of wheat's floral biology. It is harder to hybridise than rice or maize. Despite this, hybrid wheat has been gaining traction in India, due in part to private companies like Mahyco and Nuziveedu.

Currently, the most advanced genetically engineered trait in wheat is called HB4, developed by an Argentine company called Bioceres Crop Solutions. This trait uses a gene from sunflowers to help wheat plants tolerate drought. This is not a new type of gene editing but a traditional genetically engineered trait. HB4 is already being grown commercially in Argentina, and on a smaller scale in Brazil and Paraguay.

In August 2024, the U.S. Department of Agriculture gave the green light for HB4 wheat to be grown in the country, making it the fourth to approve its production. However, it may take a few years before we see large-scale commercial planting in the U.S., since more field trials need to be done and the trait needs to be integrated into American wheat varieties. Additionally, export markets need to approve the trait as well.

Australia is taking a two-pronged approach to improving wheat yields, with two separate programmes running side by side. The Australian government has given the green light for field trials of HB4. This trial started in 2024. At the same time, the University of Adelaide is working on a project to engineer wheat and barley to produce higher yields, using genetic modification techniques. This project is set to run until 2029.

Meanwhile, an Australian breeding company called InterGrain has teamed up with a U.S. firm called Inari to try out CRISPR gene-editing. They are hoping to boost wheat yields by 10% and have already started field trials in the 2025 growing season. In a significant development, Australian Grain Technologies and China's Qihe Biosciences have announced that they will be working together on cross-border field trials of a new CRISPR-edited wheat variety. This is important as it shows that international collaboration is driving progress in wheat gene-editing, unlike some other crops like rice.

Reviving a tradition

India's approach to breeding wheat and rice is still largely controlled by the public sector, which means new techniques like editing genes without adding foreign ones can be made available to farmers.

As new tools like apomixis become more widely available and private companies start investing more in Indian seeds, it is as important to think about how our system will adapt to these changes as it is to invest in fundamental research in plant genetics, physiology, development and host-pathogen interactions.

We have had a great tradition here, and it should be revived.

(K. VijayRaghavan is the DAE-Homi Bhabha Chair, TIFR-National Centre for Biological Sciences, Bengaluru. vijay@ncbs.res.in)



India's approach to breeding wheat and rice is still largely controlled by the public sector, which means new techniques like editing genes without adding foreign ones can be made available to farmers. GETTY IMAGES



Salt marshes in India have been estimated to cover around 290 sq. km and support wildlife while stabilising coastal sediments. FILE PHOTO

How the humble salt marsh softens the ocean's fury

Vasudevan Mukunth

The boundary between land and sea is neither fixed nor clear. The soil does not suddenly stop and give away to a wall of water. Instead, the line is often a salt marsh, where ocean waves break and lose vim as they pass over the marsh's elevated surface and push against the stems of salt-tolerant plants.

Gujarat is home to India's largest coastal salt marshes, with smaller areas in Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh, and Maharashtra, among some other places. One 2020 study in *Estuarine Coastal and Shelf Science* estimated they covered around 290 sq. km in all, and supported wildlife and stabilised coastal sediments. Unfortunately they also face significant threats from expanding aquaculture and coastal development.

As global warming continues, storms become ever stronger and water levels rise, these coastal zones are slowly being acknowledged for the formidable natural buffers they are. But they are being threatened as well, especially their plants, and what might happen if they are gone?

A 2014 study in *Nature Geoscience* used a wave flume – a long tank filled with water that uses a mechanical paddle to generate waves – to show that the plants of the salt marsh could break waves substantially even when their stems bent or broke.

Key findings

A new study in *Nature* by researchers at Wageningen University & Research in the Netherlands took the study a big step further. The team moved 306 sq. metres of a live salt marsh, down to the soil and roots, from the coast of the Dutch Wadden Sea to a 300-metre-long flume at the Deltares Research Institute, capable of creating the world's largest artificial waves. There, the marsh was tested at different depths against waves measuring 75 cm, 1.25 metres, and 2 metres high over many hours.

The findings were remarkable: the marsh's elevation fell only 7 mm but at the cost of the flora on the surface losing 75-80% of their biomass and having their stems become shorter by almost half. The researchers concluded the plants' dense network of roots had helped hold the sediments together. The team also found the plants cut the height of waves 75 cm high by 6-22% but those of waves 2 metres high only by up to 6%.

The team also combined their findings with maps of salt marshes worldwide and modelled the storm surges there. For once in a century storms – the kind climate change is rendering more common these days, like Cyclone Nisarga in 2020 – the team elucidated two kinds of outcomes.

Where the incoming waves are at most a metre high, the plants could be expected to cut the height of waves by over 10%, in some instances by as much as 50%. But if the waves got higher, the plants (alone) also became less effective at attenuating them.

Obviously these figures are not a guarantee for every coast everywhere. The study relied on a Dutch marsh dominated by one species of grass (*Elymus athericus*).

A different study published this year, in *Communications Sustainability*, also found that marsh species with more flexible stems often survived extreme waves better than stiffer ones. Nonetheless, the findings are important: they reinforce the ecological value of salt marshes, including the roots they still hold on exposed coasts.

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Hunker down

Proactive governance kept the casualties low after Cyclone Arnab

Cyclone Arnab, the first named storm of the North Indian Ocean cyclone season this year, intensified rapidly before making landfall as a 'very severe cyclonic storm' on October 28. This particular rapidity is a challenge for forecasters and some models did fail to anticipate how strong Arnab would become. It also moved faster than expected towards the coast, before stalling for a time and beginning the landfall process several hours before the India Meteorological Department (IMD) had predicted it would, in the middle of the night, leaving many district authorities with a potentially narrower window to evacuate high-risk settlements. With core wind speeds of 125-135 kilometres per hour, it delivered more than 100 mm of rain over parts of Anakapalli, Visakhapatnam, Kalingapatnam, Kakinada and Machilipatnam, in Andhra Pradesh. But even though it has completed landfall, southern Odisha likely faces a greater threat only hence. Early reports claimed no loss of life in Andhra Pradesh or Odisha, which has been attributed to the disaster management operations in both States; the Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister, N. Chandrababu Naidu, said there were five deaths in Andhra Pradesh. Regrettably, the suspension of transport services, including road connectivity and flights, closure of schools and offices, and power cuts to minimise risks posed by loose wires remains an essential part of saving lives, entailing other social and economic disruptions that the States must account for, and address, in their post-storm assessments.

Odisha may have to brace for rainfall and waters due to moisture in the storm's outer circulation, which will arrive over land that has recovered in patches from the fourth wettest monsoon in the State's history. Extreme rainfall after repeated flooding may face soil that has not drained fully, raising the risk of more flooding following even lower levels of rainfall, and slope failures in hilly terrain. Farmers in Ganjam and Puri have already voiced worries about the risk of prolonged inundation destroying paddy crops, compounding the already considerable financial consequences of the southwest monsoon; Ganjam alone had lost 33% of crops by October. In Sundargarh, however, farmers hope that Arnab will relieve moisture stress in standing crops after a dry month. The IMD has already issued alerts in the Ganjam, Gajapati, Rayagada, Koraput, Malkangiri, Nabarangpur, and Kalahandi districts, before the rainbelt extends further north. The relatively low figure of deaths will be a testament to proactive governance. However, it is past time that States adopted a zero-disruption approach, especially since property and infrastructure were damaged, and the risk of people being pushed into poverty over lost possessions and livelihoods persists.

Clinging on

Netanyahu's continuance will be bad news for Israel and the region

Benjamin Netanyahu was at the centre of Israel's October 27 elections. For Israel's longest-serving Prime Minister, who oversaw a genocidal war in Gaza following Hamas's October 7 attack, the election was the biggest test of his political career. For the Opposition, which promised to hold him accountable for the failures of October 7 and end the country's "forever wars", the election offered an opportunity to oust him from power. The results, however, sent a mixed message. With 85.6% of the votes counted, Mr. Netanyahu's right-religious coalition has lost its majority but is still the largest bloc. His Likud party is projected to win 26 seats, while its main rival Yashar, led by former military chief Gadi Eisenkot, is expected to secure 21. Otzma Yehudit and Religious Zionism, the far-right extremist parties in Mr. Netanyahu's coalition, demonstrated their continued strength, winning 13 seats between them. The dark horse, however, could be the Arab parties – the Joint List is projected to win 12 seats while the United Arab List (Ra'am) could secure seven seats. With neither bloc commanding a majority, the Arab parties could propel the opposition coalition to power. But the big question is whether the anti-Netanyahu coalition is ready to join hands with the Arab parties, which have historically been kept on the margins of Israel' s power politics.

Mr. Netanyahu's central promise has been that only he can guarantee Israel's security. Yet, the October 7 attack took place on his watch and he has refused to take responsibility for the failures that led to it. A wanted man by the International Criminal Court, he has repeated, before and after October 7, that a Palestine state would not be formed while he is in power. His war on Gaza has killed over 70,000 Palestinians, including 20,000 children, and displaced the region's population. Israel's brutal occupation machinery has also expanded and tightened its control of the West Bank, while settler terrorists have unleashed violence on Palestinian households. His war on Iran has been a disaster, with global economic consequences. Mr. Netanyahu has sought to portray his wars as bold, necessary moves to protect Israel, while exploiting Israelis' security concerns for political gain. He may not be voted out immediately, but his failure to secure a majority and the decline in his party's popularity are significant. The Opposition should take its cue from the results and form a broad coalition with the Arab parties. It should restore accountability in governance, revisit his unchecked militarism and rebuild ties with the world. If Mr. Netanyahu continues to cling to power, it would be bad news for Israel and the region.

The SIR verdict, serious constitutional questions



Bishwajit Bhattacharyya

Senior Advocate, Supreme Court of India, and a former Additional Solicitor General of India

Did the Supreme Court of India err in its verdict dated May 27, 2026, on the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls by empowering the Election Commission of India (ECI) to undertake a "limited" inquiry into citizenship for the inclusion of names in, or their exclusion from, the electoral rolls?

Second, can crystallised electoral rolls be unsettled in subsequent elections by deleting names on suspicion?

These questions arise in the context of the electoral rolls in Bihar, published on January 6, 2025, following the ECI's Special Summary Revision (SSR).

On June 24, 2025, the ECI decided to undertake a fresh SIR, beginning with Bihar. Thus, every electoral roll in Bihar between January 1, 2003 (the date of the last SIR in Bihar), and January 6, 2025 (the date of the last SSR, in Bihar), was, in effect, called into question by the ECI. This was unnecessary, as the ECI, in any case, periodically updates the electoral rolls efficiently.

This unusual exercise effectively called into question the electoral rolls used in every election held in Bihar between 2003 and 2025.

Consequently, in Bihar, the SSR dated January 6, 2025, was superseded by the SIR ordered on June 24, 2025.

The ECI's notification dated June 24, 2025, was challenged before the Court. However, the challenge was unsuccessful, with the Court endorsing the ECI's stand in its verdict dated May 27, 2026.

Even before the Court delivered its verdict on May 27, 2026, Assembly elections were held in Bihar in November 2025 and West Bengal in April 2026, following the ECI's SIR exercise, which entailed mass deletions and surprising inclusions of voters. Widespread dissatisfaction prevailed.

The SIR is now being implemented in other States amid protests.

The ECI's powers

The Court's verdict clarified that the ECI has not been empowered to determine citizenship in the "strict sense". The Court held that the power of the ECI affects an "individual's entitlement to be included in the electoral roll". It also held: "It does not, however, operate to divest the individual of claims of citizenship, nor does it foreclose a determination of that question by the competent authority under the Citizenship Act."

With respect, the words "limited" and "strict sense", in the context of an inquiry into citizenship, carry no legal significance, even as *obiter dicta* of the Court.

And the statement that the "power of ECI" "affects" an "individual's entitlement" to be "included in the electoral roll" is not capable of any interpretation other than that the ECI has the power to disenfranchise an existing voter.

This seems to give *carte blanche* to the ECI. Little wonder, then, that the ECI has been proceeding to alter the existing electoral rolls nonchalantly.

The top court must ensure fairness in electoral roll revisions

Enquiry means enquiry, no less; citizenship means citizenship, no less. The ECI's constitutional authority to inquire into citizenship remains contentious. Even a limited inquiry risks exceeding the ECI's electoral mandate. The Court seems to have erred.

While preparing the electoral roll, the ECI's function is limited only to ensuring that every person included is an adult Indian citizen.

The minimum age (18 years) and Indian citizenship are required to be ensured through documents. The ECI's role is strictly ministerial; it has no authority to conduct any inquiry – limited or otherwise – into citizenship. The problem, however, arises because no single document conclusively proves citizenship.

In other words, the Court vested the ECI with unguided discretion to remove a name from an existing electoral roll on the grounds of suspicious Indian citizenship. This amounts to a citizen, whose name was already on the electoral roll as of January 6, 2025, and who was presumed to be an Indian citizen, being disenfranchised by the ECI through the SIR process with effect from July 1, 2025.

Documents, citizenship, deletion

The Court's verdict did not even specify any document that could serve as proof of Indian citizenship.

Significantly, however, paragraph 158 of the Court's verdict reads, *inter alia*: "... it may not be out of place to note that a Ration Card, unlike a Passport or Birth Certificate, is certainly not a conclusive proof of citizenship..." Thus, the Court has ruled that a passport or birth certificate is conclusive proof of citizenship.

Is this why the Ministry of External Affairs, during a press briefing marking Passport Seva Divas on June 24, 2026, made the controversial statement that a passport was merely a travel document and not proof of Indian citizenship?

Could the Court not have, in the exercise of its jurisdiction, specified the documents that prove Indian citizenship? Or, could the Court not have issued a writ of mandamus directing the government to specify the documents that prove Indian citizenship?

The Court did neither, belying the hopes of every Indian citizen whose citizenship is questioned by the ECI.

How does one prove one's Indian citizenship? This question still cannot be answered clearly, yet the ECI can disenfranchise a person who has already voted in the last election merely on the grounds of doubts about their Indian citizenship.

On what basis have electoral rolls in India been prepared since January 26, 1950? How can an electoral roll used in a concluded election be altered on the grounds of suspicion? How can a person be disenfranchised after having voted in the previous election? What is the constitutional benchmark for disenfranchising an existing voter? These are questions that the Court could have considered.

The Supreme Court's powers are extensive under Article 32 (the right to constitutional remedies and the Court's power to issue writs for the enforcement of fundamental rights), Article 141 (the binding nature of the law declared by the Court on all courts in India), Article 142 (the power to pass orders necessary to do complete justice in any cause or matter pending before it), and Article 144 (the obligation of all civil and judicial authorities in India to act in aid of the Court). The Court can surely still set right this legal vacuum by clearly laying down a yardstick for establishing Indian citizenship.

Adulthood and Indian citizenship are the only two – repeat, only two – qualifications required for inclusion in the electoral roll. The Constitution does not prescribe any third mandatory qualification.

The question of disqualification arises only after identifying qualified voters. Only a person who is otherwise qualified can be disqualified.

Article 326 specifies the grounds for disqualification: "non-residence", "unsoundness of mind", "crime", or "corrupt or illegal practice".

The Representation of the People Act, 1950, and the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960, must comply with Article 326 of the Constitution. The overriding principles of natural justice must also be followed when disqualifying a qualified voter.

The name of a qualified voter simply cannot be removed from the electoral roll without a pre-decisional hearing.

Protecting franchise

Free and fair elections are part of the basic structure of India's Constitution. India's potential to emerge as a world power cannot be realised if this foundation and structure is weakened. If an Indian citizen remains on tenterhooks about their right to vote, how can we expect the best from such a citizen?

Although the right to vote has generally been characterised as a statutory right, its exercise is central to representative democracy and the constitutional commitment to free and fair elections. This was metamorphosed from the Court's judgments in *I.C. Golaknath vs State of Punjab* (1967), *Kesavananda Bharati vs State of Kerala* (1973) and *Indira Nehru Gandhi vs Raj Narain* (1975), and continues to hold the field. In the interpretation of this writer, the three judgments, read together, surely elevate the voting right to a basic feature of India's Constitution.

The *Kesavananda Bharati* judgment established that even Parliament's power to amend the Constitution cannot be exercised to destroy or damage its basic structure. The principle continues to safeguard essential constitutional features, including democracy.

My Lords, uphold the right to vote freely, fairly and on time.

India-New Zealand trade ties set to scale new heights



Anant Goenka

President, The Federation of Indian Chambers of Commerce and Industry (FICCI)

In 1953, Sir Edmund Hillary of New Zealand and Tenzing Norgay, the Nepalese-Indian Sherpa mountaineer made history by becoming the first ever to climb Mount Everest. This extraordinary partnership showed what co-operation, trust and determination could achieve, and we are once again set to see the India-New Zealand partnership scale to new heights with the entry into force of the India-New Zealand Free Trade Agreement (FTA).

The India-New Zealand relationship has always been cordial and extends beyond diplomatic ties. Their people share the same passion for cricket, place a high value on domestic traditions and share strong people-to-people ties. In fact, New Zealand is also home to a large Indian diaspora, strengthening relations between the two countries, be it in business, education or cultural exchange. The implementation of the FTA provides another opportunity to leverage these ties for a stronger economic partnership.

Moreover, this FTA is among the recently signed modern FTAs of India which will strengthen its foothold and economic engagement in the Indo-Pacific. The complementary nature of the two economies will help in creating greater opportunities for both countries, not just in trade but also in investments and other areas of economic co-operation.

High potential for trade expansion

India-New Zealand bilateral merchandise trade, which is at $1.2 billion, is way below potential. India caters to just 1.9% of New Zealand's merchandise imports worth $47.5 billion, while China accounts for an over 22% share and Australia, the United States, South Korea and Japan together account for another 33% share.

Most of these major suppliers (excluding the U.S.) already enjoy preferential access to the New Zealand market through respective trade agreements, thus placing Indian exporters at a competitive disadvantage.

The India-New Zealand FTA will strengthen trade, investment and professional mobility

With the India-New Zealand FTA now in force, Indian exporters will also get a level playing field in this market across all tariff lines that have been now offered duty free access.

The immediate gains for India could be significant in the labour-intensive sectors. New Zealand imported nearly $1.2 billion worth of apparel in 2025, but India's share was only around 4%. The elimination of average tariffs of nearly 10% on apparel offers Indian apparel manufacturers and exporters an opportunity to expand their presence in New Zealand. Similar potential exists in sectors such as leather, footwear, home textiles and carpets.

The opportunity is equally important in higher-value manufacturing. New Zealand imports nearly $7 billion worth of machinery and $5.2 billion worth of vehicles and automotive components annually. Yet, India's market share in these categories remains around 1% or lower. The FTA provides an opportunity for Indian engineering and automotive manufacturers to deepen their presence in New Zealand for these products.

Greater market access

The agreement also addresses regulatory barriers, which will create an opportunity for sectors such as pharmaceuticals. India already enjoyed zero-duty access for pharmaceuticals in New Zealand and has held a share of around 5.5% in New Zealand's imports. The FTA includes provisions that facilitate the use of regulatory evaluation and inspection reports from recognised regulators. This can reduce duplicative compliance requirements and further improve market access for Indian pharmaceutical companies.

New Zealand's services imports stood at $24.2 billion in 2024, and India's share was less than 3%. The FTA has provided commitments across 118 services sectors, including IT, professional services, healthcare, education and financial services.

The agreement also creates dedicated pathways for skilled professionals, providing a quota of 5,000 visas at any given time and stay for up to three years.

Additionally, the agreement ensures enhanced student mobility and post-study work opportunities. These will strengthen educational and professional linkages that exist between the two countries.

As part of the agreement, New Zealand will facilitate $20 billion worth of foreign direct investment into India over a 15-year period. This should not be difficult, given India's attractiveness to global investors and New Zealand's capital and technological expertise. India offers significant investment opportunities across sectors, be it high-value manufacturing, renewable energy, agritech, food processing, digital technologies or infrastructure.

Effective utilisation is the key

The outcomes from the FTA will flow only if they are effectively utilised. Indian businesses need targeted market intelligence, stronger distribution networks, regulatory preparedness and commercial partnerships. What is equally important is sustained engagement with New Zealand's investors to develop a pipeline of commercially viable projects.

Through the combined efforts of all stakeholders – the government, the associations as well as the industry on both sides – it should not be difficult to double India-New Zealand bilateral trade by 2030. The agreement has created an enabling framework and success will depend on how these opportunities are converted into exports, investments, jobs and meaningful partnerships.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Weather monitoring

Cyclone Arnab may have had landfall with its impact minimised through effective disaster management but the weather system also draws attention to the operational status of the doppler weather radars at Machilipatnam (MPT), Chennai (CHN) and Karaikal (KKL). This is particularly worrying at a time when there can be changes in the weather system over the Bay of Bengal impacting the eastern coast of peninsular India, southern Odisha and northern Andhra Pradesh. The India Meteorological Department (IMD) must restore these doppler weather radars to full operational status at the earliest and ensure that their data and imagery are made available on the IMD website.

Timely restoration is essential for accurate weather monitoring, cyclone tracking and the dissemination of early warnings to vulnerable coastal communities.

S. Sundararajan,
Chennai

Customer data

The exposure of SBI customers' personal data on the Dark Web raises questions about SBI's cybersecurity safeguards. The apparent reliance on external agencies to detect the exposure needs explanation.

Gopalaswamy J.,
Chennai

Corrections & Clarifications

In a 'Sport' page report, "Lanka drubs Pakistan, eliminates England" (October 28), the 'brief' scores should have read "Pakistan" instead of "England".

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Disinvestment as key economic strategy



Chandrajit Banerjee

Director General, Confederation of Indian Industry

Seven months into 2026-27, the fiscal year has been shaped by global uncertainty, high energy prices and worries over a deficient monsoon. Against this backdrop, disinvestment and asset monetisation have helped in navigating a challenging fiscal year. While receipts were already on course to meet the budget target, the government's approval of the sale of its share in the IDBI Bank on October 14 makes it likely that the target will be exceeded. For the industry and investors, the receipts are a signal of the government's continued commitment to reforms and a larger role for the private sector. This year so far, the disinvestment trajectory has progressed well, even before the IDBI stake sale. According to DIPAM data, the Centre mobilised ₹62,124 crore in April-September 2026 through disinvestment and asset monetisation, of which ₹55,757 crore came from disinvestment. These collections had already reached 78% of the full-year budget target of ₹80,000 crore. With the IDBI proceeds, the collections are to head past the target.

This comes at a time when the government looks to diversify its revenue sources amid rising expenditure commitments. Net tax revenue rose by a modest 3.4% in April-August 2026 and non-tax revenue by 3.2%, while capital expenditure was up by over 18%. Overall, the fiscal deficit has already reached 42% of the budgeted levels which implies a tight balance between revenue shortfalls and spending risks.

However, disinvestment should not be seen merely as a tool for meeting fiscal targets. It is a policy choice aimed at unlocking greater value from public assets, widening public ownership, and improving efficiency and governance through greater market discipline. The 2022 LIC IPO which drew in many first-time retail investors and policyholders remains a prime example.

This was precisely the rationale behind the government's 2021 New Public Sector Enterprise (PSE) Policy which envisages a "bare minimum presence" of PSEs in strategic sectors. Likewise, the National Monetisation Pipeline (NMP) re-engines capital via mature public assets. A target of ₹16.72 lakh crore has been set under NMP 2.0 for FY26-30 after having achieved 90% of its Phase 1 goal.

Demand-based approach

This year, however, until this month, receipts had come mainly through Offer for Sale (OFS) measures which help to broaden ownership but keep the status quo on an enterprise's operations. The strategic sale of the IDBI Bank since Air India in 2022 is an encouraging sign. From an industry perspective, the IDBI sale is more than a one-off sale. It is one of the largest Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) deals in India's financial sector and constitutes as the first step towards a 'Privatisation 2.0' framework. More importantly, this framework is premised on being investor-led, professionally managed and time-bound. Two changes would help to turn into a template.

First, the selection criteria for disinvestments of PSEs should move to a demand-based approach instead of being led by the government. It would work better to first gauge interest across a wider pool and prioritise PSEs that draw strong bids at expected valuations, with structured investor feedback flagging procedural and regulatory hurdles early. Second, a rolling three-year privatisation stream, based on investor interest and the government's strategic priorities, would give investors time for due diligence, which means deeper participation and better price discovery.

Given the fact that privatisation of several PSEs is a long journey, calibrated disinvestment could serve as an interim measure

Text&Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Percentage hike in dearness allowance for govt. employees

3 in per cent. The Cabinet on Wednesday approved a 3% in dearness allowance and dearness relief, benefiting over 1.17 crore Central government employees and pensioners. Announcing the decision, Information and Broadcasting Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said the Union Cabinet headed by Prime Minister has taken the decision to increase the DA and DR ahead of Diwali. PTI

Years after which Air Algerie resumed direct flights to Tripoli

12 Algeria's national carrier Air Algerie resumed direct flights to Tripoli on Wednesday after a halt of nearly 12 years, the internationally recognised Government of National Unity media office said. Many international airlines suspended flights to and from Libya after the 2014 civil war. The airline will initially operate two flights a week, the media office said. REUTERS

Amount approved by Cabinet for PM Viksit Gram Swaraj Yojana

7,395 in ₹ crore. The Union Cabinet on Wednesday approved an allocation of ₹7,395 crore for the Pradhan Mantri Viksit Gram Swaraj Yojana, with Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw calling it a paradigm shift from prescription-based schemes to a model focused on local-level capacity building and planning. PTI

Death toll from army drone strike on a market in Sudan

102 The death toll from an army drone strike on a market in the Sudanese city of Nyala has risen to 102, a rights group said on Wednesday, in the latest deadly attack on the paramilitary stronghold in western Darfur. Sudan's military, at war with the Rapid Support Forces (RSF) since April 2023, regularly strikes Nyala. AFP

Energy support announced by U.K. to 20 million households

100 in £. Britain's Labour government will hand out a direct payment of £100 ($133) to 20 million households to help with soaring energy bills, finance minister John Healey said on Wednesday. The measure is designed "to take pressure off in the coldest months and see people through to the spring", Mr. Healey said. AFP

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Is GRAP enough to curb pollution?

What is GRAP, and why is it imposed in Delhi-NCR? Which factors worsen air pollution during winter? What restrictions are imposed under Stage I of GRAP? What additional curbs come into effect under Stages III and IV? Has GRAP consistently improved Delhi's winter air quality?

EXPLAINER

Nikhil M. Babu

The story so far:

As air quality in Delhi worsened to the 'poor' category in the national capital, the Commission for Air Quality Management in NCR and adjoining areas (CAQM) on last Wednesday announced Stage 1 of the Graded Response Action Plan (GRAP) in Delhi and the National Capital Region (NCR) to bring down the pollution.

Every winter, air pollution spikes in Delhi-NCR and many parts of the larger Indo-Gangetic Plains, mainly due to meteorological factors such as lower wind speeds and a drop in temperature. Pollution from stubble burning in October and November and firecrackers during the festive season adds to emissions from vehicles and dust, further worsening air quality.

What is GRAP?

The Graded Response Action Plan (GRAP) is a set of short-term emergency measures to reduce air pollution and is divided into four stages. The CAQM announces the different stages, depending on the level of pollution recorded or forecast for the near future.

Whenever the CAQM announces GRAP, it directs State governments to implement the restrictions with "immediate effect" in entire Delhi and also in the NCR districts of Haryana, Uttar Pradesh, and Rajasthan. The restrictions will come into effect on the ground when the respective State governments pass orders to implement them.

As per law, the State governments are bound to implement directions of the CAQM and the Commission can initiate legal action against officers not following its directions.

The GRAP was first notified by the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change in January 2017, pursuant to Supreme Court directions to provide for graded measures corresponding to different levels of air quality.

Initially, the GRAP was implemented by the EPCA (Environmental Pollution (Prevention and Control) Authority), which was formed in 1998 by the Supreme Court and was responsible for the management and coordination of air pollution in Delhi and the NCR.

But the EPCA was not backed by a statute, and experts had raised the issue that it lacked the teeth to act against authorities that did not follow its orders.

In 2021, the CAQM replaced the EPCA, and since then it has been implementing the GRAP. Over the years, at times after coming under attack from the Supreme Court, the GRAP has gone through multiple revisions, making it more stringent.

What now?

Most of the actions under Stage 1 are directing authorities to strictly implement existing norms related to air pollution.

The four stages of GRAP are: Stage I - 'Poor' Air Quality (Delhi AQI ranging between 201-300), Stage II - 'Very Poor' Air Quality (Delhi AQI ranging between 301-400), Stage III - 'Severe' Air Quality (Delhi AQI ranging between 401-450), Stage IV - 'Severe +' Air Quality (Delhi AQI > 450).

A higher AQI indicates worsening air quality.

Though the GRAP can be imposed any time during the year, the higher stages of GRAP are mostly invoked during winter as air quality deteriorates.

Under GRAP 1, the CAQM has directed Delhi and its neighbouring States to ensure that diesel generator sets are not used as a regular source of power supply, among other measures.

It's under Stage III and Stage IV of the GRAP that more severe actions kick in.

For instance, under Stage III, the CAQM announces a ban on construction and demolition activities in Delhi-NCR and a ban on the plying of BS III petrol and BS IV or below emission standard diesel Light Motor Vehicles (LMVs) or cars in Delhi and in the High Vehicle Density (HVD) districts of Gurugram, Faridabad, Sonipat, Ghaziabad and Gautam Buddh Nagar.

Similarly, under Stage IV, the ban on construction becomes even more severe with fewer exemptions, and there is a ban on the entry of trucks into Delhi, except for trucks that are BS-VI, electric, CNG, and LNG. Other measures are also taken under both the stages.



Winter woes: People walk along Kartavya Path as haze envelops Rashtrapati Bhavan; every winter, air pollution spikes in Delhi-NCR and many parts of the larger Indo-Gangetic Plains, mainly due to meteorological factors. ANI

Does GRAP actually help?

The GRAP aims to cut down the sources of pollution for a short time when the air pollution is very high, so that the air quality improves, but it is not a long-term strategy.

According to an analysis released on Thursday (October 22, 2026) by the Centre for Research on Energy and Clean Air (CREA), a Finland-based non-profit research organisation, there has been "no consistent" improvement in Delhi's winter air quality over the past four years, despite the imposition of GRAP.

"Delhi's winter AQI (Air Quality Index) has fluctuated over the past four years, with no consistent improvement. The mean AQI rose from 280 in winter 2022-23 to 304 in 2023-24, fell to 285 in 2024-25 and increased again to 295 in 2025-26. The median AQI followed a similar pattern, rising from 294 to 324, falling to 289 and then increasing to 305," CREA said in a statement.

Delhi's winter air quality has not followed a consistent downward trend since the 2022 revision of GRAP, and the mean and median AQI for the latest winter were both higher than in 2022-23, said Manoj Kumar, an analyst at CREA.



Vehicles pass as an anti-smog gun sprays water to curb air pollution in central Delhi, where GRAP-I measures are in effect, in New Delhi on Tuesday. ANI

What is different this winter?

In addition to GRAP, the Delhi government in June this year issued a gazette notification of a set of restrictions for winter months. But unlike GRAP, these restrictions will come into play irrespective of the air quality at a particular time.

For instance, as per the June 23 notification, from November 1 to January 31, there will be a ban on the plying of all non-Delhi-registered motor vehicles below BSVI emission standards in the national capital. However, electric, CNG, emergency, and sovereign duty vehicles are exempted from it.

Similarly, as per the notification, from November 1 to February 28, existing parking charges at authorised parking sites will be doubled to discourage use of private vehicles, except for parking spaces owned and managed by the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC).

But if there is any conflict between the GRAP orders and the June 23 notification by the Delhi government, the GRAP will take precedence.

With the additional restrictions imposed by the Delhi government, this winter is set to see one of the highest levels of government action in the recent past in Delhi, at least on paper.

THE GIST

- GRAP imposes increasingly stringent restrictions as Delhi's air quality worsens, from 'Poor' to 'Severe+', but its measures are short-term
- Delhi's winter air quality has shown no consistent improvement over the past four years despite GRAP, with the mean AQI rising from 280 in 2022-23 to 295 in 2025-26, according to CREA
- The Delhi government has introduced additional curbs, including a ban on non-Delhi-registered vehicles below BS-VI standards and doubled parking charges at authorised sites, regardless of air quality levels

KEYWORD

How neoliberalism turned the world against its young

The rise in youth unrest stems from failures of neoliberal capitalism, which has weakened public welfare and worsened unemployment; as falling wages undermine consumption and investment, young people face fewer jobs, rising education costs and an economic system that prioritises profits

Rohit Azad
Indranil Chowdhury

France is in turmoil. And Albania. And Spain. Even India. As were Bangladesh or Sri Lanka earlier. The list goes on. While the specific demands may vary, one thing is common across these mobilisations: the young are on the streets. Why are the young angry the world over? In this piece, we look at the first world, in particular the G7 bloc, to understand why indeed.

France is a good example to understand what is happening in the global North. Emmanuel Macron, the antagonist according to the students in the French protests, has been in power since May 14, 2017.

Over his almost a decade-long reign, France has witnessed severe economic problems – high unemployment, low growth, rising cost of living, falling real wages and severe cutbacks in public expenditure. It is not a happenstance, therefore, that the spark that lit this protest was the lack of resources and staff at the Lycée Antoine-de-Saint-Exupéry in Créteil (a suburb of Paris).

At the heart of it all is the neoliberal economic model, which aggressively enforced reducedpublic expenditure in general, and welfare spending in particular. Whether it's Macron in France or Biden/Clinton in the U.S. or Starmer in the U.K., those championing this economic model have either been ousted or are on the brink of losing power.

Crisis of unemployment

The system has angered young people in particular. Although overall unemployment rates have remained high since the pandemic, youth unemployment rates in G7 countries are now almost twice as high, if not higher (Chart 1). Generation Z (Gen Z), which has taken to the streets, comprises those born between 1997 and 2012, putting them in the 14-29 age group today. That cohort overlaps with the age group 15-29 shown in the chart.

As is well known, unlike countries in the Global South, developed countries are ageing societies, with the share of young people in their populations declining over time. Yet, as their relative population share shrinks, youth unemployment continues to rise. While fewer young people enter the labour force each year, many more join the ranks of the unemployed. Clearly, the problem is not an excess supply of labour but a lack of demand for it.

What causes unemployment?

As is the case with most economics questions, this also has broadly two sides – orthodox and heterodox. The orthodox side believes unemployment has to do with high rigid wages, inflexible labour markets, lack of a skilled labour force, most of which puts the blame, directly or indirectly, on the working class itself for its misfortune.

The heterodox side, in sharp contrast, argues it is the decision of the capitalist class to employ or not to employ workers which determines unemployment in the economy.

Consider a typical labour market – demand for labour comes from the capitalists; supply of it comes from the workers. Capitalists would like to employ as many as they could to maximise their profits. The lower the wage rate, the higher the profits, and so the demand for labour rises as wages fall (downward-sloping demand curve in graph 1). The supply curve, on the other hand, is upward sloping because as the wages rise, more workers join the labour force. The intersection of the two (point E) represents full employment – those who seek work at that wage get it.

When the economy gets stuck at point A – demand for labour (point A) is less than its supply (point B) – the economy has involuntary unemployment (equal to the gap AB). But what stops the economy from reaching point E?

Orthodox economics would tell us the wages are way too high, for which either the labour unions or rigid labour market legislation (against 'hire and fire', for example) are responsible. To be sure, there are other theories like the 'efficiency wages' which explain why the economy remains stuck at A.

The heterodox approaches argue that labour demand depends on the level of demand for goods and services in the economy. Demand, under 'pure' capitalism, consists of investment and consumption (see (A) in box 1). Let's assume, for simplicity, workers consume all their wages and capitalists save their entire profits. Consumption demand would then depend on employment (wage bill), so it cannot be the cause of unemployment. The real cause, therefore, is investment. The less the capitalists decide to invest, less will be the total induced demand for goods and services, and the lower will be the need to employ workers.

It is the capitalists, not the workers, who are responsible for unemployment.

But why can the State not fill the demand gap through fiscal expansion and ensure perpetual full employment? After all, it is a win-win both for the workers and capitalists – those willing to work get work and profits rise with fiscal expansion (see (B) in box 1). That was the Keynesian route out of the capitalist crisis.

In his famous essay on 'Political Aspects of Full Employment', Michal Kalecki argued against this naïveté of Keynesianism because "under a regime of permanent full employment, 'the sack' would cease to play its role as a disciplinary measure".

The rise of the neoliberal world order in response to the 'New Deal' of the 1950s and the 1960s mirrors Kalecki's statement word for word.

Rise of neoliberalism

What was the 'New Deal'? In response to the Great Depression of the 1930s – the deepest and the longest unemployment and profitability crisis capitalism has ever faced – a new world order emerged which argued for larger governments to push the economy towards point E. This created what is called the Golden Age of Capitalism (1945-1973), which recorded the highest ever rates of growth in the global North (see chart 2). But it came along with a class alignment in favour of the working class, whose shares in the total economic pie kept rising throughout the first world (see chart 3). The 'sack' was losing its role as a disciplinary measure.

A counter-revolution, led by the economist Milton Friedman, broke out, which sought to bring the 'sack' back. Inflation that broke out between 1973 and 1980 – the pretext of this countercharge – was cost-push (oil price shocks), and had absolutely nothing to do with larger governments. Despite that, the monetarist countercharge argued that government meddling with a 'natural' state of affairs under capitalism caused this unprecedented inflation. Capitalism, on its own, produces full employment and so let the markets do their job, it was argued and that governments had no business to be in business.

Ronald Reagan in the U.S. and Margaret Thatcher in the U.K. put the monetarist doctrine into practice, which has since come to be known as the neoliberal world order. With the withdrawal of the welfare state, large-scale union busting and 'flexible' labour markets, the balance of class forces was restored in favour of the capitalists. The share of the working class in the economic pie nose-dived and the advances of the Golden Age were reversed (see chart 3).

Crisis of underconsumption

A fall in the wage share, however, comes with its own problems. What makes sense for an individual capitalist – a fall in wage cost – harms the capitalist class as a whole, as far as profits are concerned. It happens for two different reasons. One, a dollar's fall in wages means an equivalent fall in consumption demand, which means a fall in profits of capitalists selling these consumer goods. Two, such a fall in consumption leads to a second-degree fall in investment in the next period because why would the capitalists build more factories if the existing ones become idle? Karl Marx called it the crisis of underconsumption. Chart 3, seen together with Chart 2, is this crisis in action.

This fall in growth creates a crisis of unemployment, which is further aggravated by capital's bid to increase its profit margins by replacing workers with machines. It is a double whammy for the youth – low growth, which is labour-displacing. Artificial Intelligence (AI) could potentially aggravate this crisis.

Last but not the least, when workers are led to believe that their lack of skills is to blame for their unemployment, they turn to education to upgrade their skills. But neoliberalism ensures that education is turned into a money-making industry worldwide.

The cost of education has been skyrocketing under the neoliberal phase (see chart 4).

Getting a degree becomes more expensive, and those who manage to get it don't necessarily land themselves remunerative jobs. Who can blame the youth, therefore, for resisting this system rigged against them by design?

(The authors are a part of the DevMac (Development Macroeconomics) network, which seeks pluralism in Economics)

A burden on the young

Neoliberalism has reversed past economic gains, leaving the young with fewer opportunities and greater insecurity

Chart 1: Wrath of the unemployed Gen Z

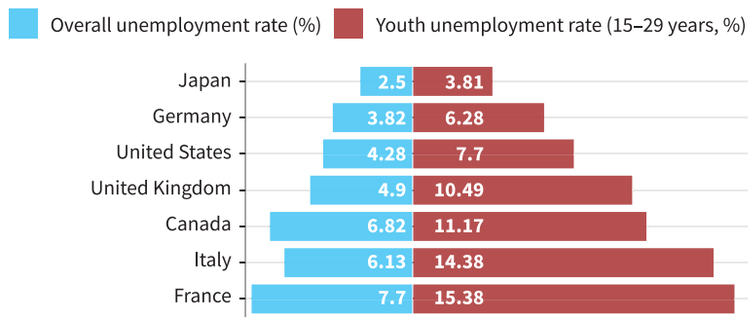


Chart: Azad & Chowdhury. Source: Authors' calculations. International Labour Organisation (ILO), International Labour Organisation Statistics (ILOSTAT)

Chart 2: Growth rates for the G7 bloc (Period-wise CAGR in %)

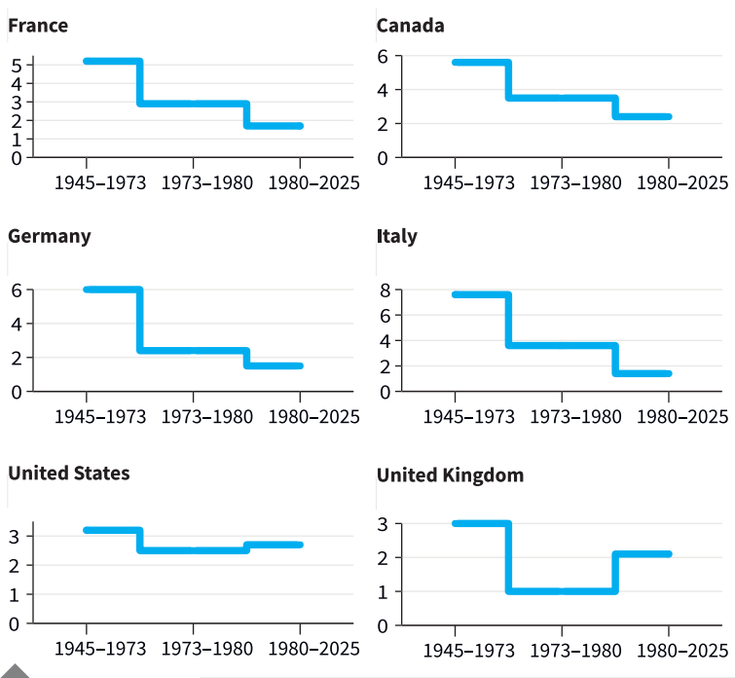
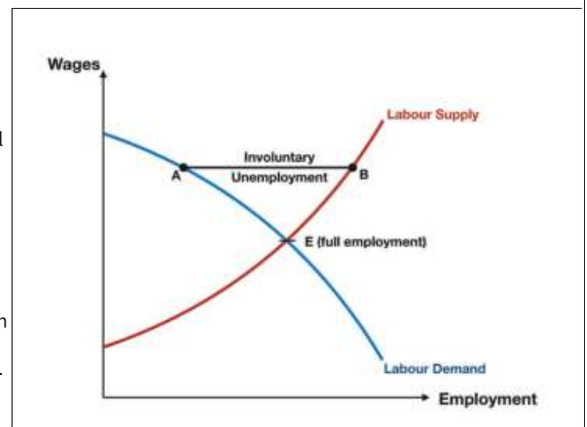
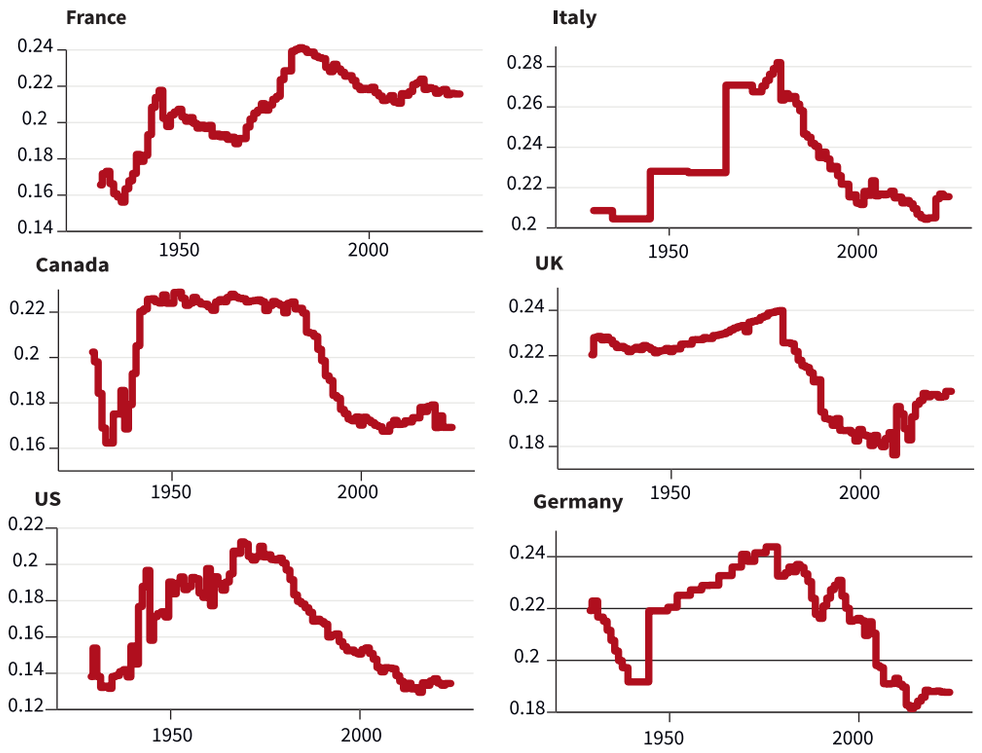


Chart: Azad & Chowdhury. Source: Authors' calculations. U.S. Bureau of Economic Analysis (BEA). Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis (FRED). Institut national de la statistique et des etudes economiques (INSEE). Federal Statistical Office (Destatis). Italian National Institute of Statistics (ISTAT), Istat-Data. Cabinet Office, Economic and Social Research Institute (ESRI). Statistics Canada. World Bank, World Development Indicators. OECD, National Accounts at a Glance



(A) A "pure" capitalist economy:
Wage bill / Wage x Employment + Profits = Consumption + Investment
(B) With state intervention:
Wage bill + Profits = Consumption + Investment + Government Expenditure
Profits = Investment + Government Expenditure

Chart 3: Share of the poorest half in the total income of G7 countries



Some data points for Italy and Germany are not available, so a connecting line through the available data points has been generated for uniformity Chart: Azad & Chowdhury. Source: World Inequality Database

Chart 4: Rising cost of education in G7

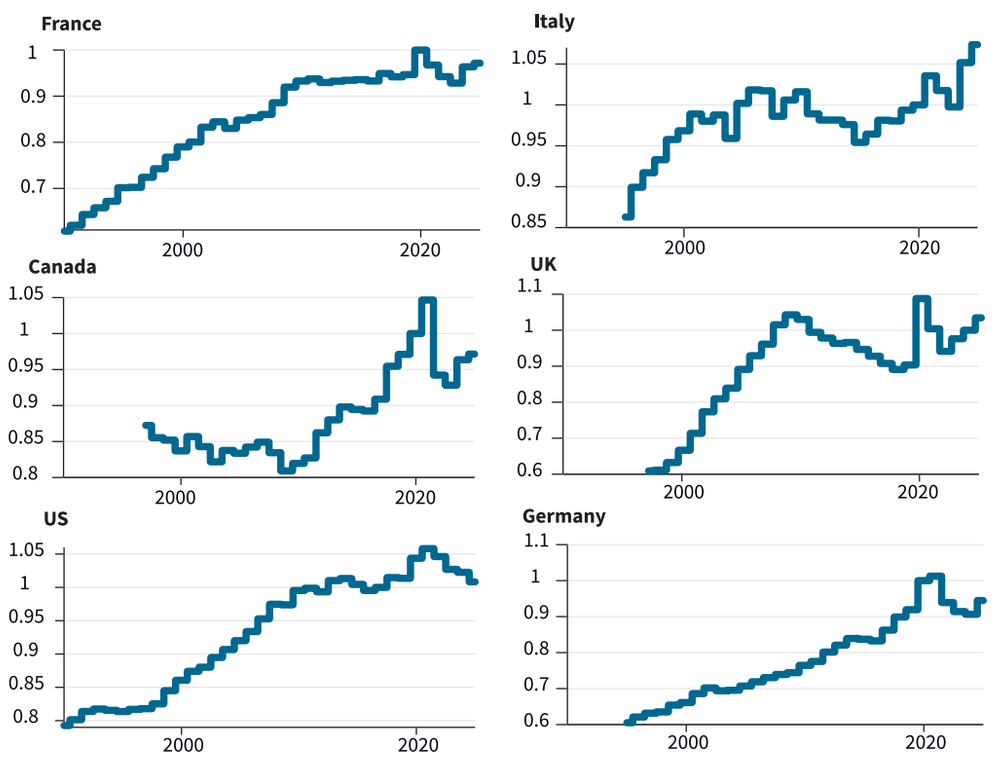


Chart: Azad & Chowdhury. Source: Authors' calculations. U.S. Bureau of Economic Analysis (BEA), NIPA, republished by FRED. Statistics Canada. Eurostat. OECD National Accounts. World Bank, World Development Indicators. Economic and Social Research Institute, Cabinet Office of Japan. UK Economic Accounts (UKEA).



In rage: France has witnessed some of the worst economic problems — high unemployment, low growth, rising cost of living, falling real wages, severe cutbacks in public expenditure. AFP

INBRIEF



City Union Bank Q2 net profit rises 26% to ₹416 crore

City Union Bank on Wednesday reported a 26% rise in net profit at ₹416 crore for the second quarter ended September 2026. The bank had a net profit of ₹329 crore in the July-September quarter of last fiscal. Interest income grew 27% to ₹2,092 crore in the second quarter of FY27, up from ₹1,653 crore in the corresponding quarter of FY26. Net non-performing assets improved to 0.48% in the September quarter of FY27, from 0.90% in the year-earlier period. PTI

Hyundai Motor India Q2 net profit falls 24% to ₹1,196 crore

Hyundai Motor India Ltd. (HMIL) reported a 24% year-on-year (YoY) decline in Q2 standalone net profit to ₹1,196 crore, as against ₹1,572 crore a year earlier, as elevated commodity prices weighed on profitability. Revenue, however, rose 19% YoY to ₹20,696 crore. "Commodity headwinds weighed on profitability, however operating leverage, healthy mix and cost reduction initiatives helped improve EBITDA margin sequentially," HMIL said in a filing.

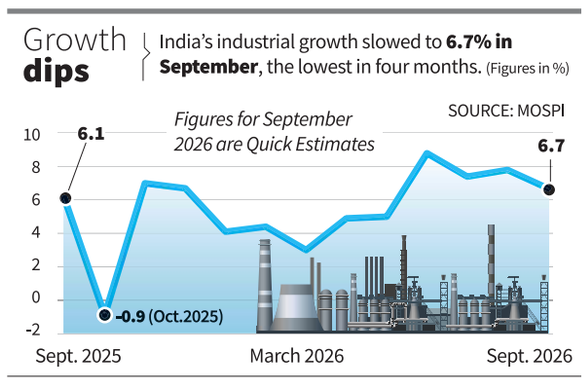
GAIL India to invest $63 mn in heating unit at Ratnagiri

GAIL India is investing ₹6 billion ($63.1 million) to build a heating unit at its Ratnagiri LNG terminal to help it gasify the super-chilled fuel, the company's business development director told reporters on Wednesday. The facility, due to be completed by June 2027, will enable the company to run the LNG terminal at its full capacity of 5 MTPA, R.K. Singhal said. The facility is operating at about 50% capacity as the heating unit is not ready, Mr. Singhal said. REUTERS

Industrial growth eases to 4-month low of 6.7% in Sept.

Growth in 10 out of the 11 sectors covered in the index was slower in Sept. than it was in August; 8 of 23 manufacturing sub-segments, with weight of 22.2% in IIP, recorded double-digit expansion

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI



Growth in industrial production slowed to a four-month low of 6.7% in September 2026, with nearly every sector slowing as compared to the previous month, the latest official data shows.

Data on the Index of Industrial Production (IIP), released by the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI) on Wednesday, showed that growth in 10 out of the 11 sectors covered was slower in September than it was in August.

The IIP had grown 7.8% in August 2026 as per the revised data.

"The deceleration was broad-based, with all the four sectors [by economic activity] recording a deterioration in their year-on-year performance between these months," Aditi Nayar, chief economist at ICRA said. Ms. Nayar also noted that, while the growth in manufacturing output eased to 7.6% in September 2026 from 8.6% in August 2026, partly on account of an unfavourable base, this growth remained "quite healthy".

"As many as eight of the 23 manufacturing sub-segments, with a weight of 22.2% in the IIP, recorded a double-digit expansion in September 2026," she pointed out.

Auto sector-driven

According to Madan Sabnavis, chief economist at the Bank of Baroda, manufacturing growth was driven by the automobile sector and electrical machinery, with some help coming from rubber products, computers, electronics, and non-metallic machinery.

LTM launches GCC Origin as IT firms race to serve global capability centres

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI


Venu Lambu

LTM, formerly LTIMindtree, has launched GCC Origin, a dedicated business unit to help enterprises establish, operate, scale and transform global capability centres (GCCs) in India, as technology services companies step up efforts to tap growing demand for such centres.

The move formalises LTM's GCC-as-a-Service offering, launched in July 2025, into a standalone business with dedicated leadership, sales and delivery teams, specialist expertise and significant investment. Shailendra Singh will lead the unit and report to Venu Lambu, CEO and Managing Director, LTM.

The launch reflects a broader industry trend, with Indian IT services companies and workforce solutions providers developing specialised offerings to help multinational corporations establish and expand their technology and business operations in the country.

Quess Corp launched its GCC-as-a-Service offering, Origint, in June 2025. Infosys unveiled its AI-First GCC Model in November 2025, while Tata Consultancy Services launched its Global Value & Innovation Centres business unit in June 2026. Cognizant, HCLTech, Wipro, Accenture and Tech Mahindra are also targeting the market through dedicated practices and services.

GCC Origin integrates strategy, artificial intelligence (AI), technology, talent, infrastructure, operations and ecosystem partnerships.

Its services include site selection, workplace and infrastructure development, operational readiness and turnkey facilities across Tier 1 and Tier 2 cities.

The unit will leverage BlueVerse, LTM's agentic AI ecosystem, to help enterprises establish new GCCs and transform existing centres into AI-native operations.

Its offerings span strategy and advisory, talent acquisition and development, AI agents and studios, automation, business operations and the transfer of capabilities and operational ownership.

Clients can opt for the entire GCC lifecycle or individual services through models such as Assisted GCC, Build-Operate-Transform-Transfer, Virtual GCC, joint ventures, staff augmentation and Hire-Operate-Transfer.

India and Mexico to start trade deal talks

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

India and Mexico on Wednesday signed the Terms of Reference (ToR) to start negotiations on a trade deal between the two countries, the government announced following the signing in Mexico.

The signing of the ToR follows an understanding reached between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Mexican President Claudia Sheinbaum during their meeting on the sidelines of the G7 Summit in Canada in June 2025.

"Mexico and India take an important step towards strengthening their economic and trade relations with the signing of the Terms of Reference for negotiations on a Preferential Trade Agreement (PTA), which establish the framework, scope, modalities and roadmap for negotiations aimed at creating new economic opportunities for both countries," the government said in a release. Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal represented the Indian side.

Jio Platforms debuts with a 21% premium

Gowri Lakshmi
MUMBAI

Jio Platforms Ltd (JPL) made a strong stock market debut on Wednesday, listing at ₹1,358, a 21.36% premium over its issue price of ₹1,119. The stock extended gains to close at ₹1,417.50, up nearly 4.4% from its listing price.

The debut came amid a weak broader market. The Sensex plunged 995 points in early trade before recovering to close 352.64 points, or 0.48%, lower at 73,246.03. The Nifty settled below 22,700 as rising crude oil prices, selling in IT stocks and caution ahead of the U.S. Federal Reserve's policy decision weighed on sentiment.

"My heart overflows with gratitude. Gratitude to every individual, every institutional investor in India and abroad, who made our IPO a blockbuster success," Akash Ambani, JPL's MD, said at the NSE listing ceremony. The ₹32,000-crore IPO was subscribed more than 22 times, attracting demand exceeding ₹7.4 lakh crore.

'India requires $220 billion for green power transition by FY30'

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

India's renewable energy sector will need $220 billion in investment between FY27 and FY30, spanning generation, transmission, manufacturing and emerging green technologies, Santosh Sarangi, Secretary, Union Ministry of New and Renewable Energy, said.

Another senior official told reporters at the curtain-raiser for the Bharat Renewable Energy Summit & Expo 2026 that solar energy would account for $70-75 billion of the requirement followed by transmission infrastructure at $40-45 billion, wind energy at $25-30 billion and green hydrogen at $20-25 billion. Manufacturing will require another $15-20 billion, the official said.

The sector attracted about $64 billion in private investment between July 2024 and June 2026, including $6.2 billion in foreign direct investment. The Centre infused $6 billion to support renewable energy development.

Mr. Sarangi said Indian green hydrogen developers got orders to supply 5.5 lakh tonne until 2026. The Ministry is developing a framework for geothermal exploration rights similar to hydrocarbon sector.

L&T eyes ₹15 lakh-cr. order book by 2031

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Larsen & Toubro (L&T) is aiming at almost doubling order book to ₹15 lakh crore by 2031 on expansion in energy, electrolysers, semiconductors, data centres and manufacturing, president and whole-time director (finance) R Shankar Raman said.

The engineering and construction conglomerate is also focusing on renewables, hydrogen, automation and strengthening its services business to drive long-term growth.

"Manufacturing thrust, consolidation and automating construction infrastructure, making the new areas of renewable and hydrogen work and pushing the services business forward, all of these together, will make the company far far stronger from what it is today by 2031," Mr. Raman told journalists.

TVS Motor decides to demerge consumer finance businesses

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

TVS Motor Company plans to demerge consumer finance and related businesses into a separate holding company, allowing it to sharpen focus on mobility while giving financial services operations greater strategic autonomy.

The announcement came as the two- and three-wheeler maker reported record quarterly revenue of ₹17,103 crore for the September quarter of FY27, up 44% year-on-year. Net profit surged 52% to ₹1,377 crore.



Q2 net surged to ₹1,377 crore

The board okayed a Composite Scheme of Arrangement under which investors would get an equal number of shares in the resulting firm as they hold in TVS Motor. The revamp is to boost capital allocation and allow finance unit to pursue opportunities across consumer finance and related sectors.

Easier registration for small sellers on e-com platforms from Nov. 1

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Small sellers on e-commerce platforms will be able to declare the platform's warehouse as their Principal Place of Business (PPoB) for supplying products in multiple states from November 1.

The Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs (CBIC) has notified changes in Central GST rules, allowing small sellers, who do not pass on input tax credit of more than ₹2.5 lakh per month, to obtain registration in any other state or UT where the person has no physical presence, by declaring a warehouse of an electronic commerce operator in that state or UT as principal place of business. A seller would need to have a physical presence in one home state, where physical verification and Aadhaar authentication would be completed, while registrations in other states could be obtained with the consent of the e-commerce platform without further involvement of a tax officer.

The changes in CGST rules were approved by the GST Council in its October 8 meeting, and will be effective November 1, 2026.

The move could enable around 9.5 lakh small sellers to access the national market without having to establish physical offices in every state where their goods are stored, while creating greater tax parity across competing e-commerce business models.

Such small sellers would have to apply in Form GST REG-01 and declare the Goods and Services Tax Identification Number (GSTIN) obtained on their Permanent Account Number (PAN) in the home state where the seller has physical presence. The application would be forwarded to the e-commerce operator concerned for their consent to be given within seven working days.

HCLTech launches AI-powered nano GCC offering on Amazon Web Services

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI



For existing GCCs, the model envisages a hub-and-spoke structure anchored at HCLTech's Lucknow campus. REUTERS

HCLTech has partnered with Amazon Web Services (AWS) to launch an AI-powered nano Global Capability Centre (GCC) offering, aimed at helping enterprises transition from AI experimentation to business deployment through smaller, focused operations.

The offering, part of HCLTech's GCC 360 solution suite, combines its GCC advisory expertise and AI platforms, including AI Force, with AWS cloud infrastructure and agentic AI services such as Amazon Bedrock, Kiro and AWS Transform.

Unlike traditional GCCs built around scale and broad mandates, the nano GCC model centres on compact, product-focused teams, AI-enabled workflows and phased expansion. Its capabilities span AI-native engineering, autonomous IT operations, advanced data analytics and intelligent business operations, with responsible AI governance integrated into the model.

HCLTech will lead the design and implementation of the operating model, while AWS will provide joint go-to-market support and access to its cloud and AI services.

The offering targets enterprises with existing GCCs seeking AI-led transformation without disrupting conventional operations, as well as mid-market companies looking to establish an in-country presence without the commitment of a large-scale setup.

For existing GCCs, the model envisages a hub-and-spoke structure anchored at HCLTech's Lucknow campus. Delivery will be supported by the company's India-based delivery organisation and its Centre of Excellence in Lucknow.

"The nano GCC model is at an inflection point. What began as a cost and talent strategy is becoming the primary engine for enterprise AI capability building. The question for most organisations is no longer whether to build AI-native operations, but how to do it without the drag of legacy setup models. The nano GCC is our answer to that urgency," said Kiran Cherukuri, Executive Vice-President and Global GCC Practice Leader at HCLTech.

Prabhakar Appana, Senior Vice-President and Global Head of the AWS Ecosystem Business Unit at HCLTech, said the offering would provide enterprises with a faster, lower-risk route to AI-native operations.

"By combining HCLTech's GCC expertise and AI capabilities with the scalability, security and agentic AI services of AWS, the nano GCC offering gives enterprises a faster, lower-risk path to building AI-native operations. It enables organisations to start with focused use cases, demonstrate measurable value and scale confidently as their business needs evolve," he said.

Amit Anshu, Head of GSI and IT Business at AWS India and South Asia, said enterprises across Asia-Pacific wanted to build AI-native operations quickly and confidently.

Sonowal, HD Hyundai chief discuss $4 bn Thoothukudi Shipyard

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI


Sarbananda Sonowal

Union Minister of Ports, Shipping and Waterways Sarbananda Sonowal on Wednesday met Chairman of HD Hyundai Chung Ki-sun in Seoul and discussed development of the proposed $4 billion greenfield shipyard at Thoothukudi in Tamil Nadu, according to an official statement.

The meeting took place during Mr. Sonowal's four-day visit to South Korea, which is focused on deepening cooperation in shipbuilding and the wider maritime industry. HD Korea Shipbuilding & Offshore Engineering (HD KSOE), HD Hyundai's shipbuilding arm, reiterated its intent to participate as a primary strategic investor, and the project partners expressed their shared intent to take the shipyard forward, the release said.

"A joint working group (JWG) will now oversee project development, the two sides will work towards agreeing a joint venture structure, and the detailed project report (DPR) is expected to be finalised within six months," it added.

Speaking at the meeting, Mr. Sonowal said, "We have a clear mandate to scale up our work together.

The MoU we signed on 20 April, 2026 is the bedrock of what we want to build together in Thoothukudi, Tamil Nadu."

"A greenfield shipyard with $4 billion investment is a massive milestone, and we are completely committed to backing it," the Minister added.

China's new export curbs draw a line around its AI crown jewels



Fine print: Draft rules distinguish between foreign clients using Chinese AI and foreign firms getting models. REUTERS

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters
SINGAPORE/BEIJING

China's proposed artificial intelligence export curbs will push a business model favoured by Beijing and the industry's biggest players: keeping valuable technology at home while selling access to it abroad as rivalry with the U.S. intensifies.

The draft rules, released on October 16, distinguish between foreign customers using Chinese AI services and foreign companies obtaining the models, data or expertise needed to operate or reproduce them independently.

"The structure the leadership prefers, with IP and R&D kept onshore and operations and access sold abroad, is the one the market was already converging on," said Alfredo Montufar-Helu, Beijing-based MD at consultancy Ankura.

The new rules would broadly allow overseas users to access Chinese AI through websites and cloud platforms while subjecting some transfers of underlying technology or deployments overseas to government approval.

That distinction matters for developers that rely on computing facilities abroad, where they can gain access to powerful chips constrained by U.S. export restrictions on China.

The broader regulatory oversight adds to the already uncertain macro-environment facing China's tech giants and startups, who are currently wrestling with a meltdown of Chinese AI and semiconductor stocks.

Guidelines on implementation
China is expected to adopt the proposals by the end of the year and issue guidelines on implementation later, according to a source familiar with the matter who requested anonymity because the timetable was not public.

The draft would add 23 AI-related technologies to a list banning or restricting their export, including advanced models, agents that carry out tasks with limited human direction and technology used to design chips and run vast computing facilities. A temporary requirement to register certain transfers took effect immediately.

Firms want clarification
The rules could impact how leading Chinese AI firms run advanced models on overseas data centres, structure international partnerships and handle foreign investment or ownership of AI assets. DeepSeek, Moonshot and Z.AI offer models to overseas customers through websites or cloud platforms. Some Chinese AI developers have also turned to overseas computing facilities to access advanced chips restricted from export to China. Nvidia's most advanced processors cannot be exported to China under U.S. restrictions.

Researchers at major Chinese AI labs are seeking clarification on whether they can train or run their most advanced models on foreign-owned overseas servers, according to a person briefed on the matter who declined to be identified because the discussions were not public. In a worst-case scenario, developers might have to maintain separate domestic and overseas versions of the same downloadable model, the person said.

Liu Jing, a senior partner at Beijing Dacheng Law Offices who participated in consultations with policymakers, told *Reuters* companies also wanted more clarity on the tests used to determine which models would be covered.

The draft specifies three tests: the computing work needed to train a model, with a threshold of 10 to the power of 26 calculations; its size, measured by at least 2 trillion parameters; or placing among the world's top 10 in certain assessments of performance, use or efficiency.

Parameters are the numerical settings a model learns during training. The ranking test could cover smaller systems that excel at specialised tasks, but the draft does not identify which rankings would count.

Size of models
Chinese law firm Han Kun, in an analysis, also questioned how regulators would count the size of models that activate only some of their components for each task, and said one proposed chip-design provision could reach beyond the most advanced products because it lacks a minimum performance requirement.

A new ore-der: can Mineral Exchanges transform India's mining economy?

India's proposed mineral exchanges aim at fixing price transparency, boost liquidity and create credible local benchmarks for ores like iron ore; Lithium, nickel, cobalt, graphite and rare earth elements may figure in the subsequent phases as India expands local mining, processing capacity

NEWS ANALYSIS

Santosh V. Perumal

In less than 14 months, an idea to bring India's fragmented market onto a common electronic platform germinated from legislative intent to a formal regulatory framework and finally, setting the stage for establishing mineral exchanges. The proposed exchanges cobbled an ambitious plan, ensuring a transparent marketplace where representative prices reflect demand and supply rather than relying on fragmented negotiations and auctions. India's mining sector has historically faced challenges on price transparency, fragmented markets and information asymmetry.

Seeking to effectively address the issues in the sector in a holistic way, the latest institutional reforms may result in the enhanced industrial competitiveness, investment flows and supply-chain resilience.

The proposed exchange framework will spell out how miners sell output, how manufacturers procure raw materials and how India establishes credible local reference prices for industrial minerals.

The move comes at a time when minerals are fast turning crucial to the country's economic security and also when India is increasingly focusing on infrastructure, renewable energy, electric vehicles, defence equipment, advanced manufacturing and clean energy.



Right pricing: Small and medium miners often have limited bargaining power. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

Power trading solutions provider PTC India this week said its board has approved incorporation of a wholly-owned subsidiary with an investment of ₹65 crore to set up and operate a mineral exchange. MCXI (Multi Commodity Exchange of India) has established MCX Mineral Exchange of India Limited as a wholly owned subsidiary.

Exchange origin
The amendments to the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Act provided the legal bedrock for the exchange, paving way for coal exchanges, marking a paradigm shift in marketing by moving from the traditional "one-to-many" sales model to a competitive "many-to-many" trading platform. Section 18B of the MMDR Act provides for promoting markets, including trading of minerals via mineral exchanges.

> Iron ore, in which India has a considerable say, is seen as a strong contender for the first major contract because it combines scale, liquidity and industrial importance

The Ministry of Mines subsequently framed the Mineral Exchange Rules, 2026. The regulatory responsibility will rest with the Indian Bureau of Mines (IBM) under the Ministry of Mines. The government has designated IBM as the authority to register and regulate mineral exchanges for minerals other than coal, lignite and atomic minerals.

Need for exchanges
Small and medium miners often have limited bargaining power when compared with large buyers.

The biggest advantage will be the creation of market-driven mineral prices which can improve cost planning, especially in industries such as steel, aluminium, cement and renewable energy equipment manufacturing.

Digital trading platform can provide visibility on transaction volumes, quality specifications and prevailing prices. This could cut information disadvantages faced by smaller miners. India – with significant mineral resources – has struggled to attract large-scale exploration investment, calling for reforms in areas such as exploration, geological data availability, logistics and investment conditions, as mentioned by NITI Aayog.

Tansparent market could encourage exploration companies by improving visibility of future demand and pricing. The proposed exchanges may initially see physical mineral ores (spot, delivery-based contracts), beginning with bulk minerals such as iron ore, bauxite, limestone and manganese ore. The government has already indicated that the exchange will initially deal with ores – the direct output from mines – rather than processed metals.

While existing commodity bourses mostly see trading of processed products, the proposed mineral exchange aims to create a marketplace for raw mineral resources. Iron ore, in which India has a considerable say, is seen as a strong contender for the first major contract because it combines scale, liquidity and industrial importance.

Buoyant steel demand led to India's iron ore production witnessing significant jump from 152 million tonne in 2013-14 to over 300 million tonne recently.

A transparent iron ore market is important as steel producers currently depend on negotiated procurement contracts, captive mines, auctions and benchmark prices. An exchange-based mechanism could create a more visible domestic reference price.

Lithium, nickel, cobalt, graphite and rare earth elements may figure in the subsequent phases as the country expands domestic mining and processing capacity for EVs, batteries, renewable energy and defence technologies. India has already been auctioning critical mineral blocks to reduce import dependence.

The exchanges are slated to begin as electronic delivery-based physical marketplace, meaning buyers and sellers trade actual mineral quantities rather than only financial contracts. The success of the exchanges hinges on liquidity, which in turn depend on participation of enough buyers and sellers.

Unlike financial assets, physical minerals involve supply chain issues, including quality variations, transportation, storage and delivery. Therefore, standardisation of mineral grades will be crucial, without which, trading may remain difficult.

Nevada's AI dilemma: jobs created, jobs shed — unions and politicians caught in the crossfire

INSIGHT

Reuters

On more than 1,00,000 acres of Nevada desert east of Reno, one of the world's largest concentrations of data centres is taking shape, providing years of work for thousands of electricians, pipe fitters and other union tradespeople who are building it.

About 400 miles southeast, along the iconic Las Vegas Strip, the AI technology powered by such data centres is taking a toll: Self-driving Zoox and Waymos are replacing human-driven taxis and valets; casino floor bartenders are being replaced by robots and MGM's massive call centre is slashing hundreds of jobs. That split screen is challenging the Nevada Teamsters, apolitically powerful network of local labor unions representing 30,000 workers across the construction, transportation and hospitality industries, many of whom will be voting in the November 3 elections.

Some want to see new data-centre construction halted or slowed. Others view the boom as a gift.

"My job is to represent all of our unions," said Ross Kinson, the Nevada Teamsters' political director, adding the group had launched a process in April to find a unified stance ahead of the November polls. "This is a very, very important issue to the building trades, and it's providing a lot of jobs and creating good opportunities for a lot of people." But, he said, he has been encouraging members to consider the flip side:



Jobs at stake: Drone view of data centres at the Apple Sparks Campus in Sparks, Nevada, U.S. REUTERS

jobs?"

Nevada unions' soul-searching reflects the national debate underway over whether regulation should slow down AI development amid conflicting projections of job destruction and creation -and whether AI will ultimately lift humanity or harm it.

It's likely to affect Nevada's voting on November 3.

The Nevada Teamsters interviewed more than 180 political candidates from both parties ahead of the election, Kinson said. Those who didn't support strong worker protections, or those looking for an outright ban on new data-centre construction, were unlikely to win the union's backing. "It's a political minefield for politicians to tiptoe through," said Kinson. Nevada will also play a significant role in the 2028 Presidential elections as the second state in the Democratic primary schedule behind South Carolina.

Robot bartenders
On a suburban street just off the Las Vegas Strip, 63-year-old Larry Goldfinger and a group of fellow Teamsters he jokingly calls "the walking dead" trudge through the desert heat, clipboards in hand. They're knocking on doors to promote candidates they believe will protect the city's workers from AI-driven job losses.

Goldfinger has spent nearly three decades as a valet at some of the Strip's most iconic casinos, and another decade in Vegas hospitality jobs - work he now fears will dry up as AI automation takes over everything from concierge services to bartending.

"I raised my family, and I have had a good life doing it and I feel like these guys that are 30ish aren't going to be able to do that," he said, wearing a Teamsters baseball cap to shield his head from the Nevada sun.

By 2035, AI and automation could put up to 92,000 Southern Nevada hospitality jobs at risk, or roughly one-third of that workforce, according to an analysis by RCG Economics. Teamsters Local 986 has already been losing call-centre workers at casinos to AI automation, while taxi drivers and valets face pressure from the expansion of autonomous-vehicle fleets operated by Waymo and Zoox.

Robot bartenders and touchscreen hotel check-ins have also become increasingly common.

MGM Resorts laid off around 200 call-centre workers last year, Kinson said. On a recent investor call, MGM International CFO Jonathan Halkyard said about 80% of guest interactions "now take place via AI/digital platforms."

MGM declined to comment for this story but directed *Reuters* to a labour contract it had reached with culinary union members in 2023. It promised advance notice of AI-driven job losses along with health care and severance pay for those affected.

The Las Vegas economy is no stranger to booms, busts and technological change. But how it navigates the AI-era will have huge consequences, said John Restrepo, principal of RCG Economics.

"If they use those tools to just do massive job displacement, that's not going to be good," he said.

Goldfinger said he worries the rise of AI in Las Vegas will not only cost the city lots of jobs, but also ultimately hurt business by making it less welcoming to tourists accustomed to interacting with well-trained hospitality staff.

"We are not against the changes," he said. "We just want to make sure we are involved in how it's changing."

New gold rush
Every morning, Christopher Williams joins the traffic along the USA Parkway in northern Nevada's high desert on his way to an expanding cluster of data centres owned by Google, Switch, Tract and others in the Tahoe Reno Industrial Center.

The historic mining region was the site of a 19th-century gold rush, briefly earning Storey County the label of "the richest place on earth."

Williams, a 20-year-old with curly black hair and glasses, is part of the new rush, this time for high-paying data-centre jobs.

He moved from northern California to Reno last year after struggling to get enough hours as a line cook earning $18.50 an hour. Now he's making more than $22 an hour and works 45 to 60 hours a week. "I might not fully agree with data centres being built everywhere, but they are helping a lot of people," he said. "If I don't take the job, somebody else will, and it's a lot of money left on the table."

For local officials, the Tahoe Reno Industrial Center has been a lifeline after a prolonged economic slump. "We're finding that our economy is more stable than it used to be as a primarily gaming and tourism economy, and it's providing opportunities, especially for young people that want to stay," said County Commissioner Clay Mitchell. According to the International Brotherhood of Electrical Workers, the Tahoe Reno Industrial Center has generated 8,50,000 work hours per month in 2026 - up from about the same number during all of 2022.

Baby, bathwater
The Nevada Teamsters' internal discussions have led it to endorse Democratic Attorney General Aaron Ford for governor, Kinson said. Ford, who is seeking to unseat Republican incumbent Governor Joe Lombardo, has proposed halting new data-centre tax abatements and requiring developers to shield residents from higher energy costs, and also wants strong regulation protecting jobs from AI - the right balance to appeal to the spectrum of Teamsters unions, Kinson said.

Ford had consulted with the Teamsters before launching his data-centre platform this summer and hosted his first town hall about the issue at the Teamsters Local 14.

Lombardo has championed data centres as a major economic driver, calling the industry a "new gold rush", but had been slower to embrace checks and balances on the industry, according to Kinson.

In September, Lombardo imposed new restrictions on some of the generous tax incentives that lured the industry to the state. Lombardo did not respond to requests for comment. The union's influence tends to be significant. In 2025, union members accounted for about 13% of wage and salary workers in Nevada, compared to 10% nationwide, according to the Bureau of Labor Statistics.

In other parts of the United States, the data-centre issue has also been key to union endorsement decisions. In Kansas, for example, Republican gubernatorial candidate Ty Masterson won backing from the state's largest transit and railroad union, as well as from a local chapter of the IBEW electrical workers union, after Democratic rival Cindy Holscher called for a moratorium on data-center development.

It marked the first time in more than 50 years that the Kansas transit union backed a Republican candidate for governor.

WASHINGTON

Trump says meeting with Putin, Zelenskyy to be set up 'very soon'



AFP

U.S. President Donald Trump said on Wednesday that a meeting between Russian President Vladimir Putin and his Ukrainian counterpart Volodymyr Zelenskyy would be set up "very soon." The Kremlin and Mr. Zelenskyy had earlier said that a meeting between Kyiv, Washington and Moscow would take place in November. AFP

PESHAWAR

One killed, five injured in gunfire along Afghanistan-Pakistan border



AFP

One person was killed and five injured after Afghan Taliban fired at civilian houses and a market in Angoor Adda town in Pakistan's Waziristan, near the countries' border, Pakistan officials said on Wednesday. Pakistani forces responded with a "brief operation targeting the Afghan side with artillery fire", an official said. AFP

TEHRAN

Iranian court sentences filmmaker Jafar Panahi to five years in prison



AP

An Iranian court has sentenced renowned filmmaker Jafar Panahi in absentia to over five years in prison, Iranian media said. The court also imposed a two-year travel ban. Mr. Panahi, whose film *It Was Just an Accident* won the top prize at the 2025 Cannes film festival, has been arrested several times in the past for his filmmaking. AFP

UNITED NATIONS

For the 34th year, UN condemns U.S. economic embargo on Cuba



AP

The U.N. General Assembly decided overwhelmingly on Wednesday to condemn the U.S. economic embargo of Cuba for the 34th year even as Washington's campaign to influence the outcome led to a number of countries voting against the resolution or sitting out the vote for the first time. The vote was 130-17, with 25 abstentions. AP

At least 68 people killed in Spain's second major train crash in a year

Computer malfunction causes trains to stop; Transport Minister says crash was due to 'inexplicable' decision from a central command centre to resume services; second fatal accident in nine months on a network seen as a source of national pride

Associated Press
URDA

A high-speed train slammed into another that had stopped on the tracks in Spain on Wednesday, killing at least 68 people and injuring dozens in the second deadly rail collision this year.

Spain's Transport Minister Oscar Puente said that the accident was caused by what he called the "inexplicable" order from a central command centre for trains after a security system had failed.

Spain's rail system operator ADIF said the crash occurred on Wednesday morning in the province of Toledo, involving two high-speed trains carrying hundreds of passengers and heading in the same direction from the capital Madrid to Seville.



Rail ruins: Emergency services work at the site of the train collision in Toledo, Spain, on Wednesday. AFP

A train operated by the state-owned RENFE company struck the rear of another train operated by private company IRYO that was stopped. The collision derailed two carriages on the tail of the IRYO train and the front of the RENFE train.

January accident

The accident comes with memories still fresh of another train crash in January involving trains from the same two companies, in which 46 people died.

The regional government for Castilla La Mancha confirmed the death toll and said 58 people needed medical treatment. Rescue workers continue to search for survivors and bodies.

Transport Minister Puente said that at 8:30 a.m., the security system on a stretch of 63 kilometres stopped working due to a computer malfunction, causing all trains on that stretch to stop. But the central command told the RENFE train to start running again without any speed restrictions, and it ended up colliding with the stopped IRYO train at 8:53 a.m.

"Today all of Spain is grieving," Spanish Prime Minister Pedro Sanchez said from the crash site, where he announced three days of national mourning.

Until this year, there had been no fatal crash on Spain's high-speed lines since the network opened in 1992. It was a source of national pride.

Iran warns any new Israel-led attack will 'devastate' markets

Agence France-Presse
TEHRAN

Iran on Wednesday warned of a devastating economic impact from any new Israeli-led attack, as the votes were counted in an Israeli election that could determine the future of the regional war.

"Devastating impact on international markets of any Israel-instigated military misadventure in Persian Gulf region remains major concern for both gas suppliers and consumers," Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi said in a post on X, referring to recent talks at the gas exporters' summit in Moscow.

Since the war erupted, it has severely disrupted energy shipments from Gulf countries after Iran began blockading the Strait of Hormuz.



Abbas Araghchi

Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, vying to form a coalition government, has said Israel has an opportunity to eliminate the "existential threat" posed by Iran.

Tehran has said the outcome of the polls "makes no difference".

After fleeing Brazil, Flavio Bolsonaro lands in U.S.

Agence France-Presse
OPA-LOCKA

Brazil's defeated presidential candidate Flavio Bolsonaro and his family arrived in Florida, U.S., by a private plane on Wednesday, after defying a court order that banned him from leaving his country.

Following speculation over his whereabouts, Mr. Bolsonaro was seen disembarking the jet at Opa-Locka Executive Airport outside Miami, having flown through Argentina and Ecuador.

Mr. Bolsonaro who lost a run-off election to incumbent Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva on Sunday, is under investigation in Brazil for alleged corruption and money laundering.

'Natural allies': Moscow woos African leaders at key summit

Agence France-Presse
MOSCOW

A summit with nearly two dozen African leaders opened in Moscow on Wednesday, with the Kremlin describing their countries as "natural allies" against the West.

The two-day Russia-Africa summit, the third since 2019, comes as Moscow grapples with Western sanctions over its Ukraine offensive and as it provides security assistance to several African governments.

"We are natural allies in building a multipolar world order," Kremlin aide Yuri Ushakov said of the summit, referring to a system where political power is no longer concentrated in the West.

Russian President Vladimir Putin said that that multipolar world was quickly becoming a reality, in an "irreversible" trend.

"The era when the fate of entire continents was determined by a narrow bloc of states is irrevocably gone," he said as he opened an economic forum, which gathered thousands of Russian and African business leaders hours before the summit began.

He told the delegations from 48 African countries, that Russia was "prepared to further expand the geographical reach of our agricultural product shipments".

'Neocolonialism'

Mr. Putin also announced that Moscow planned to "localise" the production of "effective Russian medicines and vaccines" on the African continent, and noted that the number of African students in Russia had swelled 50% since 2020.

Mr. Putin's criticism of what he calls Western "neocolonialism" in Africa has resonated on the continent.

That is especially true in the Sahel, where Mali, Niger and Burkina Faso have turned their backs on their former colonial ruler France in favour of closer ties with Moscow.

The summit was expected to end on Thursday. In all, 33 documents will be signed at the summit, focused in particular on economic cooperation, according to the Kremlin.

Cruise control



A U.S. cruise ship, *MV Odyssey,* docks at the Cambodian port of Sihanoukville, after around 200 permanent residents living aboard the vessel were forced to disembark, as the operator suspended a three-year voyage midway, citing rising fuel prices linked to Iran conflict. REUTERS

Possible new dwarf planet identified just beyond Pluto

Reuters
WASHINGTON

Scientists using the new Vera C. Rubin Observatory in Chile have identified an icy object orbiting beyond Pluto that may join our solar system's small roster of dwarf planets.

Researchers said the candidate, named 2026 ED138, has a diameter estimated at between roughly 600 and 1,500 km and is orbiting about 46 times farther from the sun than Earth.

If confirmed following further observations, 2026 ED138 would join five other dwarf planets recognised by the International Astronomical Union.

What has driven the high Arab turnout in Israel's polls?

NEWS ANALYSIS

Sambavi Parthasarathy

Israel's October 27 legislative elections have recorded a massive voter turnout of 77.7%, the highest since 1999. The country's Arab citizens, who turned up in massive numbers to vote, remained one of the main factors, contributing to the surge.

While the official figures providing voter turnout among Israeli Arabs is yet to be released by the Central Elections Committee, exit polls recorded by Channel 12 estimate Arab voter turnout to be nearly 80%. This implies that the turnout among Arab citizens in Israel would be the highest in at least a decade.

While Arabs account for about 21% of Israel's population, the parties representing them have never held more than 15 seats in the 120-member Knesset. Their turnout in the elections has also been relatively low with about 40% of the eligible Arab adults abstaining from voting in most Knesset elections over the past two decades.

"In the previous elections, I think the low voter turnout was a result of disappointment mainly from Arab parties themselves. We know that approximately 10% of Arab citizens boycott Knesset elections for ideological reasons but the majority are reluctant to take part in this political game because of the conduct of their parties," said Arik Rudnitzky, from the Israel Democracy Institute in Jerusalem.

This trend was defied in the latest election. "I believe the number one motivator specifically in these elections is fear. Fear of another term of a Netanyahu government or a right-wing government because Arab citizens have had enough in the past four years," Mr. Rudnitzky told *The Hindu*.



Public voice: Supporters of Israel's Arab-led Joint List alliance cheer in Nazareth as the first exit polls are announced. AFP

This surge was used by Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu and his coalition to mobilise right-wing voters. Mr. Netanyahu, on his X, called on his supporters to vote for Likud and described the situation as a "matter of life and death".

His posts tried to mobilise voters by calling the situation "a war at home." This attempt was criticised by Arab parties for being racist and for inciting hatred.

Key factors

A survey by the Israel Democracy Institute published in September revealed that a party's position regarding foreign affairs and security, followed by the economy and high cost of living were the two most influential factors determining the support of Jewish Israelis.

In contrast, more than half of the surveyed Arabs felt that the party's position regarding crime in Arab society was one of the most important factors determining their vote.

A large voter turnout among Israeli Arabs is expected to benefit the Arab parties, thereby improving the chances of Arab representation in the Knesset committees and better policies or support for them. This is evident in the exit polls and latest numbers which have put Arab parties leading in at least 17 seats in the Knesset.

However, it is also true that not all Arab citizens support Arab parties. "In general, approximately 15% of the Arab or Arab citizens support non-Arab parties, Jewish parties. Most of them support centrist parties. Also, the Democrats headed by Yair Golan enjoy relative significant support in the Arab sector," said Mr. Rudnitzky.

Latest numbers also show that neither the Netanyahu-bloc or the opposition coalition is set to secure a clear majority, meaning that Arab parties could hold the key as to who forms the government this time.

Saudi strikes kill 14 in Yemen, say Houthis as they target Aden

Agence France-Presse
ADEN

Yemen's Houthis said Saudi strikes killed more than a dozen people on Wednesday, while the Iran-aligned group targeted the airport in government stronghold Aden.

The Houthis last month launched a lightning offensive in Yemen, reigniting a long frozen civil war against the Saudi-backed, internationally recognised government there.

On Wednesday, Houthi broadcaster Almasirah reported 14 dead "and 15 wounded, including women and children in a preliminary toll," in attacks it blamed on Saudi Arabia in Jawf province, where it reported strikes on a market and a petrol station.

Aden airport targeted

In Aden, a Houthi missile fell inside the perimeter of the airport shortly before the group issued a call to evacuate the area, a local police source said. The group targeted the airport again later.

"Our forces call on those present at Aden airport to immediately evacuate due to the presence of a military cargo plane belonging to the Saudi enemy transporting weapons to kill the sons of the Yemeni people," Houthi military spokesman Yahya Saree said on Telegram.



Winning streak: The Ethiopian Army has advanced to the border after defeating Eritrea-backed rebels in Tigray. AFP

Influencers in Ethiopia push for Eritrea invasion

Agence France-Presse
ADDIS ABABA

Ethiopian online influencers are pushing for their government to invade neighbouring Eritrea and seize access to the sea, following its success against rebel and Eritrean forces in recent weeks.

The Ethiopian Army has advanced right up to the border after repelling an offensive by rebels in the northern Tigray state, who were supported by Eritrean troops.

Prime Minister Abiy Ahmed has repeatedly said that securing a base on the Red Sea is a vital national objective for Ethiopia, which lost its coastline when Eritrea gained independence in 1993.

Some popular online influencers say the opportunity has arrived. "The time for military action to secure access to the sea and end the Eritrean regime security threat is now," Jawar Mohammed, a political activist who recently launched the "Now or Never" campaign on social media, told *AFP*. He has more than 3.5 million Facebook followers and 1.3 million on TikTok, and thousands of Ethiopians have amplified his campaign, some sharing AI-generated images of themselves in Ethiopian military uniforms as a mark of support. Not everyone agrees with his approach.

"You are a warmonger, recklessly paving the way for mass deaths," said one Facebook commenter under an image Eliyas Kebede, 25, from Addis Ababa, created of a large crowd of Eritreans warmly welcoming the Ethiopian Army to Assab.

Mr. Eliyas says he does not feel guilty "at all".

"I believe my use of AI has been somewhat successful in boosting the morale of Ethiopian Army supporters," he said.

Poland pivots towards India as 'strategic partnership' with China develops cracks

Poland and India seek to double bilateral trade from $6 bn to $12 bn; PM Modi visited Poland in 2024, during which ties were elevated to 'strategic partnership'; Warsaw is also trying to diversify partnerships as trade imbalance and Beijing's support for Russia deepen disillusionment with China

NEWS ANALYSIS

Nikhil M. Babu
WARSAW/NEW DELHI

After Polish Prime Minister Donald Tusk's recent visit to India, the first by a Polish PM in 16 years, the India-Polish "strategic partnership" is expected to get stronger through better economic and defence cooperation.

This comes two years after Prime Minister Narendra Modi visited Poland in 2024, which was the first visit by an Indian PM in 45 years, during which the relationship was elevated to "strategic partnership".

But the ties are improving against the backdrop of an important development – Poland distancing from China on many levels.

Before India, Poland had raised its relationship with China to "strategic partnership" in the 2010s. But, Poland has moved away from China due to the trade being one-sided and the Russia-Ukraine war, in which Poland sees China as an enabler, mirroring the EU's trajectory, according to experts.

In January, the EU released a draft proposal to phase out components and equipment from "high-risk" suppliers in critical sectors, as part of revisions of the Cybersecurity Act, a move criticised by China's Huawei, which is set to be among the companies affected, *Reuters* reported. In February, the Polish Army barred Chinese-made vehicles from entering military facilities due to concerns their onboard sensors could be used to collect sensitive data, as per *Reuters*.

An official from the WB Group, one of the largest private defence manufacturing companies of Poland, told *The Hindu* that they do not use Chinese critical components. "We use chips from friendly countries like South Korea," the official said. A Polish Defence Ministry source also confirmed this development.



On common ground: Prime Minister Narendra Modi with his Polish counterpart Donald Tusk at Hyderabad House in Delhi last week. ANI

'China shock 2.0'

In July this year, a study published by the Centre for Eastern Studies (OSW), a Polish government research institute, and Union of Entrepreneurs and Employers (ZPP), titled *'Poland-Europe-China: Cooperation or Dependency Trap?'* warned that "China shock 2.0" is hitting Europe's industrial core, including Poland.

The source of this pressure is not simple market competition, but China's consistent, state-led industrial strategy, as per the study. In 2025, value added lost from European industry to China was $87 billion. Of this, $11.4 billion was borne by Poland and about 45,000 jobs in Poland are at risk, mainly in batteries, automotive parts, household appliances, and steel, as per the study.

It is against this backdrop that Łukasiewicz – ITECH, a research network under the Polish government, held its inaugural conference in Warsaw in October on its 'Asian Programme' to strengthen Poland's cooperation with Asian countries. The initial countries chosen for it are Taiwan, South Korea and India.

The ultimate goal of the programme is to move beyond general declarations of international cooperation and towards concrete projects, partnerships and recommendations that support the development of Poland's "innovation capacity", as per the institute.

During Mr. Tusk's visit, representatives of the institute were in India.

Pawel Marczewski, Director of the Department of Strategy and Analysis, Łukasiewicz – ITECH, said the main aim of the programme is to learn from the experiences of like-minded Asian countries about how they support their innovation ecosystem and commercialisation of technological innovation.

"But also, a pretty important factor is to be independent from China. For instance, how to build independence from China in terms of critical minerals and critical technologies. China has completely restricted the supply of critical minerals for the European defence sector, including Poland," Mr. Marczewski said.

But this was not always the case. Dominik Mierzejewski, associate professor, Department of Asian Studies, University of Lodz, Poland, said that in 1997, the then Polish President visited China and it was sort of an opening of doors for bilateral relations.

"The very big signal was in 2011, when we signed a strategic partnership. In December 2011, the first document was signed and the second was signed in 2016," he said.

Mr. Mierzejewski said that in 2012 there was the "16+1" cooperation (16 Central and Eastern European [CEE] nations and China) and in 2015, Poland was one of the first countries from Europe to be part of the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) of China. "So we thought the trade deficit would be narrowed by policies from Beijing. However, it did not materialise. And particularly this disappointment came from a lack of Chinese investments in Poland," he said.

'India fever'

Poland started distancing from China from February 2022, "when Russia started its war with Ukraine", he said.

"Not only in Poland, but in the whole EU, the ties with India are getting closer. What I experienced in Brussels, Paris or Berlin is that there is an India fever. Previously, we had a China fever. So, this is the current context. It is important for the EU to learn a lesson from its relationship with China," he added.

Adam Burakowski, former Polish Ambassador to India, said Poland's relationship with China was the closest around 2016. "Now Poland is politically not that close to China, but the economic relationship continues. The bilateral trade with China is about $60 billion, but it is very one-sided with around $58 billion being Chinese exports to Poland. We would like to rebalance it."

But Mr. Burakowski said that the visit by the Polish PM to India was more about economic ties with India.

"With the India-EU Free Trade Agreement (FTA) to be ratified soon, the focus of the current visit was mainly economic," he said. Mr. Burakowski said the bilateral trade between the countries now stands at around $6 billion and both the governments are working to double it.

(The writer was in Poland at the invitation of the Polish Ministry of Foreign Affairs)

Sri Lanka's Tamil farmers fight to reclaim land years after civil war

Agence France-Presse
BATTICALOA

Tired but resolute, dozens of Tamil cattle farmers have held a round-the-clock vigil for almost three years in eastern Sri Lanka, protesting what they call land "theft".

At shift change, farmers exchange news before settling beneath a tarpaulin beside photographs of the bloodied bodies of their dead cows.

"They have been shooting our cattle, threatening us, assaulting us, and spraying pesticides or poison on the pasture lands where our cattle graze," said Seenithamby Thiyagarajah, president of the local farmers' association, detailing the push his community felt from recipients of a state-funded programme that was driving them off their land.



On guard: Tamil cattle farmers staging a round-the-clock vigil beside posters of dead cows, at Batticaloa in Eastern Province. AFP

"Over 5,700 cows have been destroyed like this. Even after complaining numerous times to the police and all relevant places, we received no resolution."

The alleged perpetrators are farmers who have benefited from the state-funded Mahaweli development scheme.

Most are Sinhalese, the country's majority ethnic group, settling on land claimed by the largely Hindu Tamil minority, which makes up about 12% of the population.

The government denied any forcible attempts to remove people from their land.

Sri Lanka's 1983-2009 civil war between government forces and Tamil separatists killed more than 1,00,000 people, according to the United Nations.

Nearly two decades later, land disputes continue to fuel ethnic grievances.

Mr. Thiyagarajah says settlers aided by the scheme have encroached on grazing land used by the roughly 1,000 cattle farmers he represents.

Courts have repeatedly ordered the eviction of the scheme-backed settler farmers, he said. "Things are peaceful, for a while," he said. "But then the illegal cultivators entered again, ruining our land and destroying our cattle."

A wild warning



An activist in an orangutan costume and gas mask holds up a placard at a protest against the Indonesian government's handling of forest fires, in Jakarta on Wednesday. Rainfall brought temporary relief from toxic haze in some parts, although fires continued to burn. REUTERS

Meet the contenders for Serbia's top political posts after Vucic's election defeat

Reuters
BELGRADE

After a leaderless student-led protest movement swept Serbia's former President Aleksandar Vucic from power in a historic snap election on Sunday, the country is waiting to hear who it will appoint as Prime Minister and to other key ministerial positions as it forms a government.

Here are some of the prominent candidates on the students' list.

The banker

Former Central Bank Governor Dejan Soskic, 59. Mr. Soskic, an economist and professor at the University of Belgrade's Faculty of Economics, served as Governor of the Central Bank between 2010 and 2012, before resigning in protest at legislative amendments that he argued compromised the institution's independence. He has, for years, been a vocal opponent of Mr. Vucic's government.

Mr. Soskic, who was an avid biker in his youth but has mellowed into a softly spoken reformer, has frequently criticised the country's institutional weaknesses under Mr. Vucic.

Mr. Soskic says that prudent public finances will create a stable foundation for a permanent increase in wages and pensions.

Pro-government media have criticised Mr. Soskic's Central Bank record, accusing him of triggering the depreciation of the dinar during his tenure. Mr. Soskic has defended the depreciation as a reflection of the mandatory monetary policy amendments of the time rather than a personal failure.

The cardiologist

Cardiologist and professor Ilija Srdanovic, 55. Mr. Srdanovic, a practising cardiologist, professor at the University of Novi Sad Faculty of Medicine and a keen cyclist, became the student movement's lead candidate when the ballot list was finalised in September.

Mr. Srdanovic's transition to frontline politics began during the student-led anti-corruption demonstrations, where he frequently appeared as a public speaker. The physician participated in the movement's "Guardians of the Constitution" bicycle tour across the northern Vojvodina province.

Mr. Srdanovic campaigned with the promise of a decentralised health system "at the service of citizens and based on equality for all patients".



In the spotlight: Dejan Soskic speaks to media after polls closed during the parliamentary election in Belgrade on Sunday. REUTERS

Some of Mr. Srdanovic's policies do not represent a sharp departure from some of those of the previous government. He stressed the Student List position that Kosovo, which declared independence from Serbia in 2008, remains an integral part of the country. During the campaign he also said that European Union integration is not a current priority and that the immediate focus for the incoming administration must remain on domestic anti-corruption reforms and national "existential survival".

The basketball star

Former basketball star Dejan Bodiroga, 53. Mr. Bodiroga, the former captain of the Yugoslav national basketball team and current EuroLeague president, is one of the student movement's most prominent public speakers.

He described Sunday's election as a fight "for the return of a country that has been hijacked".

The step into politics is the latest chapter in a life that has gripped the basketball-mad nation – from capturing back-to-back FIBA World Championship gold medals in 1998 and 2002 and leading the then Yugoslav team to an Olympic silver medal at the 1996 Atlanta Games, to entering senior sports administration upon his retirement as a player in 2007 and being appointed as EuroLeague president in 2022.

During the election campaign, Mr. Bodiroga appeared at student rallies and took part in open-air folk dancing in rural municipalities. His fans frequently cheered him with a 1990s slogan "We have our God, his name is Bodiroga."

The chemist

Chemistry professor Radomir Saicic, 64. Mr. Saicic, an organic chemistry professor and a member of the Serbian Academy of Sciences and Arts (SANU), was the face of the students' election win on Sunday, taking the podium at their headquarters after Mr. Vucic conceded defeat to hail the outcome as a "citizens' victory".

He is a specialist in medicinal chemistry whose research focuses on the synthesis of chemotherapy treatments and antiviral therapies, including a special COVID-19 project in collaboration with the Pasteur Institute.

Mr. Saicic joined the student-led anti-corruption protests that followed the 2024 collapse of a railway station canopy in the northern Serbian city of Novi Sad. He became a target for pro-government tabloids after signing a petition with 24 other academics demanding Mr. Vucic's resignation, and in May 2026 he walked out of a SANU gallery exhibition to protest an appearance by Nikola Selakovic, the Minister of Culture.

During the campaign, he told crowds that he was ready to put "even his life" at the disposal of the student movement.

Political analysts have tipped him as a contender in the presidential election which will also be triggered by Mr. Vucic's recent resignation from the post.

SPIN TRIO

Sneh looks forward to bowling with Deepti and Ecclestone



FILE PHOTO: SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

Whichever team I go to, I want to give my best for them. Now that I've joined Warriorz, I want to do the same. It's a spin-heavy bowling unit. Deepti Sharma and Sophie Ecclestone will be operating with me. It's going to be a lot of fun — Sneh Rana who was bought by the UP outfit for ₹30 lakh.

BIG SIGNING

Molineux gives us a lot of quality and flexibility: UP coach Nayar



CREIMAS/BCCI

We went into the auction with a clear idea. Sophie Molineux was a key addition for us, and we are delighted to have secured her services. Along with Grace Harris, Sneh Rana and the other players we have brought in, she gives us a lot of quality and flexibility — Abhishek Nayar, UP Warriorz head coach.

KEY TARGET

Kamalini provides an aggressive option, says Giants coach Klinger



AP

Gujarat Giants head coach Michael Klinger was delighted with the acquisition of wicketkeeper-batter G. Kamalini and the make-up of the squad. "Kamalini gives us an aggressive option in our batting order. The new signings complement our retained players. We are pleased with how the squad has come together," he said.

PRIZE CATCH

Tryon adds depth to our batting and is a handy bowler too: Malolan



FILE PHOTO

I'm very happy to have Chloe Tryon in our squad. She is a very experienced player who has been figuring in franchise leagues and performing well. She adds depth to our line-up, with the ability to bat anywhere between No. 4 and No. 7. She is very handy with her left-arm spin — Malolan Rangarajan, RCB head coach.

Molineux, Kiran top earners; Kashvi scripts history

Warriorz draft in the T20 World Cup-winning captain for ₹1.10 crore; the Indian big-hitter to turn out for Capitals after being bought for ₹75 lakh; the 15-year-old is the youngest to make a WPL squad







Star attractions: Warriorz were so keen on Molineux that they raised the paddle as soon as her name was announced. Kiran and Kashvi will hope to be the points of difference for Capitals.
GETTY IMAGES, K. MURALI KUMAR & SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

WPL AUCTION

P.K. Ajith Kumar
KOCHI

Just a cricket ball's throw away from Hyatt Grand lies the peaceful Vembanad Lake. The WPL's mini auction, held at Grand Hyatt's Vembanad Hall, was about just as peaceful on Wednesday evening: there weren't that many fierce bidding wars.

That wasn't really surprising. It was a mini auction, after all, with just 27 slots up for grabs. Sophie Molineux, the all-rounder who led Australia to the T20 World Cup crown some three months ago in England, turned out to be the costliest star. She was bought by UP Warriorz for ₹1.10 crore.

Warriorz had come to the auction with by far the largest purse (₹3.75 crore), and the paddle from their table went up even before the auctioneer completed announcing Molineux's name. Her base price was ₹50 lakh. Royal Challengers Bengaluru was also keen, but had to step back as it didn't have the kind of money that Warriorz had.

Warriorz, of course, had more spots to fill than the other four franchises. They went on to add Grace Harris (₹30 lakh), Sneh Rana (₹30 lakh), Sushma Verma (₹30 lakh), Asha Sobhana (₹30 lakh), Kathryn Bryce (₹10 lakh), Manali Dakshini (₹10 lakh) and Sahana Pawar (₹10 lakh).

Among them, the biggest steal was Harris, one of the hardest hitters you would come across in women's cricket. She can be more than useful with her off-spin, too. She is returning to Warriorz after being part of the title-winning RCB.

Another big-hitter, Kiran Navgire, did not come as cheap: Delhi Capitals bought her for ₹75 lakh, against a base price of ₹40 lakh. Mumbai Indians was also interested in her.

G. Kamalini and Jess Jonassen were both picked up for their base price of ₹40 lakh, by Gujarat Giants and RCB, respectively. Mumbai Indians went on a spree of budget buys. It got Disha Kasat, Latika Inamdar, Bharti Rawal, Saanika Chalke and Akshita Bhagat, all for ₹10 lakh, and Shweta Sehrawat for ₹20 lakh. Uma Kashvi was sold for ₹10 lakh to Capitals, but she made history. At 15, she is the youngest to make it to a WPL squad.

There were big stars who failed to shine, like Sophia Dunkley. The England opener was the only player, apart from Molineux, who had asked for a base price of ₹50 lakh. She had no takers.

Who went **where**

The 25 players bought at the WPL mini auction on Wednesday

Player	Team	Price (₹)
Sophie Molineux	UP Warriorz	1.1 crore
Kiran Navgire	Delhi Capitals	75 lakh
G. Kamalini	Gujarat Giants	40 lakh
Jess Jonassen	Royal Challengers	40 lakh
Asha Sobhana	UP Warriorz	30 lakh
Chloe Tryon	Royal Challengers	30 lakh
Grace Harris	UP Warriorz	30 lakh
Orla Prendergast	Gujarat Giants	30 lakh
Sneh Rana	UP Warriorz	30 lakh
Sushma Verma	UP Warriorz	30 lakh
Tejal Hasabnis	Royal Challengers	30 lakh
Shweta Sehrawat	Mumbai Indians	20 lakh
Akshita Bhagat	Mumbai Indians	10 lakh
Bharti Rawal	Mumbai Indians	10 lakh
Disha Kasat	Mumbai Indians	10 lakh
Kathryn Bryce	UP Warriorz	10 lakh
Kirstie Gordon	Delhi Capitals	10 lakh
Latika Inamdar	Mumbai Indians	10 lakh
Manali Dakshini	UP Warriorz	10 lakh
Nazma Khan	Delhi Capitals	10 lakh
Saanika Chalke	Mumbai Indians	10 lakh
Sahana Pawar	UP Warriorz	10 lakh
Samaira Raghav	Gujarat Giants	10 lakh
Uma Kashvi	Delhi Capitals	10 lakh
Vrinda Dinesh	Royal Challengers	10 lakh











The 2027 **WPL Dugouts**

DELHI CAPITALS

Retained players: Annabel Sutherland*, Chinelle Henry*, Deeya Yadav, Jemimah Rodrigues, Laura Wolvaardt*, Lucy Hamilton*, Mamatha Madiwala, Marizanne Kapp*, Minnu Mani, N. Shree Charani, Nandani Sharma, Niki Prasad, Shafali Verma.

Wednesday's picks: Kiran Navgire, Kirstie Gordon*, Nazma Khan, Uma Kashvi.

GUJARAT GIANTS

Retained: Anushka Sharma, Ashleigh Gardner*, Beth Mooney*, Bharti Fulmali, Georgia Wareham*, Happy Kumari, Jintimani Kalita, Kanika Ahuja, Kashvee Gautam, Kim Garth*, Rajeshwari Gayakwad, Renuka Singh, Sophie Devine*, Tanuja Kanwar, Yastika Bhatia.

Wednesday's picks: G. Kamalini, Orla Prendergast*, Samaira Raghav.

MUMBAI INDIANS

Retained: Amanjot Kaur, Amelia Kerr*, Harmanpreet Kaur, Hayley Matthews*, Nat Sciver-Brunt*, Nicola Carey*, Rahila Firdous, S. Sajana, Sanskriti Gupta, Shabnim Ismail*, Vaishnavi Sharma.

Traded in: Tara Norris* (from UP Warriorz).

Wednesday's picks: Akshita Bhagat, Bharti Rawal, Disha Kasat, Latika Inamdar, Saanika Chalke, Shweta Sehrawat.

**Overseas players*



ROYAL CHALLENGERS BENGALURU

Retained: Arundhati Reddy, Ellyse Perry*, Georgia Voll*, Lauren Bell*, Nadine de Klerk*, Pooja Vastrakar, Prathyoosha Kumar, Prema Rawat, Radha Yadav, Richa Ghosh, Sayali Satghare, Shreyanka Patil, Smriti Mandhana.

Wednesday's picks: Chloe Tryon*, Jess Jonassen*, Tejal Hasabnis, Vrinda Dinesh.

UP WARRIORZ

Retained: Deepti Sharma, Harleen Deol, Kranti Gaud, Meg Lanning*, Phoebe Litchfield*, Pratika Rawal, Shikha Pandey, Shipra Giri, Simran Shaikh, Sophie Ecclestone*.

Wednesday's picks: Asha Sobhana, Grace Harris*, Kathryn Bryce*, Manali Dakshini, Sahana Pawar, Sneh Rana, Sophie Molineux*, Sushma Verma.



Talking tactics: RCB CEO Rajesh Menon and head coach Malolan Rangarajan in discussion. CREIMAS/BCCI

Vaishnavi's five-for sets up India's series sweep

ZIMBABWE IN INDIA

Lavanya L.
VADODARA

Zimbabwe's historic maiden tour of India ended on a sobering note for the Lady Chevrons, with Vaishnavi Sharma's maiden five-wicket haul and fifties from Pratika Rawal and Shafali Verma guiding India to a dominant eight-wicket win and a 3-0 series sweep here on Wednesday.

People in Vadodara are simple. They like their food and cricket.

They particularly like their local stars being involved in international fixtures.

At the BCA Stadium, from the security personnel to the ground staff, Yastika Bhatia was the name on everyone's lips.



One to cherish: Vaishnavi castles Gwanzura to complete her maiden five-wicket haul. CREIMAS/BCCI

After frustrating the home fans twice, India finally swapped out Richa Ghosh for her.

Yastika had a great afternoon behind the stumps, taking a catch and effecting a stumping and a run out, in an effort that restricted Zimbabwe to just 131 in 39.5 overs. But she botched a perfect opportunity to make a statement with the bat, going grand off the very first ball of the innings, only to find Francisca Chipare at mid-on.

Harleen Deol, in for Tejal Hasabnis, was overshadowed by Pratika's fluency and fell for a run-a-ball 19. Pratika and Shafali, visibly in a hurry, got the job done at T20 pace with 33 overs to spare.

Earlier, Sayali Satghare and Kranti Gaud nipped Zimbabwe's dream of a competitive score in the bud, leaving it stuttering at 12 for two by the third over.

Inexperience

Inexperience showed as the visitors struggled to rotate strike and crumbled under dot ball pressure – a staggering 193 in 237 balls.

Modester Mupachikwa resisted, but Vaishnavi's left-arm spin gobbled up the middle-order.

The Gwalior-born bowler also registered India's first no ball of the series and had a few going wide with the turn which she got on a slow track in Kotambi.

But, a maiden ODI five-for brightened the day and she eventually led India off the field with a wide smile and her signature curtain call.

The scores:
Zimbabwe 131
in 39.5 overs (Modester Mupachikwa 37, Josephine Nkomo 35, Vaishnavi Sharma 5/39) lost to India 133/2 in 17 overs (Pratika Rawal 59 n.o., Shafali Verma 51 n.o.).
Toss: Zimbabwe; **PoM:** Vaishnavi; **PoS:** Pratika.

Renshaw, Inglis put Australia in front

CRICKET

Agence France-Presse
CAPE TOWN

Josh Inglis and Alex Carey added an unbroken 145 for the fifth wicket as Australia took the lead on the second day of the third Test against South Africa at Newlands on Wednesday.

Australia was 330 for four at close, one run ahead of South Africa's first innings total of 329.

Matt Renshaw (74) and Cameron Green (65) put on 126 for the third wicket before Inglis (85 batting) and Carey (51 batting) put Australia ahead. Renshaw and Travis Head (41) put on 58 before Head was dismissed by Simon Harmer. The offie had Marnus Labuschagne caught at slip for a duck in the same over.



Inglis' knock gave Australia the upper hand. AP

The scores: South Africa 329 vs. Australia 330/4 in 90 overs (Renshaw 74, Green 65, Inglis 85 batting, Carey 51 batting).

Vijay hopes to show that off-spinners can excel in both Tests and T20s

The Andhra tweaker sheds light on his transition from playing on cement tracks to turf wickets; the 25-year-old has been making rapid strides

RANJI TROPHY

Sahil Mathur
VIJAYAWADA

T. Vijay is a lanky off-spinner with an uncomplicated action.

He gets the ball to drift and dip without losing accuracy for long. Combined with the turn on offer, these qualities make him a tricky bowler to face.

For much of his cricketing journey, however, Vijay had little idea about the finer aspects of the game. Hailing from Tekkali in Andhra Pradesh's Srikakulam district, he started playing cricket on the only cement pitch his town had.

"There is only one net and one cement wicket. There is nothing beyond that. I had no idea about turf wickets," Vijay told *The Hindu*.

It was only after joining an academy in Vizianagaram that he encountered a turf wicket and gradually learnt more about the sport. "I learnt about strength training, fitness, running and everything else. Before that, I only knew how to bowl. I didn't know much about other aspects of cricket or how professional cricket worked," the 25-year-old said.

With the support of his coaches Vikram Verma and C.D. Thomson, whom he met in Vizianagaram, and his family, Vijay began his journey.

In four years of senior cricket, Vijay has played 19 First Class matches and taken 65 wickets. He has also featured in 14 List A matches and 11 T20s – performances that have drawn the attention of selectors and scouts.

He made his IPL debut in 2026 with Delhi Capitals, after which he featured in South Zone's squad in the Duleep Trophy.

Subsequently, he received his maiden India-A call-up as well for the two multi-day matches against Australia-A.

Vijay is aware that traditional off-spin is a dying art in modern cricket and that's exactly what pushes him forward.

"It motivates me to come out of my comfort zone. I want to show everyone that off-spinners can also do well in T20s and Test cricket. That's my motto, and I will keep working hard and hope to do wonders," Vijay concluded.

Day three washed out

Persistent rain overnight following Cyclone Arnab's landfall brought an end to day three of the Ranji Trophy Group 'B' clash between Andhra and Chhattisgarh without any play here at the DVR Ground on Wednesday.

Both sides will hope conditions improve on the final day, with three points still in sight. Chhattisgarh is 15 runs behind Andhra's first-innings total of 231 but has lost eight wickets. Amandeep Khare is unbeaten on 74 while Vijay has picked three wickets so far.



Rising star: Vijay celebrates the dismissal of Chhattisgarh's Vikalp Tiwary. K.V. S. GIRI

Antonelli — Mercedes's pride, Ferrari's envy

Reuters
MEXICO CITY

Ferrari fans can only imagine what might have been had local boy Kimi Antonelli signed for their team rather than Mercedes as a young go-karter.

Formula One's oldest and most successful team had the chance to secure the talent now set to become Italy's first champion in 73 years, and Formula One's youngest ever, but let it slip through their fingers.

Mercedes seized the opportunity instead in 2018, when Antonelli was 11.

"For Ferrari, Kimi was still too young whereas Mercedes could offer better guarantees regarding his future prospects," Antonelli's former manager Giovanni Minardi told the Gazzetta dello Sport newspaper earlier this year.

Mercedes team boss and co-owner Toto Wolff recalled how others said Antonelli, after nine rounds without points last year, should not have been given the Mercedes seat.

He spoke of those at other teams who suggested the youngster should not even be in Formula One.

But Antonelli, in only his second season, has a 123-point lead over teammate and closest rival George Russell with a maximum 100 still available after Mexico.

Two points on Sunday – a ninth place – is all he needs to become Italy's first champion in 73 years even if Russell wins the race.

Antonelli was fast-tracked by Mercedes as replacement for seven-time champion Lewis Hamilton when the Briton went to Ferrari.

Mirabai to compete in 53kg at World c'ships

WEIGHTLIFTING

Y.B. Sarangi
KOLKATA

World and Olympic medallist Mirabai Chanu, who recently got a silver medal in the Asian Games in the 49kg category, will compete in 53kg at the World weightlifting championships in Ningbo, China, on Thursday.

The 32-year-old lifter jumped to the higher weight after 53kg became the minimum weight category for women at the Los Angeles 2028 Olympics.

Mirabai, who has won all her major medals in either 48kg or 49kg, had competed in 55kg once at the Singapore International meet in 2022.

For the World championships, which is an Olympic qualifying event, Mirabai has entered a pre-competition total of 200kg and is placed in Group 'B.' Top competitors in each weight are clubbed in Group 'A.'

"Mira entered this competition to check herself and gather some ideas. She did not have the time to prepare after the Asian Games, leave alone increasing her normal body weight (which stays around 50kg).

"We will begin our preparation from March next. The target is to qualify for the Olympics," chief national coach Vijay Sharma told *The Hindu*.

The LA Olympics qualifying timeline has two periods. Best three results of the first period, comprising six events, and best two results from the second period, including four events, of an athlete will be considered to finalise the Olympic Qualification Ranking (OQR).

Top-eight athletes in each weight category will earn Olympic quota places.

Meanwhile, India has fielded Gyaneshwari Yadav (53kg), Usha and Nirupama Devi (both 61kg) and Commonwealth Games silver medallist Lovepreet Singh (+110kg).

Charu Pesi (65kg), hailing from Arunachal Pradesh, could not make it to Ningbo after he got a stapled Chinese visa.

RANJI TROPHY SCORES – ROUND THREE, DAY THREE

Elite:
Group A:
At Vadodara: Baroda 616 vs. J&K 303 in 77.5 overs (Qamran Iqbal 121, Umar Nazir 101, Atit Sheth 4/61) & 8/1 in 6 overs.
At Nagpur: Goa 220 & 41/1 in 23 overs vs. Vidarbha 442/8 decl. in 134.2 overs (R. Samarth 53, Dhruv Shorey 168, Danish Malewar 56, Akshay Wadkar 63 n.o., Ruthvik Naik 5/70).
At Puducherry: Uttar Pradesh 333 in 124.5 overs (Karan Sharma 167, Shivam Mavi 50, Sagar Udeshi 4/64) vs. Pondicherry 172 in 68.1 overs (Neyan Kangayan 46, Zeeshan Ansari 4/41) & 39/0 in 11 overs.
Group B: At Vijayawada: Andhra 231 vs. Chhattisgarh 216/8 in 95 overs. No play on third day.
At Hyderabad: Punjab 431 & 57/0 in 24 overs vs. Hyderabad 380 in 119.5 overs (Abhirath Reddy 97, Rahul Radesh 86, K. Himateja 81, Pragnay Reddy 65, Vihaan Malhotra 4/15).
At Mysuru: Tripura 194 & 98/3 in 38 overs vs. Karnataka 490/9 decl. in 144 overs (Rohan Patil 72, K.V. Aneesh 68, Karun Nair 63, Aneeshwar Gautam 100, Manvanth Kumar 51, Rithesh Bhatkal 74 n.o.).
At Rajkot: Assam 281 & 65/7 in 26 overs (Parth Bhut 6/7) vs. Saurashtra 387 in 131.4 overs (Hetvik Kotak 80, Prerak Mankad 76, Arth Yadav 46 n.o., Mohit Thakur 4/126).
Group C: At Ranchi: Delhi 515/5 decl. vs. Jharkhand 131/4 in 47 overs. No play on third day.
At Bhubaneswar: Odisha 194 vs. Services 13/0 in 5 overs. No play on third day.
At Pune: Gujarat 223 & 227/3 in 67 overs (Aarya Desai 132 batting) vs. Maharashtra 330 in 120.3 overs (Digvijay Patil 43, Harshal Kate 84, Saurabh Nawale 95).
At Thiruvananthapuram: Bengal 350 & 198 in 46 overs (Abhimanyu Easwaran 47, Jalaj Saxena 5/70) vs. Kerala 141 in 51.3 overs (Vishnu Vinod 41, Pradipta Pramanik 4/44) & 53/4 in 20 overs (Pramanik 4/21).
Group D: At Dehradun: Rajasthan 272 & 290/5 decl. in 101.4 overs (Sachin Yadav 53, Mahipal Lomror 45, Karan Lamba 100 n.o., Kunal Rathore 77) vs. Uttarakhand 194 & 38/0 in 9 overs.
At Chennai: Railways 184 & 108 in 52.3 overs (S. Yuvraj Singh 42, Sai Kishore 4/39) lost to Tamil Nadu 165 & 130/5 in 59.1 overs (Andre Siddarth 56 n.o., Toufik Mondal 4/50).
Points: TN 6 (14), Railways 0 (2).
At Chandigarh: Chandigarh 685/5 decl. vs. Himachal Pradesh 340/3 in 104 overs (Innesh Mahajan 121, Shubham Arora 96, Pukhraj Mann 50 batting).
At Mumbai: Mumbai 430 vs. Haryana 270 in 107.5 overs (Nishant Sindhu 105 n.o., Dheeru Singh 45, Musheer Khan 6/85) & 73/2 in 21 overs.
Plate: At Rangpo: Nagaland 187 & 208 in 91 overs (Chetan Bist 97) vs. Sikkim 184 & 87/4 in 32 overs.
At Ahmedabad: Arunachal Pradesh 111 & 431 in 120.4 overs (Techi Doria 160, Salil Malhotra 135, Kishan Singha 5/88) vs. Manipur 364 & 12/1 in 4 overs.
At Nadiad: Meghalaya 562 vs. Mizoram 350/5 in 127 overs (Lalhruaizela 51, Chinmay Sutar 125, Joseph Lalthankhuma 70 batting).

'Youngsters giving fresh impetus'

S. Prasanna Venkatesan
CHENNAI

Former India captain and two-time Olympian V.R. Raghunath believes domestic hockey has evolved considerably since his early playing days, with improved awareness of the game, greater pace, and the emergence of younger players giving the sport a fresh impetus.

"The pace has evolved. People are much more aware of the game, and the younger teams are much better," said the 37-year-old, who captains Indian Oil Corporation Ltd (IOCL) in the 97th All-India MCC-Murugappa Gold Cup hockey tournament here.

"Railways is very good, Air Force is very good, and so are Navy and BPCL. They are bringing in new appointments, offering scholarships and recruiting new players. Young blood is coming in, and that is why the game is getting faster. The players are aware of the game. It is much better," he added.



Raghunath. R. RAGU

Raghunath also credited social media, as well as live telecasts and streaming for improving hockey's visibility.

"There is more awareness because of social media, networking, and live telecasts and streaming. Almost every small tournament is telecast or streamed live. People are following the game. I think that is one good initiative in modern sport," he said.

On India's prospects for the 2028 Olympics, Raghunath said: "They have recently won the Asian Games gold and qualified for the Olympics, so that is a step ahead. The World Cup didn't go as planned, but they have another two years to sort things out, decide on the changes and establish the core group.

"The target will be to finish in the top four, at least - to reach the Olympic semifinals. They should get 30 to 50 matches before the Olympics," he said.

IOCL holds Indian Army; BPCL through to the semifinals

MURUGAPPA GOLD CUP

S. Prasanna Venkatesan
CHENNAI

Indian Oil Corporation Ltd. (IOCL) held Indian Army to a 2-2 draw in a Pool-A match of the 97th All-India MCC-Murugappa Gold Cup hockey tournament at the SDAT Mayor Radhakrishnan Stadium here on Wednesday, leaving the latter's semifinal hopes hanging in the balance.

Indian Railways has secured a last-four berth from Pool-A, while Army's progress depends on Thursday's match between Railways and Punjab National Bank (PNB).

PNB needs to win by a seven-goal margin to advance ahead of Army.

In Pool-B, Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd (BPCL) has qualified for the semifinals. Indian Navy needs only a draw against Malaysia's junior team on Thursday to join it, while the Malaysian colts must win to progress.

Sunil Yadav put IOCL ahead in the 29th minute, converting a penalty stroke after Army's Niraj Waribam impeded S.K. Uthappa with his stick near the goal.



Strong finish: Uthappa's strike helped IOCL secure a draw. R. RAGU

Army responded immediately, with Cyril Lugun converting a penalty corner in the 30th minute off Rohit Irengbam's delivery.

Army went ahead in the 43rd minute when Jobanpreet Singh converted a penalty stroke.

The award followed Lugun's drag-flick striking Vikramjit Singh's leg on the goal-line as the defender prevented a certain goal.

IOCL restored parity in the 49th minute through S.K. Uthappa, who finished a long through pass from V.R. Raghunath.

Both sides squandered a penalty corner each in the closing stages.

The results:

Pool-A: IOCL 2 (Sunil Yadav 29-ps, S.K. Uthappa 49) drew with Indian Army 2 (Cyril Lugun 30-pc, Jobanpreet Singh 43-ps).

Pool-B: Hockey Unit of Tamil Nadu 4 (G.M. Pruthvi 14-pc, Yojin Minz 23, 47, Patras Tirkey 26-pc) bt Malaysia junior team 2 (Salihe Muhammad 15-pc, Karthikesan Shivamoorthy 60-pc).

BPCL 5 (Varun Kumar 23-ps, Charanjeet Singh 25, 41, Anmol Ekka 35-pc, Sudeep Chirmako 42) drew with Indian Navy 5 (Sushil Dhanwar 6-pc, Pawan Rajbhar 34, 56-pc, Rajat Sharma 37, Rajat Minz 46).

SNAPSHOTS

Shadman hits unbeaten 99 on opening day

MIRPUR: Bangladesh opener Shadman Islam was stranded on 99 as bad light brought an early end to day one in the first Test against West Indies on Wednesday.

The scores: Bangladesh 213/3 in 74 overs (Shadman Islam 99 batting, Towhid Hridoy 42) vs. West Indies. **Toss:** Bangladesh.

Silver for Neelam, Kajal

ASTANA: Neelam Sirohi (50kg) and Kajal Dhochak (76kg) took silver medals after losing their respective final bouts at the World wrestling championships on Wednesday. Against four-time World champion Yui Susaki, Neelam could not last long as the Japanese grabbed a 5-0 lead before pinning the Indian. Two-time World under-20 champion Kajal lost 8-6 to Ukraine's Anastasiya Alpyeyeva.

Day of upsets in mixed doubles qualifying

CHENNAI: The Indian pair of Neil Mulye and 14-year-old Tanishka Kalbhairav stunned the third seeded duo of Sahil Rawat and Hansini Mathan 11-9, 11-9, 10-12, 11-8 in the mixed doubles qualifying round one of the WTT Feeder on Wednesday. In mixed doubles, Akash Gupta and Garima Goyal, seeded eighth, blanked fourth seed Harshit Kumar and Gungun Sahu 11-9, 12-10, 11-6, and 10th seed Punit Biswas and Ditsa Roy packed off seventh seeds Rajiv Sahu and Shriya Anand 11-7, 11-7, 11-2.

Indian colts lose

BAKU: India lost 1-2 to Honduras in a round of 32 Tier C match of the FIFA u-15 World Cup and Festival on Wednesday. The Blue Colts will now move to the round of 16 of the lower bracket and contest for positions 81-96.
The result: Honduras 2 (Danio Flores 18, Alejandro Amaya 36) bt India (Ronandev Aheibam 31).

Lazio routs Sassuolo

Romano Floriani, great-grandson of Italian dictator Benito Mussolini, scored his first Serie A goal as Lazio soared to the top of the Italian league with a 6-2 thrashing of 10-man Sassuolo on Tuesday.
The results: Sassuolo 2 (Sutalo 7-og, Esposito 43) lost to Lazio 6 (Taylor 2, Isaksen 13, Floriani 17, Zaccagni 45+1, Noslin 55, 65); Roma 4 (Lulli 15, Pisilli 21, Mora 85, Malen 87) bt Cagliari 2 (M'Bala Nzola 10-pen, Maldini 81); Torino 1 (Adams 24) lost to Como 3 (Ramon 81, Paz 87, Baturina 90+2).

Emotional and proud homecoming for the hockey heroes at ACT

Uthra Ganesan
JALANDHAR

India's opening game of the Asian Champions Trophy (ACT) here had three goals from Mandeep Singh. The man who had stepped on to the field earlier that day, however, was Lalli.

That's what Mandeep's friends and family call him. They were all in attendance at the Olympian Surjit Singh stadium on Tuesday, watching him play in an India jersey on home ground for the first time ever.

Fourteen years after he made the national team as an 18-year-old, Mandeep returned to the turf where he learnt to hold a hockey stick, this time as a two-time Olympic medalist.

"I can't express what it means to play at home in front of family. It's just a very special, very proud feeling right now. It started the moment I entered the building and watching the crowd in the stands. I have played for the country for 14 years and this is the first time I am doing so in my own state," Mandeep told *The Hindu*.

He was one of the five players from the academy to take the field; Manpreet Singh, the most famous one, missed out with an injury even though his family was present in the stands.



Mandeep's family saw him play at home for the first time 14 years after he turned out for India. X@THEHOCKEYINDIA

Every player in this team, in fact, will be playing international hockey in Punjab for the first time ever – the last time the state hosted a tournament was the Gold Cup in 2009, in Chandigarh.

Harmanpreet Singh was excited about having his parents see him play live in a stadium for the first time. "We have played in all the major cities across the world but nothing matches returning home. This is a very special homecoming for all of us," he admitted.

Dilpreet, the youngest from the academy, had his own vocal support group of kids from his village in Batala, holding up his posters.

"My parents keep asking me when is the tournament beginning, when can we come; they even want to come and watch me in training sessions," said Dilpreet.

Goalkeeper Krishan Pathak and Jarmanpreet Singh are the other two from the academy. The one common factor in their narratives is the importance of heroes and watching them live on the domestic circuit, and the importance of domestic events themselves.

"I watched Jugraj Singh play for Punjab Police here," Harmanpreet gushed.

"I was inspired by watching Sardar and Sandeep Singh during domestic competitions," Mandeep added.

India, meanwhile, will take on China in its second game of the tournament while Malaysia takes on Korea and Bangladesh plays Japan on Thursday.





CREIMAS/BCCI

Terrific Threesome — redefining the slam-bang manual

India are blessed to have four equally aggressive and proven options to pick from to open the batting should it come to that. Abhishek, Samson, Sooryavanshi and Kishan are each more than a handful on his own; throw three, or even all four (like at the Asian Games) in the mix, and you can't help but feel for the already beleaguered bowling community

R. Kaushik

If cricket is a game of glorious uncertainties, then its 20-over variant is even more so. It's no secret that the shorter the format, the more of a level-playing field it is, which is why 'upsets' are more commonplace in T20 cricket than in 50-over games or matches of longer durations.

One of the almost iron-clad certainties, even in the slam-bang version, is that if Abhishek Sharma plays a minimum of 10 deliveries, at least one six, if not more, is guaranteed. So complete is his command over his craft that he has established himself as the most valuable property in this format, wreaking such unimaginable havoc that oftentimes, opposition bowlers desperately wish for the earth to open up and gobble them up.

Tuesday at Wellington's Hnry Stadium is the latest instance of the left-hander from Punjab snatching the game away from the opposition in the small matter of a half-hour. Trailing 0-2 in the five-match and perhaps aware that they had left at least 25 runs back in the changing room, New Zealand targeted early success to keep themselves in the hunt after posting 198. As it turned out, with no little help from the precocious, precious Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, Abhishek made it decidedly a no-contest, raining fours and sixes with such stunning regularity that Mitchell Santner and his charges had nowhere to hide.

The vicissitudes of sport

No one has experienced the vicissitudes of sport, and specifically the T20 game, more than Abhishek – perhaps with the exception of his regular opening partner, Sanju Samson. He began 2026 in a blaze of glory with two half-centuries against the Kiwis at home, but each of those was succeeded by a first-ball blob. Then came the cruellest of cuts as India began their hunt to defend the T20 World Cup crown worn in Bridgetown in June 2024.

Abhishek was expected to set the tone for India's dominance, but he made the most wretched of starts to his World Cup career. In the opener against United States in Mumbai, he was dismissed off the first ball of the contest, caught at deep cover. It was an unfortunate dismissal in the sense that he picked out the admittedly strategically placed fielder with unerring accuracy as he opened his shoulders and creamed a full, wide ball from paceman Ali Khan, looking to make his trademark opening statement with a signature six.

It happens, we all said, especially given the willingness with which Abhishek embraces risk. But it happened again, in his next match against Pakistan in Colombo (he missed the game against Namibia in Delhi after being hospitalised with a stomach infection). And in the fixture that followed, against Netherlands in Ahmedabad. Three ducks on the bounce, the last two also in the first over against off-spinners Salman Agha and Aryan Dutt respectively, suggested a pattern which compelled India to split their all-left opening combination of Abhishek and Ishan Kishan by bringing Samson into the equation.

Abhishek salvaged a most modest tournament with an authoritative half-century in the final against New Zealand, feeding off the show of confidence from the think-tank which didn't so much as contemplate leaving him out despite 0, 0, 0 and 15 in his first four hits. His stunning early assault, with the by-now flowing Samson, sparked a first-wicket stand of 98 in a mere 43 deliveries, the foundation from which India closed out a commanding 96-run victory to retain their title in grand style in front of nearly 100,000 unashamedly partisan spectators at the Narendra Modi Stadium.

Thriving off his heroics in the final, Abhishek slipped back into his usual destructive mode thereafter, one of the few bright spots when India lost 0-6 to Ireland and England combined in June-July. A trough in Zimbabwe - 11 runs in three innings - was no more than a temporary blip. Upon return home, he smashed 108 off 34 balls against Afghanistan in Delhi, 61 (28b) in the Asian Games final against Pakistan in Nisshin and 69 (30b) against West Indies in Indore.

Frenzied starts

In New Zealand, he had got the team off to much-needed frenzied starts in the first two games, with 29 off 12 and 27 off 21 in stiff run-chases. Which brought us to the Hnry Stadium, where India were confronted with a target of 199 to take an unbeatable 3-0 lead.

For much of Abhishek's post-World Cup run, his partner in crime was Samson. On and off, the latter made way to accommodate Sooryavanshi, most notably in Zimbabwe where the wicketkeeper from Keralam didn't even figure in the extended squad after a run of modest scores following his Player-of-the-Tournament heroics in the World Cup.

For long, Samson has been one of the great enigmas of Indian cricket. When he is on song, he bats like a dream, making that vocation look ridiculously easy and straightforward. But then, he also lapses into frustrating inconsistency, which is what opened the door in the first place for Kishan's reintegration with international cricket. Overlooked for the early part of the World Cup (except in Delhi in Abhishek's unavailability), Samson was brought back in Chennai to offer a right-handed point of difference at the top of the tree, and responded with successive scores of 24, 97 not out, 89 and 89 (the last three in the knockouts) to become the toast of the nation.

Typically Samson-like, he followed that up with 5, 0 and 1 to make way for Sooryavanshi midway through the England series; chastened, he reeled off 57 and 50 in consecutive knocks against Afghanistan, then embarked on a string of 9, 7, 2 and 11 to ensure that he reprised a pattern that has been his constant companion all his career.

Why then would he not make half-centuries in three of his next five knocks? He wouldn't be Samson otherwise, would he?

Abhishek's mostly-off, now-on travails and Samson's blow-hot blow-cold figures could paint the picture of the lack of substantial starts and early pressure on the incoming No. 3, mostly Kishan, and while there might be some truth to how that picture takes shape, the reality is also starkly surprising. The 26-year-old stylist from Amritsar and the 31-year-old purist from Thiruvananthapuram have been involved in five stands in excess of 50 in the 25 innings in which they have opened together this calendar year, equalling an Indian record held hitherto by K.L. Rahul and Rohit Sharma (in 2021) and by Abhishek himself and his good mate Shubman Gill (in 2025) when the latter made a brief if largely unsuccessful return to 20-over internationals.

Two to tango

Abhishek and Samson complement each other superbly; there is no competition, healthy or otherwise, no subconscious duel of one-upmanship, no trying to outdo each other. Both are comfortable in their respective skins, instinctively holding back when they sense that their partner is firing on all cylinders, and quickly taking over the lead role if the other is a little off-key. It helps that one is a left-hander and the other bats right-handed, because it then becomes practically impossible for the bowling group to line a particular type of batter up.

They target different areas of the ground - Abhishek's on-side play has come on by leaps and bounds and his pick-up shot is a joy to behold even if it can sometimes be his kryptonite too - and hit different strokes to balls of the same length, driving the opposition ragged with their dominance, their chutzpah and their fearlessness, for which loads of credit must also be placed at the doorstep of successive leadership groups.

On Tuesday, Samson was pushed down to No. 3 so that Sooryavanshi, the boy wonder, could return to his preferred opening slot. In Christchurch on Saturday when Kishan was unavailable with an adductor injury, the lad from Bihar had batted at No. 3 and evidently struggled, piecing together an unconvincing four off eight deliveries. That was understandable, considering it was his first competitive outing for three weeks, since the Asian Games final on October 3.

Orchestrating the swap

Quickly realising that Samson's greater experience could allow them to split up the successful opening combination by slotting him at one-drop and thrusting Sooryavanshi to his comfort zone, Shreyas Iyer and Gautam Gambhir orchestrated the swap that resulted in the highest ever PowerPlay score (118) in T20I history.

Sooryavanshi hammered four fours and as many sixes in a 19-ball 45, almost holding his own as his senior partner, Abhishek, tore into the bowling. That being said, it was Sooryavanshi who fired the first shots across the bows, hammering the first ball of the chase, from Jacob Duffy, over mid-on for four and clattering the third legal delivery of the innings over and behind point for a towering six. New Zealand ran into a revolving door; they were battered for 50 in just 2.2 overs, the fastest team fifty in all T20Is.

Huge accomplishment

Abhishek brought up his half-century in 15 deliveries, and took another 20 balls for his second fifty. His 11th century meant he left the great Virat Kohli behind and became the Indian with the most 20-over hundreds; it was also his fourth T20I ton, a monumental accomplishment considering he has played just 69 innings.

Just to put things in perspective, Rohit Sharma (who holds the record for the most T20I hundreds alongside Glenn Maxwell), finished with five centuries from 151 hits, while Suryakumar Yadav, with whom Abhishek drew abreast, batted 107 times though that is offset by the fact that he didn't always occupy the top three slots. In all T20s, only Chris Gayle (22) and Babar Azam (13) have more three-figure knocks than the rangy left-hander. With time, opportunity and ambition on his side, Abhishek won't be playing second fiddle to many of these worthies for a long time.

India are blessed to have four equally aggressive and proven options to pick from to open the batting should it come to that. Abhishek, Samson, Sooryavanshi and Kishan are each more than a handful on his own; throw three, or even all four (like at the Asian Games) in the mix, and you can't help but feel for the already beleaguered bowling community.

As a popular catchline for a television brand goes: Neighbour's Envy, Owner's Pride.

THE GIST

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